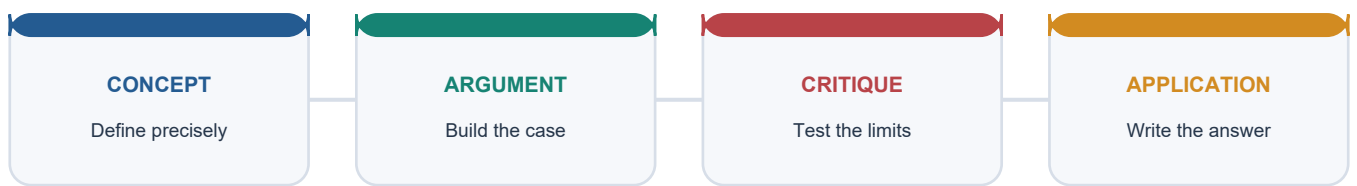


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Yoga - Complete Learning Session

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Yoga - Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper I - Indian Philosophy · Syllabus item 17. **Official syllabus wording (verbatim, printed spelling retained):** Yoga; Citta; Cittavṛtti; Klesas; Samadhi; Kaivalya. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads; the accurate Sanskrit term in IAST follows immediately in brackets. **Evidence discipline:** doctrine, textual attribution and previous-year wording follow the repository's canonical owners. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never presented as official keys.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Teaching sessions in the Basic block	17
Core diagnostic multiple-choice questions	24
Remedial diagnostic multiple-choice questions	8
Total diagnostics	32
Solved previous-year questions	8 (7 primary-owned + 1 routed)
Original solved Mains models	6 (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20)
Consolidated register parts	17 (A-Q)

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

How this Basic block is organised

The seventeen sessions below run in teaching order, not in source order. Each session opens with a definition, gives a gateway idea in plain language, shows the concept before it argues it, then supplies the named evidence, the answer-grabbing line, the must-write keywords, a worked answer-paragraph model, the exam route, the traps and a rapid revision strip.

Everything needed for a complete 10-, 15- or 20-mark answer on any routed question is inside this Basic block. The Optional Advanced block near the end of this document is enrichment; no core answer depends on it.

Yoga is the one Paper I school whose syllabus clause is a list of five technical nouns - mind-field, mental modification, afflictions, absorption and isolation. The sessions therefore move along the system's own causal spine: first what the mind is, then how it moves, then why its movement binds, then how the binding is dismantled, then what remains when it is gone.

Session	What it settles	Why it comes here
1	The definition of Yoga (yogaś-citta-vṛtti-nirodhaḥ) and the Sāṃkhya inheritance	Fixes what the word names before any doctrine is argued
2	Textual identity: Patañjali, Vyāsa, the four chapters (pāda) and source control	Separates sūtra claims from commentarial elaboration
3	The mind-field (citta): constitution and material basis	Introduces the first syllabus noun
4	Reflection, borrowed consciousness and misidentification	Explains how an insentient mind can seem to be a self
5	The five levels of the mind-field (citta-bhūmi)	The applied taxonomy the 2019 paper tested
6	Mental modification (citta-vṛtti): the five kinds and the afflicted/unafflicted division	The second syllabus noun
7	Why restraint is prescribed; the three instruments of knowledge and yogic perception	Answers the "why" half of the 2023 question

Session	What it settles	Why it comes here
8	Sustained practice (abhyāsa) and dispassion (vairāgya)	The two-handed method that makes restraint possible
9	Real transformation of the mind-substrate (citta-pariṇāma)	Shows why graded practice needs a persisting mind
10	The five afflictions (kleśa) and their four states	The third syllabus noun
11	Action, deposit, fruition, impression, and preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga)	The causal engine the 2021 question asks to dismantle
12	The eight-limbed discipline (aṣṭāṅga-yoga), combined discipline and the nine obstacles	The practical architecture linking affliction to absorption
13	Meditative absorption (samādhi): the two classifications that must not be conflated	The fourth syllabus noun, and the 2020/2022 core
14	Truth-bearing insight, seedless absorption, powers and the cloud of dharma	The upper reaches of absorption and their traps
15	The Lord (Īśvara): special witness, sacred syllable and a limited theism	What makes Yoga <i>seśvara</i> -Sāṃkhya, and the 2025 core
16	Isolation (kaivalya): discriminative knowledge, involution and self-abidance	The fifth syllabus noun and the school's terminus
17	The realist polemic, inter-school debates, criticisms and the graded verdict	The evaluative close every high-mark answer needs

SESSION 1 - WHAT YOGA ACTUALLY IS: RESTRAINT OF MENTAL MODIFICATION AND THE SĀMḲHYA INHERITANCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Yoga, in Patañjali's system, is not a posture practice, not a fitness regime and not a merger of the soul with God. It is the disciplined stopping of the mind's continuous churning, undertaken so that the pure consciousness that was watching all along stops mistaking that churning for itself.

Technical definition. Classical Yoga is defined as the restraint of the modifications of the mind-field (**yogaś-citta-vṛtti-nirodhaḥ**), with the immediate consequence that the seer then abides in its own nature (**tadā draṣṭuḥ svarūpe'vasthānam**). It is described in the tradition as Sāṃkhya-exposition (**sāṃkhya-pravacana**) or theistic Sāṃkhya (**seśvara-sāṃkhya**): it accepts the dualism of conscious witness (**puruṣa**) and primordial material nature (**prakṛti**) and the standard twenty-five principles (**tattva**), and adds a graded practical soteriology together with a special conscious witness, the Lord (**Īśvara**).

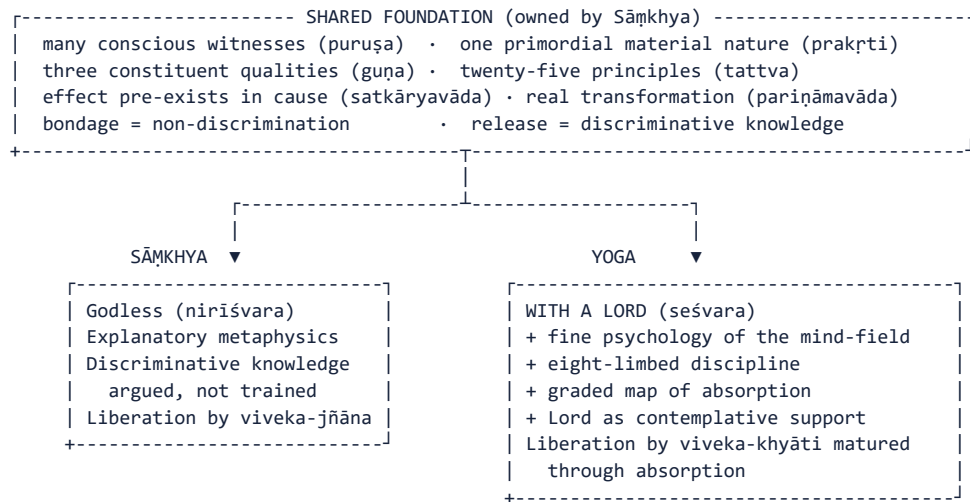
SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Imagine a lamp standing behind a rotating cut-glass drum. The lamp does not move, does not heat up and does not change colour. But the drum spins, and its facets throw moving coloured patterns on the wall. If you watched only the wall you would swear the *lamp* was dancing.

Yoga's whole diagnosis is in that image. The lamp is consciousness; the drum is the mind; the moving patterns are the mind's modifications. The mistake is not that the patterns exist. The mistake is the sentence "I am the pattern." Stop the drum, and the sentence has nothing left to attach to - the lamp is seen simply as the lamp.

This is why the school's opening definition is negative in form and positive in intent. "Restraint" sounds like suppression, but its purpose is disclosure: nothing is created, nothing is destroyed, and one persistent misreading is ended.

VISUAL - WHAT SĀṂKHYA GIVES AND WHAT YOGA ADDS



ONE-LINE VERDICT -> Sāṁkhya supplies the map; Yoga supplies the training that makes a traveller able to read it.

What the diagram shows: the two schools do not disagree about what exists. They differ over whether the decisive knowledge can be reached by argument alone, and over whether a special witness may be admitted as an aid.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- The definition is a definition of a state, not of an activity.** Yoga names the condition in which the mind's modifications have been restrained. Postures, breath-work and ethical vows are *means* that produce that condition; none of them is the definition. This is the single most examinable sentence in the topic, and the one candidates most often replace with a wellness paraphrase.
- The second half of the definition supplies the payoff.** Restraint would be pointless quietism if nothing followed from it. Patañjali immediately adds that the seer then abides in its own nature. So restraint is *revelatory*: it removes an overlay, it does not manufacture a new state of the self.
- What happens otherwise is stated with equal precision.** When restraint is absent, the seer takes the form of the modifications - that is, consciousness appears to be whatever the mind is currently doing. Bondage in Yoga is therefore a cognitive-phenomenological condition, not a physical chaining of an immaterial thing.
- The metaphysics is borrowed, deliberately and openly.** Yoga does not construct a rival cosmology. It accepts the two ultimates and the twenty-five principles and restates only as much of them as its psychology requires. The examiner's implicit test is whether you can distinguish what Yoga *owns* from what it *inherits*.
- What Yoga owns is the psychology and the method.** The mind-field, the five modifications, the afflicted/unafflicted division, practice and dispassion, the five afflictions, the moral causation of action, the eight limbs, the absorption taxonomies, combined discipline, the Lord, discriminative knowledge, the cloud-of-dharma absorption and isolation are Yoga's own subject matter.
- What is inherited stays labelled as inherited.** Primordial material nature, the conscious witness, the qualities, the twenty-five principles and real transformation are Sāṁkhya's. Yoga uses them; it does not re-prove them, and an answer that spends its length re-proving them has answered the wrong syllabus item.
- The addition of a Lord is the school's public signature.** Sāṁkhya in its classical form is Godless. Yoga admits a special conscious witness untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit. That single admission is why the tradition calls Yoga *śeśvara-sāṁkhya*, and why every comparison question between the two schools ends here.

Qualification to keep. "Theistic Sāṁkhya" is an accurate label but a limited one. Yoga's Lord is not the material cause of the world, is not presented in the sūtras as a creator in the Nyāya manner, and does not bestow isolation from outside. The theism is real but bounded, and the boundary is exactly what the 2025 question rewards.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.2** - the definition: Yoga is the restraint of the modifications of the mind-field.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.3** - then the seer abides in its own nature.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.4** - otherwise the seer takes the form of the modifications.
- **The traditional titles sāmkhya-pravacana and seśvara-sāmkhya*** - the tradition's own statement of the relationship between the two schools.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.24** - the Lord as a special conscious witness untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yoga does not add a new world to Sāmkhya's world; it adds a discipline to Sāmkhya's argument - which is why its definition is a psychological state and not a metaphysical thesis.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **restraint of mental modification (citta-vṛtti-nirodha)**
- **the seer abides in its own nature (svarūpe'vasthānam)**
- **the seer takes the form of the modifications (vṛtti-sārūpyam)**
- **Sāmkhya-exposition (sāmkhya-pravacana)**
- **theistic Sāmkhya (seśvara-sāmkhya)**
- **Godless Sāmkhya (nirīśvara-sāmkhya)**
- **special conscious witness (puruṣa-viśeṣa)**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Yoga's originality lies not in what it says exists, but in what it says must be done about it.

Named evidence. Its defining aphorism restrains the modifications of the mind-field, its second aphorism restores the seer to its own nature, and its fourth states the alternative - the seer taking the form of the modifications - while its ontology is the inherited Sāmkhya scheme of many conscious witnesses, one primordial material nature and twenty-five principles.

Analysis. Because the two ultimates are already fixed by the inherited scheme, the only work left for Yoga is the work of correction, and correction of a persistent misreading requires training rather than proof. That is precisely why the school's central term is a discipline word, *nirodha*, and why its texts are organised around practice rather than around cosmological derivation.

Qualification. The inheritance is not total. Yoga's admission of a Lord marks a genuine doctrinal difference from classical Sāmkhya, but it is a bounded difference: the Lord functions as an unequalled support for concentration and an obstacle-remover, not as material cause or as the external giver of release.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

This session supplies the opening move for every routed Yoga question. It is directly load-bearing for **2024 Q7(b)**, whose quoted statement is a paraphrase of the seer-takes-the-form aphorism, and for **2025 Q7(b)**, which cannot be answered without the *seśvara* framing. It is also the correct first paragraph for **2023 Q7(c)**, where the definition must be stated before the modifications are listed.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** define Yoga as union with God. Patañjali defines it as restraint of the mind's modifications; the "union" gloss belongs to devotional and later usage.
- Do **not** write that Yoga rejects Sāmkhya. It accepts Sāmkhya's ontology and supplies what Sāmkhya lacks.
- Do **not** treat posture as the definition or the goal. It is one limb of eight, and the eight

limbs are a means to the defined state.

- Do **not** present the Lord as the difference that changes the metaphysics. The metaphysics stays dualist; the difference changes the *resources of the path*.

RAPID REVISION

- Definition: restraint of the modifications of the mind-field -> seer abides in its own nature.
- Otherwise: the seer takes the form of the modifications - that is bondage.
- Ontology inherited from Sāṃkhya; psychology, method and Lord are Yoga's own.
- Labels: *sāṃkhya-pravacana*, *śeśvara-sāṃkhya* against Sāṃkhya's *nirīśvara*.
- One line: *Yoga is Sāṃkhya made trainable, and only secondarily made theistic*.

SESSION 2 - TEXTUAL IDENTITY: PATAÑJALI, VYĀSA, THE FOUR CHAPTERS AND SOURCE CONTROL

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Before you can quote Yoga you have to know who said what. The system's base text is a set of short aphorisms; almost everything else that gets attributed to "Yoga" in an exam hall is actually commentary, and mixing the two is the fastest way to lose marks on a source-sensitive question.

Technical definition. Classical Yoga is the Pātañjala system set out in the *Yoga-sūtra*, read in the tradition with Vyāsa's *Yoga-bhāṣya* and, later, with Vācaspati Miśra's *Tattvavaiśārādī* and Vijñānabhikṣu's *Yogavārttika*. The *Yoga-sūtra* is organised in four chapters (**pāda**): absorption (**samādhi-pāda**), practice (**sādhana-pāda**), powers (**vibhūti-pāda**) and isolation (**kaivalya-pāda**).

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Think of the *Yoga-sūtra* as a set of headings and the commentaries as the paragraphs written under them. The headings are extremely compressed - often three or four words - and were never meant to be read alone. So when a textbook says "Yoga classifies the mind into five levels," the honest sentence is: *the classical commentarial exposition beginning with Vyāsa classifies the mind into five levels, and the classification is standard*.

That is not pedantry, and it is not a reason to avoid the fivefold list. It is the difference between a candidate who says "Patañjali lists five mind-levels" - which is false - and a candidate who says "the classical exposition, standard from Vyāsa onward, distributes the mind into five levels" - which is true, and which signals source control to the examiner.

VISUAL - THE FOUR CHAPTERS AND WHAT EACH ONE OWNS

PATAÑJALI · YOGA-SŪTRA

|

+-- 1. ABSORPTION CHAPTER (samādhi-pāda)
| definition of Yoga · the five modifications · practice and dispassion
| the Lord and the sacred syllable · object-supported absorption
| coalescence-varieties · truth-bearing insight · seedless absorption
| -- owner emphasis: the mind and its absorption --
|

+-- 2. PRACTICE CHAPTER (sādhana-pāda)
| preparatory discipline · the five afflictions and their four states
| action, deposit and fruition · the seen and the seer · the eight limbs
| -- owner emphasis: causal therapy and practice --
|

+-- 3. POWERS CHAPTER (vibhūti-pāda)
| concentration + meditation + absorption = combined discipline
| the three transformations of the mind · extraordinary capacities
| capacities as obstacles when appropriated
| -- owner emphasis: advanced contemplative application --
|

+-- 4. ISOLATION CHAPTER (kaivalya-pāda)
| realism about mind and object · latent tendencies · discriminative knowledge
| cloud-of-dharma absorption · involution of the qualities · isolation
| -- owner emphasis: final metaphysics and liberation --

COMMENTARIAL LAYER -> Vyāsa (Yoga-bhāṣya) · Vācaspati Miśra (Tattvavaiśārādī)
· Vijñānabhikṣu (Yogavārttika)

RULE OF USE -> cite the layer you are actually using; never promote commentary
into the sūtra text, and never demote a sūtra into "later tradition".

What the diagram shows: each chapter has a distinct centre of gravity, so a question's vocabulary usually tells you which chapter you are being examined on.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **Patañjali is the traditional systematiser, not the inventor of the practices.** The aphorisms collect, order and define; they do not claim to originate meditation, restraint or dispassion.
2. **Vyāsa's commentary is the classical interpretive baseline.** When later expositors disagree, they disagree within the space Vyāsa opened. For UPSC this means Vyāsa-derived material is safe to use - provided it is named as commentarial when the question is source-sensitive.
3. **The four-chapter division is itself examinable orientation.** A question about the difference between object-supported and objectless absorption is a first-chapter question; a question about afflictions and the eight limbs is a second-chapter question; a question about extraordinary capacities is a third-chapter question; a question about the mind-object realism, discriminative knowledge and isolation is a fourth-chapter question.
4. **The chronology of the text and its commentaries is genuinely disputed.** The layering, dating and even the unity of the sūtra collection are scholarly questions. The correct exam behaviour is to identify the received system confidently and to build nothing on a contested date.
5. **The most frequently mis-sourced item is the five mind-levels.** They are standard in the commentarial exposition and completely usable - including for the 2019 applied question - but they are not a five-item aphorism of Patañjali, and a candidate who claims they are has handed the examiner an error.
6. **The second most frequently mis-sourced item is the four-stage analysis of lower dispassion.** The effort-toward-control, separation, single-residual-desire and mastery sequence is commentarial elaboration; Patañjali's own concise statement of lower dispassion is mastery over thirst for seen and heard-of objects.
7. **The third is the later theoretical proof-set for the Lord.** Arguments from scripture, from maximal degrees of knowledge and power, and from the need for intelligent coordination belong to later Yoga commentators. Patañjali's own grounds are compact and practice-facing.

Qualification to keep. Source control is not scepticism. Nothing in the commentarial layer is being rejected here; it is being *labelled*. The examiner rewards a candidate who can use the full tradition and still say which part of it is speaking.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra*** - the base text, in four chapters.
- **Vyāsa, Yoga-bhāṣya*** - the classical commentary that fixes the standard reading.
- **Vācaspati Miśra, Tattvavaiśārādī*** - sub-commentary on Vyāsa.
- **Vijñānabhikṣu, Yogavārttika*** - later synthesising commentary.
- **The four chapter-names** - absorption, practice, powers and isolation.
- **The commentarial status of the five mind-levels and of the four stages of lower dispassion.**

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The *Yoga-sūtra* is a text of headings, and the tradition that reads it is a text of paragraphs; a Yoga answer earns its authority by never confusing the two.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- aphorism collection (sūtra)
- chapter (pāda)
- absorption chapter (samādhi-pāda)
- practice chapter (sādhana-pāda)
- powers chapter (vibhūti-pāda)
- isolation chapter (kaivalya-pāda)
- commentary (bhāṣya)
- received Pātañjala system

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The Pātañjala system must be presented as a text plus a reading tradition, because several of its most examinable classifications live in the reading tradition rather than in the text.

Named evidence. The *Yoga-sūtra*'s four chapters distribute the doctrine - absorption, practice, powers, isolation - while Vyāsa's *Yoga-bhāṣya*, Vācaspati Miśra's *Tattvavaiśārādī* and Vijñānabhikṣu's *Yogavārttika* supply the fivefold mind-level scheme, the four-stage analysis of lower dispassion and the fuller theoretical grounds for the Lord.

Analysis. Because the aphorisms are compressed to the point of unintelligibility in isolation, the commentary is not optional decoration but the operative form in which the system is actually taught; the discipline required is therefore attribution, not avoidance. An answer that uses the mind-levels while naming them as commentarial exposition is both complete and accurate, whereas one that ascribes them to Patañjali is complete and wrong.

Qualification. The historical layering and dating of the text-and-commentary tradition remain genuinely disputed, so the safe move is to identify the received system and to avoid resting any argument on a chronological claim.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

No printed question asks for the textual map directly, but it protects **2019 Q7(b)**, where the mind-levels must be used and correctly attributed, and **2025 Q7(b)**, where the compact Patañjala grounds for the Lord must not be inflated into later creator-arguments. It also supplies the one-line source caution that lifts an otherwise ordinary **2022 Q5(c)** answer.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** attribute the five mind-levels to Patañjali as a sūtra list.
- Do **not** attribute the later theoretical proofs of the Lord to Patañjali.
- Do **not** import later postural manuals into the Pātañjala account; they belong to a different textual stream.

- Do **not** build an argument on the date of the *Yoga-sūtra* or of the *Bhāṣya*.

RAPID REVISION

- Base text: *Yoga-sūtra*, four chapters - absorption, practice, powers, isolation.
- Reading tradition: Vyāsa -> Vācaspati Miśra -> Vijñānabhikṣu.
- Commentarial, not sūtra: the five mind-levels; the four stages of lower dispassion; the expanded proof-set for the Lord.
- Dating and layering are contested; identify, do not date.
- One line: *use the whole tradition, but always name the layer you are quoting.*

SESSION 3 - THE MIND-FIELD (CITTA): CONSTITUTION AND MATERIAL BASIS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. The mind-field is everything that thinks, decides, remembers, feels and says "I" - taken as one working apparatus rather than as three separate faculties. In Yoga it is made of matter, in a very subtle form, and it is not the self.

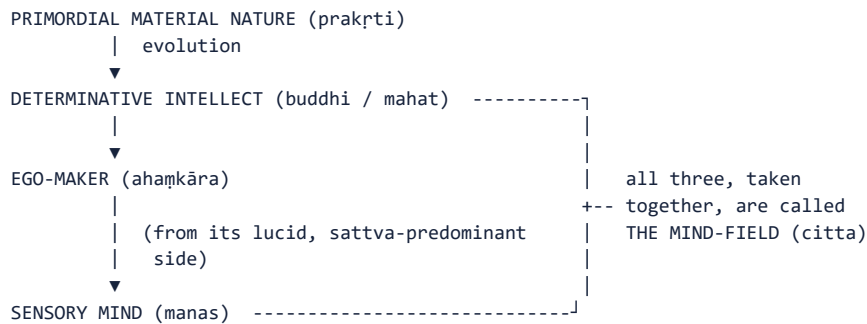
Technical definition. The mind-field (**citta**) is the internal organ or mind-complex through which cognition, affect, volition and meditative discipline become possible. In Yoga it is not the sensory mind (**manas**) in isolation but the unified internal apparatus comprising determinative intellect (**buddhi**), ego-maker (**ahaṁkāra**) and sensory mind (**manas**). It is a product of primordial material nature and is therefore insentient (**jaḍa**), though as a functioning whole it is predominantly of the lucid quality (**sattva**), which explains its transparency.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Sāṃkhya, being a taxonomist, separates three inner instruments and gives each a job: intellect decides, ego appropriates, mind coordinates. Yoga, being a therapist, mostly stops separating them - because the patient does not experience three faculties. The patient experiences one restless interior.

That is the entire reason for the term. Bondage does not happen to your intellect while your ego looks on; liberation does not free your sensory mind while your intellect stays trapped. The disease and the cure both concern the whole interior, so Yoga gives the whole interior one name.

VISUAL - THE MIND-FIELD AS ONE APPARATUS WITH THREE FUNCTIONS



COMPONENT	PRIMARY ROLE	WHY YOGA FILES IT UNDER citta
intellect (buddhi)	ascertainment, decision	discrimination and resolve happen here
ego-maker (ahaṃkāra)	appropriation as "I"	ownership, doership and identification arise here
sensory mind (manas)	co-ordination, doubt, oscillation	sense-data is received and arranged here

PRECISION POINT -> only the sensory mind arises *directly* from the lucid side of the ego-maker. The mind-field as a functioning whole is sattva-predominant, but that is a statement about the whole, not a derivation of all three components from sattva-ahamkāra.

What the diagram shows: a derivation order on the left, a functional division in the table, and one precision point that separates a correct answer from a plausible-sounding wrong one.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The mind-field is material, in the subtle sense.** It is an evolute of primordial material nature. Nothing about it is intrinsically conscious. This is not a concession Yoga makes reluctantly; it is the premise that makes the whole reflection theory necessary.

2. **It is one apparatus with three functions.** Sāṃkhya's analytic separation is retained as analysis, but Yoga's operative unit is the composite. That is why the school can speak of "restraining the mind-field" as a single project.

3. **Its transparency is explained by the lucid quality.** Because the composite is sattva-predominant, it is subtle and clear enough to take the form of what it attends to and to mirror consciousness. A tamas-heavy instrument could do neither.

4. **The derivation must be stated exactly.** Intellect evolves first from primordial nature; the ego-maker evolves from intellect; the sensory mind evolves from the lucid side of the ego-maker. It is therefore wrong to say that intellect, ego and mind *all* arise directly from sattva-predominant ego-maker. This is a favourite close-option trap.

5. **The mind-field is not the sensory mind of Nyāya.** In Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika the internal sense is atomic, partless and instrumental, and the self is a separate substance to which cognition belongs as a quality. Yoga's mind-field is broad, composite, transformable and karmically loaded.

6. **The mind-field is not the inner instrument of Advaita either.** Advaita's inner instrument operates under beginningless ignorance within a non-dual Brahman framework. Yoga's operates within a plural-witness dualism with no Brahman doctrine at all.

7. **Because bondage runs through the mind-field, so must release.** One cannot free the witness by modifying the witness, which is eternally free and unmodifiable. The only available surface for work is the instrument. That is why Yoga is, in its own self-description, a therapy of attention, habit, impression and misidentification.

Qualification to keep. Saying the mind-field is "insentient" is a technical claim about its intrinsic nature, not a denial that mental life is luminous. It is luminous - but by reflection, and the next session is entirely about what that means.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **The threefold constitution** - determinative intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind functioning as one field.
- **The evolutionary order** - nature -> intellect -> ego-maker -> sensory mind from the lucid side of the ego-maker.
- **The lucid-quality explanation of transparency** - the composite is sattva-predominant.
- **The inter-school contrast table** - Sāṃkhya's analytic separation, Nyāya's atomic internal sense, Advaita's inner instrument under ignorance.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yoga's decision to gather intellect, ego and sense-mind under a single name is not terminological convenience; it is a claim that bondage is suffered by the whole interior and therefore cannot be cured faculty by faculty.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- mind-field (citta)
- determinative intellect (buddhi)
- ego-maker (ahaṃkāra)
- sensory mind (manas)
- insentient (jaḍa)
- lucid quality predominance (sattva-pradhāna)
- psychical instrument of experience

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. In Yoga the mind is a single material instrument, and this description is doing soteriological work rather than merely descriptive work.

Named evidence. The mind-field is the unified internal apparatus of determinative intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind; it is a product of primordial material nature and therefore insentient; and it is predominantly of the lucid quality, which is what makes it transparent enough to take the form of objects and to mirror consciousness.

Analysis. If the instrument were partly conscious in its own right, the school could not explain liberation as a correction of misattribution, because there would then be a genuine conscious subject inside nature whose bondage would be real rather than reflected. Making the instrument wholly insentient forces the entire explanatory burden onto the relation of reflection - and it is that relation, not any faculty, which the discipline is designed to interrupt.

Qualification. The composite claim must be stated with the correct derivation, since only the sensory mind arises directly from the lucid side of the ego-maker; the sattva-predominance is a property of the working whole and not a derivation of each component.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

This is the first substantive paragraph of **2023 Q7(c)** ("Explain Citta and its modifications") and the necessary preliminary of **2024 Q7(b)**, whose quoted sentence presupposes that the mind both changes and reflects. It also supplies the classification base for **2019 Q7(b)**.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** equate the mind-field with the sensory mind alone. That is the Nyāya internal sense, not Yoga's mind-field.
- Do **not** derive all three components directly from sattva-predominant ego-maker.
- Do **not** call the mind-field conscious. It is transparent, not luminous in its own right.

- Do **not** import Advaita's inner instrument under ignorance; Yoga has no Brahman framework.

RAPID REVISION

- Mind-field = intellect + ego-maker + sensory mind as one working apparatus.
- Material, insentient, sattva-predominant, therefore transparent.
- Derivation: nature -> intellect -> ego-maker -> sensory mind (from the lucid side).
- Broader than Nyāya's atomic internal sense; not Advaita's inner instrument under ignorance.
- One line: *bondage is suffered by the whole interior, so the whole interior gets one name.*

SESSION 4 - REFLECTION, BORROWED CONSCIOUSNESS AND MISIDENTIFICATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. The mind is not conscious, and the self does not act. Yet experience feels like a single conscious actor. Yoga explains the appearance by saying that the mind *mirrors* consciousness - and that the whole of bondage consists in mistaking the mirror-image for the original.

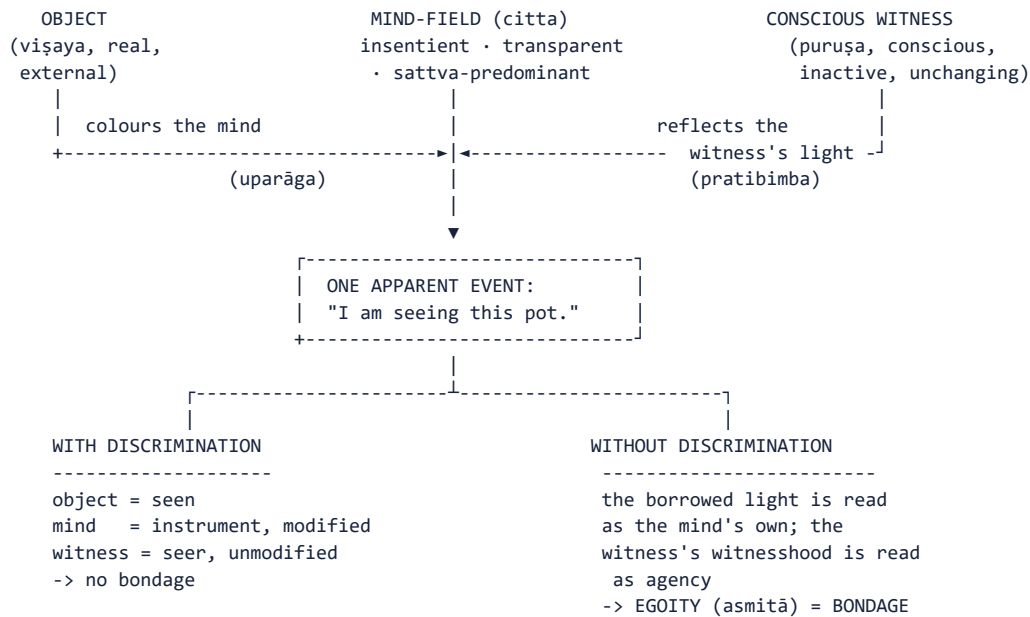
Technical definition. Yoga's reflection theory (**pratibimba**; also **chāyā**, shadow-image) holds that the mind-field appears conscious because it stands in proximity to the conscious witness, while the conscious witness appears bound because its light is reflected in the mind-field. The resulting confusion is egoity (**asmitā**) - described as the conflation of the power of the seer with the power of the instrument of seeing (**sva-svāmi-śakti**) - and the relation itself is mere proximity (**sannidhi-mātra**), involving no change in the witness.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Put a clear quartz crystal next to a red flower. The crystal looks red. Nothing has happened to the flower, and nothing chemical has happened to the crystal; the redness is a fact about how a transparent thing behaves next to a coloured one.

Now run the analogy twice, because Yoga does. The mind takes the *colour of objects* - that is cognition. The mind also takes the *light of the witness* - that is the feeling of being someone. Both are borrowings. And the second borrowing is the dangerous one, because when a borrowed light is mistaken for an owned light, the borrower starts saying "I know, I suffer, I want" - and the lender, who never moved, appears to be in trouble.

VISUAL - THE DOUBLE BORROWING AND WHERE THE MISTAKE ENTERS



THE PROTECTED CLAIM -> the transformation is entirely on the mind's side. The witness neither acts nor changes. The relation is mere proximity (sannidhi-mātra), not causal contact between two things.

What the diagram shows: two distinct borrowings converge into one apparent event, and the entire difference between bondage and freedom is whether that event is correctly analysed.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- The witness cannot literally be affected.** It is unchanging (*aparīṇāmin*); therefore it cannot act, suffer, acquire properties or undergo modification. Any theory that lets bondage *really* happen to it has already contradicted the school's definition of it.
- The mind cannot be intrinsically luminous.** It is a product of nature and therefore insentient; but its lucid-quality subtlety makes it capable of mirroring. Transparency is a material property; luminosity is not.
- Therefore knowledge cannot be modelled on physical contact.** An inactive consciousness cannot collide with an object the way two bodies collide. Yoga's model is proximity-plus-reflection, and it is chosen precisely because contact models are unavailable to it.
- Bondage is a double misreading, not one.** The mind's borrowed consciousness is misread as selfhood; the witness's mere witnesshood is misread as agency. Both halves are needed to generate the ordinary sense of being an experiencing doer.
- The technical name for this is egoity.** Egoity is the identification of the seer with the instrument of seeing, or of the conscious witness with the intellect. It is an affliction, and Session 10 will place it second in the list of five.
- The soteriological consequence is exact.** Since the witness cannot be changed, the task is not to alter the witness but to end the misattribution - by purifying and restraining the instrument in which the misattribution occurs.
- The standard image is the crystal near the flower.** A second, exam-friendly image is the magnet and iron filings: mere presence explains movement on the iron's side without any action on the magnet's side. Both images do the same protective work - they let something happen without anything happening to the witness.
- The objection is real and must be voiced.** Reflection normally requires some relation between mirror and original. If the two principles are ontologically disjoint, how can the inactive witness be "reflected" at all?
- The reply is mere proximity - and its residual force must be conceded.** Yoga answers that all

the transformation is on the mind's side; the witness neither acts nor changes. But Advaita and Nyāya can still press the classical difficulty of how two radically different principles combine to yield one experience. The honest verdict names the reply *and* the pressure.

Qualification to keep. "Mere proximity" is best described as naming the relation more precisely than it explains it. That is the single most useful evaluative sentence in the entire topic, and it is exactly what a *critically examine* directive is looking for.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **The crystal-and-flower analogy (sphaṭika)** - a transparent thing appears coloured by what is near it.
- **The magnet-and-iron image** - mere presence produces movement without action in the mover.
- **Mere proximity (sannidhi-mātra)** - the technical name of the relation.
- **The seer/instrument conflation (sva-svāmi-śakti)** - the technical description of egoity.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.4** - otherwise the seer takes the form of the modifications.
- **The 2024 examination statement** - that so long as the mind changes, the self is reflected in it and, lacking discriminative knowledge, identifies with those changes.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yoga's reflection theory is designed to let bondage be devastating and unreal at the same time: devastating in experience, because the misreading governs a whole life; unreal in metaphysics, because nothing whatever has happened to the one who seems bound.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- reflection (pratibimba / chāyā)
- mere proximity (sannidhi-mātra)
- colouring by the object (uparāga)
- unchanging (apariṇāmin)
- insentient (jaḍa)
- egoity (asmitā)
- power of the owner and the owned (sva-svāmi-śakti)
- crystal near a flower (sphaṭika)

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Yoga's soteriology stands or falls with its reflection theory, because that theory is the only device by which an unchanging witness can be said to be bound at all.

Named evidence. The mind-field is transparent but insentient and therefore mirrors the witness's light, as a clear crystal takes the colour of a nearby flower; the relation is mere proximity, with all transformation on the mind's side; and the resulting conflation of the seer's power with the instrument's power is named egoity.

Analysis. This lets the school hold two claims that would otherwise be inconsistent - that bondage is experientially total, and that the witness is eternally pure - because bondage is relocated from the witness to a misreading that occurs in the instrument. The therapeutic consequence follows immediately: since the misreading occurs in the instrument, only the instrument can be worked on, which is why the entire eight-limbed discipline addresses conduct, body, breath, sense and attention rather than the self.

Qualification. The reply of mere proximity names the relation more clearly than it explains it, and rival schools press exactly there: Advaita by collapsing the duality, Nyāya by making consciousness an adventitious property of a substantial self. The defensible verdict is that Yoga's phenomenology is strong and its account of the relation remains its exposed flank.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

This session is **2024 Q7(b)**: the quoted statement about the self being reflected in a changing mind and identifying with those changes in the absence of discriminative knowledge is precisely this doctrine, and the demand is an appraisal of Yoga soteriology in its light. It also supplies the "why" of **2023 Q7(c)** and the diagnostic half of **2021 Q6(a)**.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** say the witness is *modified* by reflection. Nothing happens to it.
- Do **not** say the mind is conscious. It is transparent and borrows.
- Do **not** present mere proximity as a full explanation. Concede the residual difficulty.
- Do **not** convert the crystal analogy into a claim that the mind *becomes* the object; it takes the object's form, which is what colouring means.

RAPID REVISION

- Two borrowings: colour from the object; light from the witness.
- Reflection theory protects the witness: all change is on the mind's side.
- Bondage = borrowed light read as owned light + witnesshood read as agency = egoity.
- Images: crystal near a flower; magnet and iron.
- Reply: mere proximity - and it names the relation better than it explains it.
- One line: *the mirror is in trouble; the lamp never was.*

SESSION 5 - THE FIVE LEVELS OF THE MIND-FIELD (CITTA-BHŪMI)

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Minds are not all in the same condition. Yoga sorts them into five working states - scattered, dull, occasionally-focused, one-pointed and fully restrained - and says that only the last two are actually fit for the discipline it teaches.

Technical definition. The levels of the mind-field (**citta-bhūmi**) are the five operative conditions of the mind-complex, classified by the dominance of the constituent qualities: scattered (**kṣipta**, active quality dominant), dull (**mūḍha**, inert quality dominant), distracted (**vikṣipta**, mixed with occasional lucidity), one-pointed (**ekāgra**, lucid quality dominant) and restrained (**niruddha**, all modifications arrested).

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

There is a simple test hidden in this list, and it catches almost every candidate. Ask: is a brilliant research scientist, absorbed in a problem for fourteen hours, in a yogic state?

The intuitive answer is yes - that looks like concentration. The Yoga answer is no. Intensity of attention is not the criterion; *direction and stability of the whole mind* is. A mind can be formidably concentrated and still be outward-turned, ambitious, anxious about results and dependent on its object. That is a mind that flashes lucidity inside a rajas-dominated life. Yoga has a precise name for it, and it is not the name of a yogic state.

VISUAL - THE FIVE LEVELS, THE QUALITY THAT RULES EACH, AND THE FITNESS LINE

LEVEL	QUALITY-PATTERN	CHARACTER	FIT FOR YOGA?
scattered (kṣipta)	active (rajas) dominant	runs object to object; activity without integration	NO - pre-yogic
dull (mūḍha)	inert (tamas) dominant	torpor, delusion, inertia; obscuration, not calm	NO - pre-yogic
distracted (vikṣipta)	mixed, occasional lucidity (sattva)	can attend, infer, analyse and briefly concentrate, but cannot stay collected	NO - only partially prepared
one-pointed (ekāgra)	lucid (sattva) dominant	sustained one-pointedness on a chosen support	YES
restrained (niruddha)	modifications arrested	consummation of disciplined inwardness	YES - culmination

kṣipta --> mūḍha --> vikṣipta $\xrightarrow{\quad}$ ekāgra --> niruddha

THE DECISIVE STEP:
occasional concentration -> sustained one-pointedness

APPLIED READING (2019) -> scientist = vikṣipta · God-realised devotee = ekāgra
· self-realised yogin = niruddha

What the diagram shows: the classification is by ruling quality, not by intelligence; and the decisive transition is the one that ordinary excellence never crosses.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- The classification is qualitative, not quantitative.** It records which constituent quality is ruling the mind, and therefore what the mind is *for* at that moment, not how hard it is working.
- Scattered is activity without integration.** The active quality supplies motion; desire, worry, ambition and sensory dispersion dominate. This is the ordinary agitated mind.
- Dull is obscuration, not peace.** The inert quality supplies torpor, delusion and confusion. It is important to say this explicitly, because a heavy, unmoving mind can be mistaken for a quiet one.
- Distracted is the level that flatters itself.** Lucidity flashes; analysis and even brief concentration are available; but the active and inert qualities are not overcome, so the mind cannot remain inwardly collected. This is the condition of many highly capable worldly persons.
- One-pointed is the first genuinely yoga-fit level.** The lucid quality predominates sufficiently for meditative absorption to deepen on a chosen support.
- Restrained is the culmination, and it is not blankness.** All modifications are arrested. It is the mind-state correlated with the highest absorption and with the approach to isolation.
- Only the last two are fully fit.** The first three are pre-yogic or only partially prepared. The transition from distracted to one-pointed is therefore the decisive step of the entire practical path.
- The 2019 application is exact and must be justified, not asserted.** A scientist intensely focused on an empirical problem, yet directed outward and attached to worldly ends, is best classified as distracted. A God-realised devotee whose mind is one-pointedly centred on the Lord is one-pointed. A self-realised yogin in whom all modifications are stilled is restrained. The subtlety that earns the marks is the first one: *high intellectual focus does not itself amount to yogic restraint.*

Qualification to keep. This fivefold scheme is standard in Vyāsa's commentarial exposition and in the tradition that follows him. It is entirely usable - the 2019 paper used it - but it must not be cited as a five-item aphorism of Patañjali.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **The fivefold list itself** - scattered, dull, distracted, one-pointed, restrained.
- **The quality-assignment** - active quality for the scattered, inert for the dull, mixed with occasional lucidity for the distracted, lucid for the one-pointed.
- **The fitness rule** - only the one-pointed and restrained levels are fully fit for authentic Yoga.
- **The 2019 applied triad** - scientist, God-realised devotee, self-realised yogin.
- **Vyāsa's Yoga-bhāṣya*** - as the source layer of the classification.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The mind-level scheme is Yoga's quiet refusal to flatter intelligence: it grades minds by which quality rules them, and on that grading a distracted genius sits below a one-pointed devotee.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **levels of the mind-field (citta-bhūmi)**
- **scattered (kṣipta)**
- **dull (mūḍha)**
- **distracted (vikṣipta)**
- **one-pointed (ekāgra)**
- **restrained (niruddha)**
- **one-pointedness (ekāgratā)**
- **fit for Yoga (yogya)**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The five levels are not a psychological curiosity but a fitness criterion, and they disqualify precisely the kind of excellence that examinees instinctively promote.

Named evidence. The scattered mind is ruled by the active quality and the dull mind by the inert quality; the distracted mind attains occasional lucidity without sustained collection; the one-pointed mind is lucid-dominant; the restrained mind has all modifications arrested; and only the last two are fully fit for Yoga.

Analysis. Because the classification tracks the ruling quality rather than the force of attention, a mind can be extraordinarily powerful and still be structurally worldly - outward-turned, result-dependent and interrupted - which is why the scientist of the 2019 question falls on the unfit side of the line while a devotee of lesser analytic power falls on the fit side. The classification thus encodes the school's core claim that liberation is a matter of direction and stability rather than of cognitive capacity.

Qualification. The scheme is commentarial rather than a printed five-item aphorism, and its application to individuals is a judgement about the ruling condition of a mind, not a permanent label attached to a profession or a role.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2019 Q7(b) is this session in its entirety: "How would Yoga philosophy comprehend the Citta-levels of a Scientist, a God-realized Devotee and a Self-realized Yogi? Justify your answer." The marks live in the justification, so each assignment must be argued from the ruling quality and the fitness rule, not merely stated.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** classify the scientist as one-pointed. Intense outward focus is distraction in Yoga's sense.
- Do **not** describe the dull level as calm or peaceful. It is obscuration.
- Do **not** treat the restrained level as unconscious blankness.
- Do **not** attribute the five levels to a sūtra list of Patañjali.

RAPID REVISION

- Five levels: scattered · dull · distracted · one-pointed · restrained.
- Ruling qualities: active · inert · mixed-with-flashes · lucid · arrested.
- Fit for Yoga: only one-pointed and restrained.
- Decisive step: distracted -> one-pointed.
- 2019 triad: scientist = distracted · devotee = one-pointed · yogin = restrained.
- One line: *concentration is not restraint, and brilliance is not fitness.*

SESSION 6 - MENTAL MODIFICATION (CITTA-VṚTTI): THE FIVE KINDS AND THE AFFLICTED DIVISION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. A modification is any shape the mind takes. Yoga says every mental event you can name - a true perception, a mistake, a word-picture with nothing behind it, sleep, a memory - is one of exactly five shapes, and that each shape can either bind you or help free you.

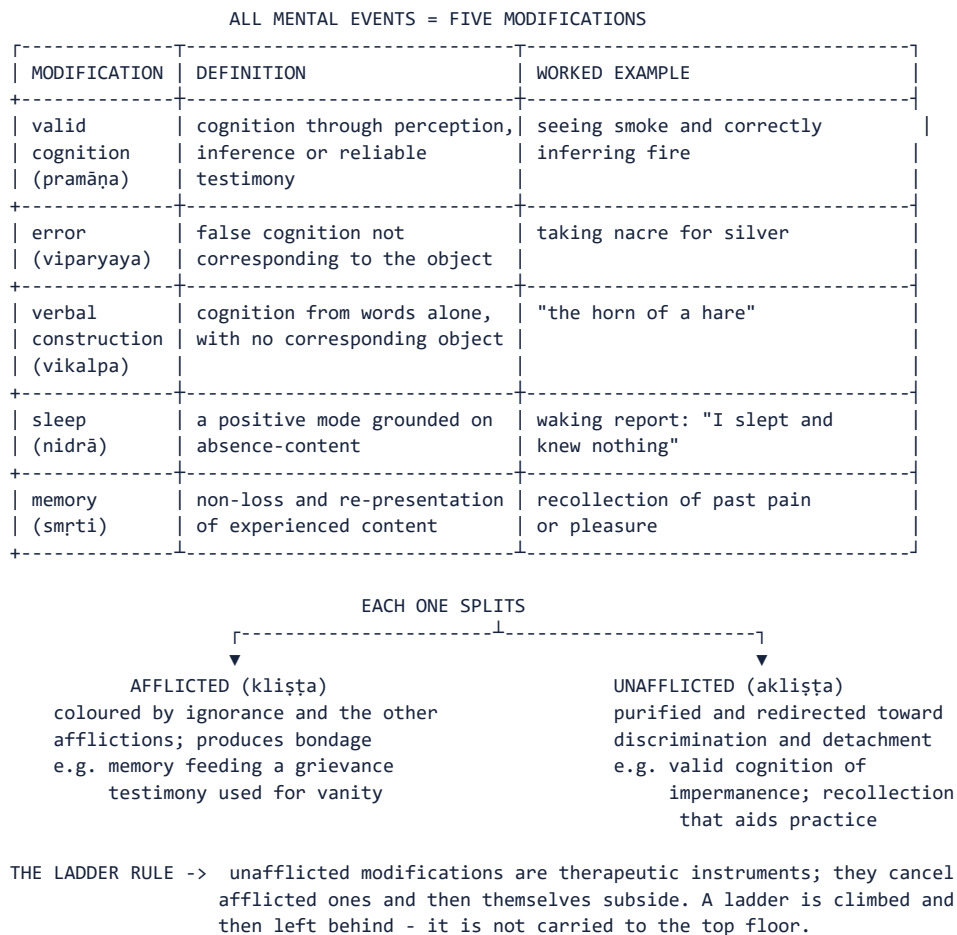
Technical definition. A mental modification (**citta-vṛtti**) is an operative mode or fluctuation of the mind-field. Patañjali classifies all modifications into five kinds: valid cognition (**pramāṇa**), error (**viparyaya**), verbal construction (**vikalpa**), sleep (**nidrā**) and memory (**smṛti**). Each of the five may be afflicted (**kliṣṭa**) or unafflicted (**akliṣṭa**), according to whether it sustains affliction or serves release.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

The list looks odd at first, and the oddity is the teaching. Why is *sleep* a mental modification? Why is *true knowledge* on a list of things to be stopped?

Because Yoga is not sorting mental events by whether they are good or true. It is sorting them by whether they are *shapes the mind takes*. Sleep is a shape - you wake and report "I slept and knew nothing," which means something was registered. True cognition is a shape - an accurate one, but still a shape. And the problem is never the accuracy of a shape. The problem is that shapes are what the witness keeps mistaking for itself.

VISUAL - THE FIVE MODIFICATIONS AND THE AFFLICTED/UNAFFLICTED CUT



What the diagram shows: an exhaustive five-way classification on top, an orthogonal moral cut underneath, and one rule that explains why even true cognition eventually stops.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- The classification claims to be exhaustive.** Yoga holds that the mind constantly assumes forms corresponding to objects, memories, errors, absences and verbal constructions, and that these five exhaust the field.
- Valid cognition is included, and its inclusion is the doctrinal point.** Yoga does not deny valid knowledge; it accepts perception, inference and reliable testimony. But even true cognition is *a modification of the mind*, and modifications are what the witness misidentifies with. Truth does not exempt a mental form from being a mental form.
- Error is false knowledge not corresponding to the object as it is.** It covers both perceptual and conceptual misapprehension. Since error reinforces wrong attachment and aversion, it is typically afflicted.
- Verbal construction is cognition produced by words alone.** It is not nonsense; it has linguistic intelligibility without an objective referent. Yoga is unusually sensitive here: it sees that language can autonomously generate mental worlds, anxieties, dogmas and imagined identities.
- Sleep is a positive modification, not a gap.** The later recollection "I slept and knew nothing" shows that sleep leaves a determinate mental trace; its content is an absence, but the mode is real. Philosophically this matters because it forbids the equation of quiescence with liberation.
- Memory is non-loss and re-presentation of prior experience.** It links past impressions to present identity and reaction, and in practical psychology it feeds attachment, trauma, fear and habitual self-narration.
- The afflicted/unafflicted division is orthogonal to the fivefold list.** Any of the five can fall on either side. Afflicted modifications are coloured by ignorance and the other afflictions and are therefore bondage-producing; unafflicted ones are purified and redirected toward discrimination, detachment and liberation.
- Yoga therefore does not abolish cognition at once.** It first transforms the *quality* of

mental life, replacing afflicted modifications with unafflicted ones, and only then lets even those subside once their work is done.

9. **The division qualifies modifications, never afflictions.** Afflictions are inherently afflictive; there is no "unafflicted ignorance". Reversing this is a standard close-option trap.

Qualification to keep. The claim that even valid cognition must finally cease is not a claim that valid cognition is false or worthless. It is a claim about *category*: what has to stop is the mind's form-taking, and truth-value is irrelevant to whether something is a form.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **The five-kind classification** - valid cognition, error, verbal construction, sleep, memory.
- **Patañjali's three instruments of valid knowledge** - perception, inference and authoritative testimony (*āgama/śabda*).
- **The nacre-and-silver example** for error and the **hare's horn** for verbal construction.
- **The waking report "I slept and knew nothing"** as the argument for sleep as a positive mode.
- **The afflicted/unafflicted distinction** (*kliṣṭa / akliṣṭa*).

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yoga's most counter-intuitive move is to put true knowledge on the list of things that must eventually stop - and it is defensible, because what binds the seer is not the falsity of a mental form but the fact that it is a form at all.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- mental modification (*citta-vṛtti*)
- valid cognition (*pramāṇa*)
- error (*viparyaya*)
- verbal construction (*vikalpa*)
- sleep (*nidrā*)
- memory (*smṛti*)
- afflicted (*kliṣṭa*)
- unafflicted (*akliṣṭa*)

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The fivefold classification of modifications is designed to be exhaustive, and its inclusion of valid cognition and sleep is the point at which Yoga's psychology becomes a soteriology.

Named evidence. The five are valid cognition through perception, inference and reliable testimony; error, illustrated by taking nacre for silver; verbal construction, illustrated by the hare's horn; sleep, established as a positive mode by the waking report "I slept and knew nothing"; and memory as the non-loss and re-presentation of experienced content - each of which may be afflicted or unafflicted.

Analysis. By classifying mental life by *form* rather than by truth or moral value, Yoga can explain why the path is not simply a programme of correcting errors: correcting errors merely substitutes accurate forms for inaccurate ones, whereas the seer is misidentified with forms as such. The afflicted/unafflicted cut then supplies the graded method, because unafflicted forms can be used to dissolve afflicted ones before themselves subsiding.

Qualification. The afflicted/unafflicted division qualifies modifications and not afflictions, and the eventual cessation of valid cognition is a claim about category rather than a devaluation of truth.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2023 Q7(c) demands exactly this list - "Explain Citta and its modifications in the philosophy of Yoga" - before it asks why cessation is prescribed. It is also the technical vocabulary presupposed by **2024 Q7(b)**, whose "changes and modifications in citta" are these five.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** apply the afflicted/unafflicted division to the afflictions. It qualifies modifications only.
- Do **not** treat sleep as the absence of mental modification. It is one of the five.
- Do **not** say Yoga rejects valid cognition. It accepts three instruments of knowledge.
- Do **not** describe verbal construction as mere nonsense; it is intelligible without a referent.

RAPID REVISION

- Five modifications: valid cognition · error · verbal construction · sleep · memory.
- Three instruments inside valid cognition: perception · inference · reliable testimony.
- Each modification is afflicted or unafflicted; afflictions themselves are never unafflicted.
- Sleep is a positive mode with absence-content - quiescence is not liberation.
- Unafflicted modifications are ladders: used, then let go.
- One line: *what binds is form, not falsity.*

SESSION 7 - WHY RESTRAINT IS PRESCRIBED: THE ARGUMENT, THE INSTRUMENTS AND YOGIC PERCEPTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. This is the "why" half of the definition. Why should a mind that works perfectly well be stopped? Yoga's answer is a five-step argument, and it ends with a claim that restraint reveals rather than destroys.

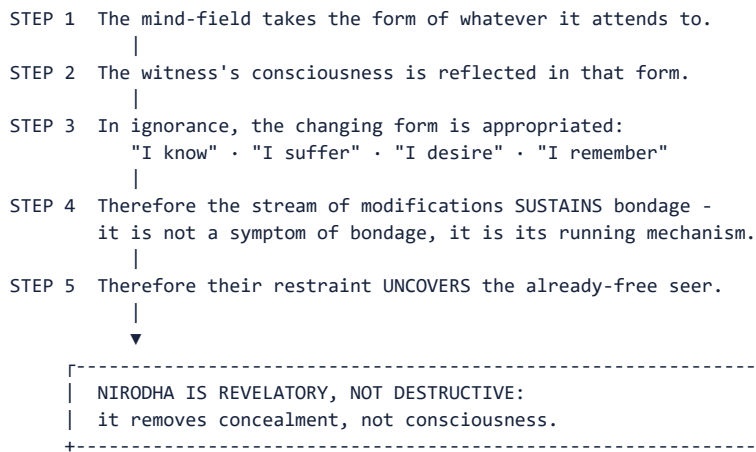
Technical definition. Restraint (**nirodha**) is prescribed because the mind-field takes the form of whatever it attends to, the witness's consciousness is reflected in it, and in ignorance the resulting forms are appropriated as "I know", "I suffer", "I desire", "I remember". The stream of modifications therefore sustains bondage, and its restraint uncovers the already-free nature of the seer. Yoga admits three instruments of valid knowledge - perception (**pratyakṣa**), inference (**anumāna**) and authoritative testimony (**āgama/śabda**) - and treats the perfected insight of the disciplined practitioner as extraordinary yogic perception (**yogi-pratyakṣa**), not as a fourth instrument.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

A pool of water reflects the sky. Stir it, and the reflection breaks into a hundred moving fragments; someone reading the fragments would conclude that the sky is chaotic. Let the ripples settle and the same water shows one clear sky.

Nothing was added to the water and nothing was taken from the sky. That is what "restraint is revelatory, not destructive" means. Yoga is not attacking the mind. It is removing the distortion that makes an undistorted thing look distorted.

VISUAL - THE FIVE-STEP ARGUMENT AND WHAT IT LICENSES



----- EPISTEMOLOGY IN THE SAME FRAME -----	
THREE INSTRUMENTS ADMITTED	WHAT IS *NOT* ADDED
perception (pratyakṣa)	a fourth instrument for yogic insight
inference (anumāna)	-> truth-bearing insight is perfected
testimony (āgama / śabda)	PERCEPTION (yogi-pratyakṣa), not a new pramāṇa
	-> and it is still a modification, so it too ceases

What the diagram shows: a five-step derivation that turns a psychological description into a prescription, plus the epistemological restraint that stops the school from inflating its own meditative claims into a new instrument of knowledge.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **Step one is descriptive.** The mind, by its nature, takes the form of its object. This is not a defect; it is what a transparent instrument does.
2. **Step two adds the reflection theory from Session 4.** The witness's light falls on that form.
3. **Step three introduces ignorance as the operative variable.** Where discriminative knowledge is absent, the changing form is appropriated in the first person. The four sample appropriations - knowing, suffering, desiring, remembering - map neatly onto the five modifications and are worth writing verbatim.
4. **Step four upgrades the modifications from symptom to mechanism.** This is the load-bearing move. If modifications merely accompanied bondage, restraining them would be cosmetic. Because they *sustain* it, restraining them is causal.
5. **Step five states the payoff and its limit.** Restraint uncovers what was already the case. It does not manufacture freedom, and it does not extinguish awareness.
6. **The pool image carries the whole argument.** When ripples settle, the water reflects without distortion; when modifications settle, the witness is no longer misread through mental turbulence.
7. **The epistemology is deliberately modest.** Three instruments, aligned with Sāṃkhya's scheme. Yoga does not add a meditative fourth instrument, and it does not reduce the three.
8. **Perfected insight is classified as extraordinary perception.** Truth-bearing insight (Session 14. is a refinement of perception, not a new means of knowledge. This restraint is worth a line in any epistemology-facing answer, because it shows the school policing its own enthusiasm.
9. **And even that insight is a modification.** Which is why the path does not end with it. An unaffected modification cancels afflicted ones and then must itself subside.

Qualification to keep. The word *nirodha* invites the translation "suppression", and the translation invites the objection that Yoga is a doctrine of self-annihilation. Both should be pre-empted in the answer: restraint is the cessation of form-taking in an instrument, not the destruction of the instrument and certainly not of the seer.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **The five-step derivation** from form-taking to appropriation to bondage to restraint.
- **The four first-person appropriations** - "I know", "I suffer", "I desire", "I remember".
- **The settled-pool image** for restraint as revelation.
- **Yoga's three instruments of valid knowledge**, aligning it with Sāṃkhya against Nyāya's four and

Advaita's six.

- **Extraordinary yogic perception (yogi-pratyakṣa)** as the classification of perfected insight.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yoga prescribes cessation not because thought is bad but because thought is the running machinery of a mistake: as long as the mind keeps producing forms, the seer keeps being handed something to be.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **restraint (nirodha)**
- **revelatory, not destructive**
- **form-taking (sārūpya)**
- **discriminative knowledge (viveka-khyāti)**
- **perception (pratyakṣa)**
- **inference (anumāna)**
- **authoritative testimony (āgama / śabda)**
- **extraordinary yogic perception (yogi-pratyakṣa)**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Cessation is prescribed because the mind's modifications are the operating mechanism of misidentification rather than its by-product.

Named evidence. The mind takes the form of its object; the witness's consciousness is reflected in that form; in the absence of discriminative knowledge the form is appropriated as "I know", "I suffer", "I desire", "I remember"; and when the modifications settle, as ripples settle on a pool, the seer stands in its own nature.

Analysis. This is what converts a description of mental life into a prescription, since a mechanism can be interrupted whereas a symptom can only be masked; and it explains why the school's therapeutic apparatus targets attention, habit and impression rather than belief alone. It also explains why Yoga can be cognitivist at the summit while being practical throughout - restraint is the condition under which discriminative knowledge becomes stable rather than episodic.

Qualification. Restraint is revelatory rather than destructive: it removes concealment, not consciousness, and Yoga guards the same modesty in epistemology by admitting only three instruments of knowledge and classifying even perfected meditative insight as extraordinary perception rather than as a fourth instrument.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2023 Q7(c) asks in terms: "Why does Yoga philosophy prescribe cessation of modifications of Citta? Give reasons in support of your answer." The five steps *are* the reasons, and the answer should number them. The same argument supplies the evaluative spine of **2024 Q7(b)**.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** describe restraint as destruction of the mind as a substance.
- Do **not** give Yoga four or six instruments of knowledge. It admits three.
- Do **not** promote truth-bearing insight into a separate instrument of knowledge.
- Do **not** say that restraint produces freedom. It uncovers it.

RAPID REVISION

- Five steps: form-taking -> reflection -> appropriation -> modifications sustain bondage -> restraint

uncovers the seer.

- Restraint is revelatory, not destructive.
- Three instruments: perception, inference, testimony - as in Sāṃkhya.
- Yogic insight = perfected perception, not a fourth instrument, and still a modification.
- One line: *stop the machinery and the mistake has nothing left to run on.*

SESSION 8 - SUSTAINED PRACTICE AND DISPASSION (ABHYĀSA AND VAIRĀGYA)

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Restraint has two handles, and you need both. One is doing the work long enough and steadily enough that it becomes your default; the other is genuinely not wanting the things that pull you off it. Effort without letting-go becomes strain; letting-go without effort becomes drift.

Technical definition. Sustained practice (**abhyāsa**) is the effort to remain stable in restraint, and it becomes firmly grounded when cultivated for a long time, without interruption and with devoted seriousness. Dispassion (**vairāgya**) is mastery over thirst; in its lower form (**apara-vairāgya** or **vaśīkāra-vairāgya**) it is the cessation of thirst for seen and scripturally promised objects, and in its higher form (**para-vairāgya**) it is non-thirst even for the constituent qualities of nature, arising from direct discernment of the conscious witness.

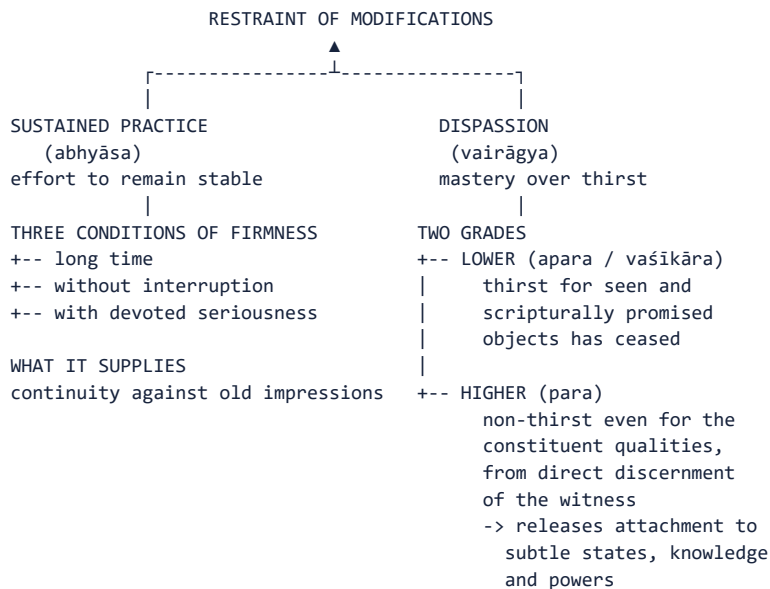
SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Consider two failures that look opposite and are actually the same failure.

The first person meditates rigorously every day and still wants everything - status, comfort, recognition, spiritual attainment. The practice is real; the pull is untouched; every session is a tug-of-war. The second person is genuinely detached - bored of the world, unimpressed by rewards - but never builds a stable practice, so detachment sits as mood rather than as capacity.

Yoga's answer is that restraint is produced by the *pair*, not by either handle alone. And the higher form of dispassion is the surprising one: it lets go not of worldly goods but of the subtle attainments - insight, powers, exalted states - that a successful practitioner is uniquely tempted by.

VISUAL - THE TWO HANDLES AND THE TWO GRADES OF LETTING GO



COMMENTARIAL LADDER INSIDE LOWER DISPASSION (label it as commentarial):
 effort toward control (yatamāna) -> separation of subdued from unsubdued (vyatireka)
 -> withdrawal to a single residual mental desire (ekendriya) -> mastery (vaśikāra)

FAILURE MODES -> practice without dispassion = strain and relapse
 dispassion without practice = mood without capacity

What the diagram shows: two jointly necessary means, three conditions that make practice firm, two grades of dispassion, and one clearly-labelled commentarial refinement.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- The pair is jointly responsible for restraint.** Neither repetition without detachment nor detachment without stabilised practice is sufficient. This joint responsibility is stated at *Yoga-sūtra* 1.12 and is the correct opening sentence for any practice-facing answer.
- Practice has three stated conditions of firmness.** Long duration, uninterruptedness and devoted seriousness. Candidates routinely give one; the marks are in all three.
- Practice's function is continuity against old impressions.** Latent impressions push the mind back into habitual forms; only an equally continuous counter-force can hold restraint.
- Lower dispassion is defined by what has ceased, not by what is renounced.** Patañjali's own concise definition at *Yoga-sūtra* 1.15 is mastery over thirst for objects that are seen and for objects heard of through scripture. Note that this deliberately includes *heavenly* rewards - Yoga does not permit the substitution of a subtler acquisitiveness for a grosser one.
- Higher dispassion is defined by its source.** At *Yoga-sūtra* 1.16 it follows knowledge of the conscious witness and extends renunciation even to the constituent qualities themselves. It is therefore not a stronger version of lower dispassion but a consequence of discernment.
- Higher dispassion is what protects an advanced practitioner.** Its specific targets are subtle states, lucid insight and extraordinary powers - the goods that only success makes available. Session 14's warning about powers depends on this.
- The four-stage analysis of lower dispassion is commentarial.** Effort toward control, separation of subdued from unsubdued tendencies, withdrawal to a single residual mental desire, and mastery. Use it, and label it.
- This pair sits underneath the whole later architecture.** Preparatory discipline, the eight limbs and the absorption ladder are all elaborations of "practise steadily, want less".

Qualification to keep. Higher dispassion must not be described as indifference or as apathy. It is the specific non-thirst that follows seeing the witness as distinct from every quality of nature - a cognitive achievement expressed as an affective condition, not a temperament.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.12** - practice and dispassion are jointly responsible for restraint.
- **The three conditions of firm practice** - long time, without interruption, with devoted seriousness.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.15** - lower dispassion as mastery over thirst for seen and scripturally promised objects.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.16** - higher dispassion as non-thirst even for the constituent qualities, following knowledge of the witness.
- **The commentarial four-stage ladder** - effort toward control, separation, single residual desire, mastery.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yoga's method is deliberately two-handed: practice supplies the continuity that old impressions would otherwise win, and dispassion removes the fuel that would otherwise make the contest permanent.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **sustained practice (abhyāsa)**
- **dispassion (vairāgya)**
- **lower dispassion (apara-vairāgya / vaśīkāra-vairāgya)**
- **higher dispassion (para-vairāgya)**
- **long time, uninterrupted, with devoted seriousness**
- **latent impression (saṃskāra)**
- **effort toward control (yatamāna)**
- **mastery (vaśīkāra)**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Yoga makes restraint the joint product of two means because each alone reproduces a recognisable failure.

Named evidence. Practice and dispassion are jointly responsible for restraint at *Yoga-sūtra* 1.12; practice becomes firmly grounded only when pursued for a long time, without interruption and with devoted seriousness; lower dispassion is mastery over thirst for seen and scripturally promised objects; and higher dispassion follows knowledge of the conscious witness and extends even to the constituent qualities.

Analysis. The division of labour is precise: practice answers the problem of latent impressions, which is a problem of *continuity*, while dispassion answers the problem of motivation, which is a problem of *direction*. That is why the higher grade is not merely a stronger version of the lower - it is generated by discernment and therefore targets exactly the subtle attainments that a successful practitioner would otherwise convert into a new attachment.

Qualification. The four-stage analysis of lower dispassion belongs to the commentarial tradition rather than to Patañjali's concise definition, and higher dispassion should be presented as discernment-generated non-thirst rather than as temperamental indifference.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

This session supplies the "how" that **2023 Q7(c)** implies once cessation has been justified, and it is essential to **2021 Q6(a)**, where the removal of afflictions must be shown as a method and not as a wish. Higher dispassion is also a required stage in the **2025 Q7(b)** account of the road to isolation.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** give only one condition of firm practice. There are three.
- Do **not** restrict lower dispassion to worldly objects; it includes scripturally promised ones.
- Do **not** describe higher dispassion as apathy or as world-hatred.
- Do **not** present the four-stage ladder as Patañjali's own definition.

RAPID REVISION

- Two handles: sustained practice and dispassion, jointly responsible.
- Firm practice = long time + uninterrupted + devoted seriousness.
- Lower dispassion: seen *and* scripturally promised objects.
- Higher dispassion: even the constituent qualities, from witness-knowledge.
- Commentarial ladder: effort -> separation -> single residual desire -> mastery.
- One line: *practice buys continuity; dispassion removes the fuel.*

SESSION 9 - REAL TRANSFORMATION OF THE MIND-SUBSTRATE (CITTA-PARIṆĀMA)

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. If a person really improves through years of practice, something must persist that is doing the improving. Yoga says the mind genuinely changes - it does not merely appear to change, and it is not replaced moment by moment - and that this persisting-yet-changing mind is what makes a graded path intelligible.

Technical definition. Transformation of the mind-field (**citta-pariṇāma**) is Yoga's account of how the mind-complex really changes across practice without losing its continuity as a substrate of nature. The tradition recognises three specifically yogic transformations - of restraint (**nirodha-pariṇāma**), of absorption (**samādhi-pariṇāma**) and of one-pointedness (**ekāgratā-pariṇāma**) - within a general threefold transformation of any substrate: of property (**dharma-pariṇāma**), of temporal character (**lakṣaṇa-pariṇāma**) and of condition (**avasthā-pariṇāma**), all presupposing a persisting substrate (**dharmin**).

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

A lake can be storm-lashed, then gradually calming, then perfectly still. Three genuinely different states - and one lake throughout.

Now ask the awkward question a Buddhist would ask: why do you need "one lake"? Why not just say there is a series of water-events, each causing the next? Yoga's reply is that its own path presupposes more than succession. Practice accumulates. Impressions are deposited and later retrieved. A practitioner acquires a stable capacity. Those are not descriptions of a series; they are descriptions of something that *carries* what it has undergone.

VISUAL - THE THREE YOGIC TRANSFORMATIONS ON A PERSISTING SUBSTRATE

GENERAL FRAME (any substrate of nature)

PERSISTING SUBSTRATE (dharmin)	
--- change of PROPERTY	(dharma-pariṇāma)
--- change of TEMPORAL PHASE	(lakṣaṇa-pariṇāma) past / present / future
--- change of CONDITION	(avasthā-pariṇāma) intensity, maturity

THE THREE SPECIFICALLY YOGIC TRANSFORMATIONS OF THE MIND

restraint-transformation (nīrodha-pariṇāma)	impressions of restraint progressively overpower impressions of emergence; the mind becomes habituated to cessation rather than to dispersion
absorption-transformation (samādhi-pariṇāma)	many-pointedness declines and unified absorption rises; distracting multiplicity weakens as one object becomes dominant
one-pointedness- transformation (ekāgratā-pariṇāma)	similar cognitive moments arise and subside in an unbroken stream toward the same object

THE CONTESTED JOINT

Buddhist momentarist (kṣaṇikavādin)	-> a stream of momentary events suffices; a persisting mind is an unnecessary fiction
Yoga's reply	-> practice, memory, impression-continuity and stable meditative acquisition need more than disconnected flashes
Advaita (vivartavāda)	-> change is only apparent; Yoga answers that change in mind and nature is REAL

What the diagram shows: a general theory of change, three specific applications to the mind, and the two rival theories the doctrine is positioned against.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- Yoga inherits real transformation from Sāṃkhya.** The mind really changes. This is *pariṇāmavāda*, not apparent transformation.
- Restraint-transformation explains how cessation becomes a habit.** Impressions of restraint progressively overpower impressions of emergence, so the mind's default shifts from dispersion toward cessation. This is why restraint is not a heroic act repeated forever but a condition that consolidates.
- Absorption-transformation explains the movement from many-pointedness to unity.** The multiplicity of contents weakens as one object becomes dominant.
- One-pointedness-transformation explains sustained sameness.** Similar cognitive moments arise and subside in an unbroken stream directed at the same object. Notice that even the highest stability is described as a *stream*, not as a frozen state.
- The general threefold transformation supplies the metaphysical licence.** Any substrate of nature may change in property, in temporal phase and in condition without ceasing to be the same substrate.
- The persisting substrate is doing philosophical work.** Without it, graded progress, impression-deposit, memory and stable acquisition are unintelligible. That is the whole reason Yoga refuses a purely momentary psychology.
- The Buddhist objection deserves a full sentence.** A momentarist can argue that a causal series explains continuity without any substance, and that the substrate is an idle postulate.
- The reply, and what survives it.** Yoga answers that its own path presupposes accumulation, retrieval and acquisition, which a series of disconnected flashes does not obviously deliver. Both schools admit ceaseless change; the disagreement is whether change requires a bearer. The Buddhist position remains a live alternative, and saying so is what "critically examine" rewards.
- The contrast with Advaita runs the other way.** Advaita makes ultimate reality

non-transforming and worldly change apparent; Yoga keeps change in mind and nature *real*, and keeps many witnesses. Yoga is therefore squeezed between a momentarism that denies the bearer and an illusionism that denies the change.

Qualification to keep. The persisting mind is a substrate of *nature*, not a self. Saying that the mind persists is not a back-door reintroduction of a psychological soul; the witness remains outside every one of these transformations.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **The three yogic transformations** - of restraint, of absorption, of one-pointedness.
- **The general threefold transformation** - of property, of temporal character, of condition.
- **The persisting substrate (dharmin)** as their common presupposition.
- **The lake analogy** - stormy, calming, still, yet one lake.
- **Buddhist momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda)** and **Advaita apparent transformation (vivartavāda)** as

the two rival positions.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yoga needs a mind that both changes and lasts, because a path that promises graded progress cannot be built either on something that never really changes or on something that never lasts long enough to have progressed.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- transformation of the mind-field (citta-pariṇāma)
- restraint-transformation (nirodha-pariṇāma)
- absorption-transformation (samādhi-pariṇāma)
- one-pointedness-transformation (ekāgratā-pariṇāma)
- property, temporal character, condition (dharma / lakṣaṇa / avasthā)
- persisting substrate (dharmin)
- real transformation (pariṇāmavāda)
- momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda)

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Yoga's theory of mental transformation is not an incidental piece of psychology; it is the condition under which its graded path can be true.

Named evidence. The tradition names three yogic transformations - restraint-transformation, in which impressions of restraint overpower impressions of emergence; absorption-transformation, in which many-pointedness gives way to unity; and one-pointedness-transformation, in which similar cognitions succeed one another toward the same object - all within the general transformation of property, temporal phase and condition in a persisting substrate.

Analysis. Each of these presupposes that something carries what it has undergone, since habituation, deposit and retrieval are not features of a mere succession; and it is precisely this that separates Yoga from Buddhist momentariness on one side and from Advaita's apparent transformation on the other, since the first denies the bearer and the second denies the change.

Qualification. The persisting substrate is an evolute of nature and not a self, and the Buddhist alternative retains genuine force, because a sufficiently rich causal series may reproduce much of what Yoga attributes to a substrate.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

This doctrine is the technical backing for the "changes and modifications in citta" of **2024 Q7(b)**, and it is the correct reply when a *critically examine* directive on Yoga's psychology invites a Buddhist counter. It also underwrites the graded stage-language required by **2022 Q5(c)**.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** say the witness transforms. Only the mind and nature do.
- Do **not** merge the three yogic transformations with the three general ones. They are two levels

of the same theory.

- Do **not** present the persisting substrate as a soul.
- Do **not** dismiss momentariness as obviously false; state its residual force.

RAPID REVISION

- Three yogic transformations: restraint · absorption · one-pointedness.
- Three general transformations: property · temporal phase · condition.
- All presuppose a persisting substrate of nature.
- Against Buddhism: change needs a bearer. Against Advaita: the change is real.
- One line: *a graded path needs a mind that both changes and lasts.*

SESSION 10 - THE FIVE AFFLICTIONS (KLEŚA) AND THEIR FOUR STATES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Below the surface of what you think lies what colours your thinking. Yoga calls these deep colourings afflictions, lists five of them, roots all of them in one, and adds that they operate at four different intensities - including a dormant intensity in which they look absent and are not.

Technical definition. The afflictions (**kleśa**) are the causal colourings of mental life that generate binding action and sustain the cycle of rebirth. They are five: ignorance (**avidyā**), egoity (**asmitā**), attachment (**rāga**), aversion (**dveṣa**) and clinging to life (**abhiniveśa**), with ignorance as the root of the rest. They function in four states: dormant (**prasupta**), attenuated (**tanu**), interrupted (**vicchinna**) and fully active (**udāra**).

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Two things about this list surprise people.

The first is that ignorance is not defined as not knowing something. It is defined as four specific reversals: taking the non-eternal for the eternal, the impure for the pure, the painful for the pleasant, and the non-self for the self. That is not a gap in information; it is a standing misorientation that structures a whole life.

The second is the last item. Clinging to life is said to be present *even in the learned*. Yoga is explicitly denying that scholarship cures the fear of death, because the fear is carried in impressions rather than in beliefs. That single sentence tells you why the school thinks argument alone cannot liberate - and it is the sentence examiners most reliably reward.

VISUAL - THE ROOT, THE FOUR THAT GROW FROM IT, AND THE FOUR INTENSITIES



What the diagram shows: a root-and-branch structure on top, an intensity scale underneath, and the diagnostic rule that connects them - absence of feeling is not evidence of absence.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- Afflictions are deeper than thoughts.** They are not items in the stream; they are what colours the stream. This is why they are treated separately from modifications and why a modification can be "afflicted".
- Ignorance is the matrix, not merely the first item.** The other four arise within it. An answer that lists five parallel afflictions has missed the structure the question is testing.
- Ignorance is defined by four reversals.** Non-eternal as eternal; impure as pure; painful as pleasant; non-self as self. Write all four; each is a separately markable point.
- Egoity is the specific confusion of seer with instrument.** More precisely, the identification of the conscious witness with the determinative intellect or the inner organ. It is the affliction that Session 4's reflection theory explains.
- Attachment and aversion are memory-driven.** Attachment follows remembered pleasure; aversion follows remembered pain. Together they structure most reactive life - chasing the agreeable, fleeing the disagreeable - and both depend on the memory-modification of Session 6.
- Clinging to life is instinctive and carried by impressions.** Its presence "even in the learned" is a doctrinally deliberate claim: it shows that afflictions are not corrected by information, and it is frequently tested.
- The four states explain why progress is hard to assess.** A dormant affliction is seed-like; favourable conditions reactivate it. An interrupted affliction merely lost a contest to a stronger tendency - attachment may look absent only because fear is currently louder. Only the attenuated state represents genuine progress, and even it is not destruction.
- The therapeutic sequence follows directly from the states.** Gross expressions are weakened by

ethical and practical discipline; subtle forms (**sūkṣma**) are burned by meditation; and the seed-state is finally destroyed by discriminative knowledge. This is why mere moral restraint is insufficient.

9. **The afflicted/unafflicted division never applies here.** Afflictions are inherently afflictive.

The division qualifies modifications only.

Qualification to keep. Describing ignorance as "existential misorientation" is analytical phrasing and should be presented as such; the doctrinally exact statement is the four reversals. Give the reversals first and the interpretation second.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **The five afflictions in order** - ignorance, egoity, attachment, aversion, clinging to life.
- **The four reversals** that define ignorance.
- **The claim that clinging to life is present even in the learned.**
- **The four states** - dormant, attenuated, interrupted, fully active.
- **The gross/subtle therapy distinction** - discipline for gross expression, meditation for subtle

forms.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yoga's list of afflictions ends with the fear of death and insists that it survives learning - a deliberate admission that the disease it treats is deeper than opinion, and therefore not curable by instruction.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **affliction** (*kleśa*)
- **ignorance** (*avidyā*)
- **egoity** (*asmitā*)
- **attachment** (*rāga*)
- **aversion** (*dveṣa*)
- **clinging to life** (*abhiniveśa*)
- **dormant** (*prasupta*), **attenuated** (*tanu*), **interrupted** (*vicchinna*), ****fully active**

(*udāra*)**

- **subtle form** (*sūkṣma*)

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The afflictions are ordered as a root with derivatives, and that ordering is the doctrine rather than a convenience of exposition.

Named evidence. Ignorance is defined as taking the non-eternal for the eternal, the impure for the pure, the painful for the pleasant and the non-self for the self; egoity is the confusion of the seer with the instrument of seeing; attachment and aversion follow remembered pleasure and remembered pain; and clinging to life is instinctive and present even in the learned.

Analysis. Because the four derivatives grow within the field of ignorance, no derivative can be removed durably while the root stands, which is why Yoga's therapy is graded rather than piecemeal: ethical discipline weakens gross expressions, meditation burns subtle forms, and only discriminative knowledge removes the seed. The four states then explain why self-assessment is unreliable, since dormancy, interruption and attenuation are all experienced as "I no longer feel it".

Qualification. The afflicted/unafflicted division applies to modifications and never to the afflictions themselves, and dormancy must never be reported as destruction, since favourable conditions can reactivate a seed that has merely gone quiet.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2021 Q6(a) asks in terms for "the nature of kleśas" before asking how their removal leads to isolation, so this session is the first half of a twenty-mark answer. The definition of egoity is also required by **2024 Q7(b)**, and the four states supply the precision that lifts a routine answer.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** list five parallel afflictions. Ignorance is the root of the other four.
- Do **not** reduce clinging to life to intellectual error; it survives learning.
- Do **not** call a dormant affliction destroyed.
- Do **not** apply the afflicted/unafflicted division to afflictions.

RAPID REVISION

- Five: ignorance (root) -> egoity, attachment, aversion, clinging to life.
- Ignorance = four reversals: non-eternal/eternal, impure/pure, painful/pleasant, non-self/self.
- Four states: dormant · attenuated · interrupted · fully active.
- Gross expression -> discipline; subtle form -> meditation; seed -> discriminative knowledge.
- One line: *the last affliction is the fear of death, and it does not read books.*

SESSION 11 - ACTION, DEPOSIT, FRUITION AND IMPRESSION: THE ENGINE, AND PREPARATORY DISCIPLINE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Afflictions do not merely feel bad; they drive actions, and actions leave residues that come back as circumstances. This session is the machinery that turns a psychological problem into a cosmological one - and the first tool Yoga hands you for jamming it.

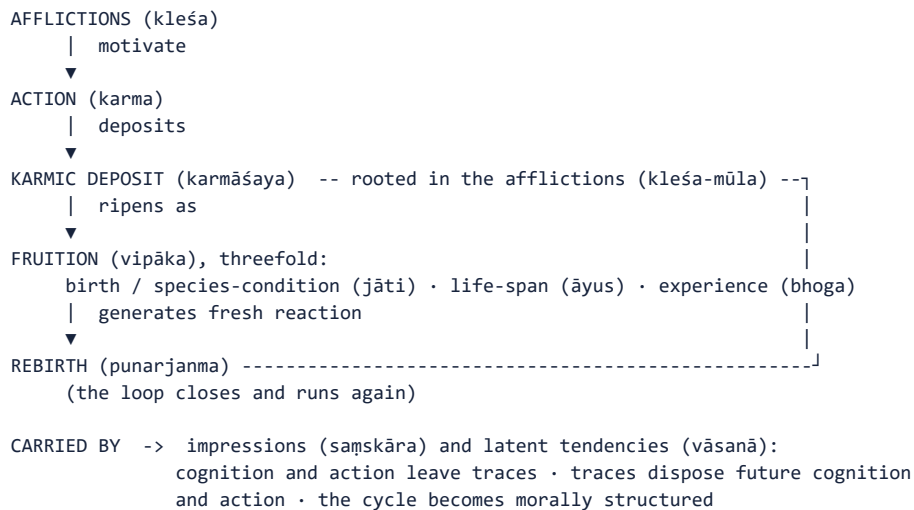
Technical definition. The karmic deposit (**karmāśaya**) is the subtle store of action-traces rooted in the afflictions (**kleśa-mūla**), and fruition (**vipāka**) is its ripening as concrete embodied experience, classically threefold: birth or species-condition (**jāti**), life-span (**āyus**) and experience (**bhoga**). Continuity is carried by impressions (**saṃskāra**) and latent tendencies (**vāsanā**). Action is classified as white (**śukla**), black (**kr̥ṣṇa**), mixed (**śukla-kr̥ṣṇa**) and neither-white-nor-black (**aśukla-akr̥ṣṇa**), the last associated with the practitioner whose action no longer produces ordinary bondage. Preparatory discipline (**kriyā-yoga**) - austerity (**tapas**), self-study (**svādhyāya**) and dedication to the Lord (**Īśvara-praṇidhāna**) - is prescribed to attenuate the afflictions and to cultivate absorption.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Here is the difficulty this session exists to solve. Yoga's diagnosis so far is psychological: afflictions, misidentification, mental forms. But its promise is not psychological - it promises the end of rebirth. How does cleaning up a mind end a cosmic process?

The answer is the chain. Afflictions motivate action; action deposits residue; residue ripens as birth, lifespan and experience; experience generates fresh reaction. Because the *first* link is psychological, work done on the mind is not merely therapeutic - it interrupts a moral-causal engine at its source. That is Yoga's claim to be a soteriology rather than a wellness programme, and it is why the 2021 question can move from "nature of afflictions" straight to "how does removal lead to isolation".

VISUAL - THE ENGINE OF BONDAGE AND THE TWO PLACES IT CAN BE JAMMED



FOUR COLOURS OF ACTION

white (śukla)	meritorious
black (kr̥ṣṇa)	demeritorious
mixed (śukla-kr̥ṣṇa)	the ordinary human mixture
neither white nor black (aśukla-akr̥ṣṇa)	associated with the practitioner whose action no longer produces ordinary bondage

WHERE THE ENGINE IS JAMMED

- ① at the root -> attenuate the afflictions (thinning, tanū-karaṇa) by
PREPARATORY DISCIPLINE (kriyā-yoga):
austerity (tapas) + self-study (svādhyāya)
+ dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna)
- ② at the seed -> burn subtle forms in meditation; finally destroy the seed by
discriminative knowledge, and reabsorb the residue (pratiprasava)

THE BURNT-SEED RULE -> a burnt seed keeps its shape and cannot germinate.

THE POTTER'S WHEEL -> when the push stops, the wheel still turns until its
momentum is spent - residual embodiment, not fresh bondage.

What the diagram shows: a closed causal loop, the mechanism that carries it, the fourfold moral classification of action, and the two intervention points that the whole path exploits.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The chain must be written as a chain.** Afflictions -> action -> fruition -> deposit -> rebirth.

Reproducing it in order is worth marks by itself, because it is the structure the 2021 question asks you to dismantle.

2. **The deposit is rooted in the afflictions.** Action binds *because* it is coloured by ignorance, egoity, attachment, aversion and clinging to life. Uncoloured action does not deposit in the same way - which is what the fourth colour of action records.

3. **Fruition is threefold and specific.** Birth or species-condition, life-span, and experience.

Naming all three is what distinguishes a doctrinal answer from a vague one.

4. **Impressions and latent tendencies explain continuity.** Repeated cognition and action leave traces; traces dispose future cognition and action. This is the mechanism by which a moral order becomes psychologically self-reinforcing.

5. **The fourfold classification of action grades practitioners, not just acts.** White, black, mixed, and neither-white-nor-black. The last is the yogic category, and it is the doctrinal basis for saying that a liberated practitioner still acts without accumulating bondage.

6. **Preparatory discipline is the first therapy, and its purpose is stated.** Austerity, self-study and dedication to the Lord are prescribed explicitly to attenuate the afflictions and to cultivate absorption. Yoga therefore begins from a deliberate re-education of habit and motive, not from metaphysical argument.

7. **The three components are not interchangeable.** Austerity is disciplined, heat-generating effort; self-study is study and recitation of sacred teaching together with reflective self-examination; dedication to the Lord is surrender of the fruits and of the ego's proprietary claim. Note that the third is also a positive observance in the eight limbs and an independent means to absorption - its triple role is examinable.

8. **The standard objection is about scale.** If release requires exhausting an unsurveyable stock of deposits, release seems indefinitely postponed.

9. **The reply is the burnt seed, with a qualification.** Liberating knowledge and absorption burn the seeds of *future* bondage; only the already-fructifying portion of embodiment continues, like a potter's wheel turning briefly after the potter stops pushing. This is the careful basis for liberation-while-living language in Yoga.

Qualification to keep. The already-fructifying/stored distinction is best introduced with the later comparative vocabulary flagged as such. The exam-safe formulation is that the momentum of an already-moving psycho-physical complex may continue after the push of fresh action has stopped.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **The chain** - afflictions, action, fruition, deposit, rebirth.
- **The threefold fruition** - birth, life-span, experience.
- **Impressions (saṃskāra) and latent tendencies (vāsanā)** as the carriers of continuity.
- **The four colours of action** - white, black, mixed, neither-white-nor-black.
- **The three components of preparatory discipline** - austerity, self-study, dedication to the Lord
- with the stated purpose of attenuating afflictions and cultivating absorption.
- **The burnt-seed (dagdha-bīja) and potter's-wheel images.**

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yoga earns the right to call itself a path to liberation, and not merely a psychology, at exactly one point: it shows that the machinery of rebirth has a psychological first link, and that a first link is a place where a machine can be stopped.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- karmic deposit (karmāśaya)
- rooted in the afflictions (kleśa-mūla)
- fruition (vipāka)
- birth (jāti), life-span (āyus), experience (bhoga)
- impression (saṃskāra), latent tendency (vāsanā)
- white, black, mixed, neither-white-nor-black action
- preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga)
- austerity (tapas), self-study (svādhyāya), dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna)
- thinning (tanū-karaṇa), reabsorption (pratiprasava), burnt seed (dagdha-bīja)

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The doctrine of action and fruition is what converts Yoga's psychology of affliction into a theory of bondage and release.

Named evidence. The karmic deposit is rooted in the afflictions and ripens as a threefold fruition of birth, life-span and experience; impressions and latent tendencies carry the continuity between action and disposition; action is classified as white, black, mixed and neither-white-nor-black; and preparatory discipline - austerity, self-study and dedication to the Lord - is prescribed explicitly to attenuate the afflictions and prepare absorption.

Analysis. Because the first link of the chain is psychological, the school can claim that disciplined work on attention, habit and motive is not merely palliative but causally interruptive, and this is exactly why it prescribes a preparatory therapy of conduct before any advanced contemplative technique. The fourfold colour-classification then completes

the account by showing that the goal is not the cessation of action but the cessation of the affliction-colouring that makes action bind.

Qualification. The reply to the objection from the sheer scale of accumulated deposit is that liberating knowledge burns the seeds of future bondage while an already-fructifying momentum runs out, as a potter's wheel continues after the push stops - a qualification that must be stated rather than assumed if liberation-while-living language is used.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2021 Q6(a) - "the nature of kleśas. How does the removal of these lead to kaivalya?" - is answered along this chain: the afflictions are diagnosed in Session 10, the engine is set out here, and the dismantling is completed in Sessions 12 to 16. It also supplies the moral-causal justification demanded by **2024 Q7(b)**'s appraisal of Yoga soteriology.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** compress the chain. Afflictions, action, fruition, deposit and rebirth are five named stages.
- Do **not** give fruition as a single item; it is birth, life-span and experience.
- Do **not** say the liberated practitioner performs no action; the fourth colour of action says otherwise.
- Do **not** equate preparatory discipline with the eight limbs. It is a distinct, three-part therapy.

RAPID REVISION

- Chain: afflictions -> action -> deposit -> fruition (birth, life-span, experience) -> rebirth.
- Carried by impressions and latent tendencies.
- Four colours of action; the yogin's is neither white nor black.
- Preparatory discipline = austerity + self-study + dedication to the Lord, to thin afflictions.
- Burnt seed keeps its shape and cannot germinate; potter's wheel explains residual embodiment.
- One line: *the engine has a psychological first link, and that is where it is jammed.*

SESSION 12 - THE EIGHT-LIMBED DISCIPLINE, COMBINED DISCIPLINE AND THE NINE OBSTACLES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. This is the actual programme. Eight components, in order, moving from how you treat other people to what happens inside a fully absorbed mind - plus the standard list of nine things that go wrong on the way.

Technical definition. The eight-limbed discipline (**aṣṭāṅga-yoga**) comprises restraints (**yama**), observances (**niyama**), posture (**āsana**), regulation of breath (**prāṇāyāma**), withdrawal of the senses (**pratyāhāra**), concentration (**dhāraṇā**), meditation (**dhyāna**) and absorption (**samādhi**). The first five are external limbs (**bahiraṅga**) and the last three internal limbs (**antaraṅga**); the last three applied together to one object constitute combined discipline (**saṃyama**). Nine obstacles (**antarāya**) and four accompanying symptoms are listed, with dedication to the Lord among the prescribed remedies.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Notice where the list starts. Not with breathing, not with sitting, not with the mind - with how you behave towards other beings.

That ordering is an argument. A mind embedded in violence, dishonesty, theft, dissipation and acquisitiveness generates exactly the turbulence that concentration is supposed to remove; asking such a mind to be one-pointed is asking it to fight itself. So Yoga's first two limbs are not moral decoration prefixed to a technique. They are the removal of the conditions that would make the technique self-defeating. This is why Yoga's answer to "is meditation enough without ethics?" is a flat no.

VISUAL - THE EIGHT LIMBS, THE TWO GROUPS AND WHAT COMBINES

EXTERNAL LIMBS (bahiraṅga) - preparatory with respect to subtler operations

1	RESTRAINTS (yama)	non-violence (ahiṃsā) · truthfulness (satya) non-stealing (asteya) · disciplined continence (brahmacarya) · non-possessiveness (aparigraha) -- unrestricted by birth, place, time or circumstance, these form the UNIVERSAL GREAT VOW (sārvabhauma-mahāvratā), YS 2.31
2	OBSERVANCES (niyama)	purity (śauca) · contentment (santoṣa) · austerity (tapas) · self-study (svādhyāya) · dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna)
3	POSTURE (āsana)	a steady and comfortable seat; freedom from bodily distraction, not gymnastic display
4	BREATH (prāṇāyāma)	regulation of breath and the psycho-physical economy; breath is the hinge between body and mind
5	WITHDRAWAL (pratyāhāra)	senses released from compulsive extroversion; the bridge into explicitly internal work

INTERNAL LIMBS (antaraṅga)

6	CONCENTRATION (dhāraṇā)	binding the mind to one chosen locus; the first clear sign of one-pointedness
7	MEDITATION (dhyāna)	uninterrupted flow of cognition toward that same object; also the burner of subtle afflictions
8	ABSORPTION (samādhi)	the object alone shines; discursiveness recedes

6 + 7 + 8 on ONE object = COMBINED DISCIPLINE (saṃyama)

----- NINE OBSTACLES (antarāya) -----
disease (vyādhi) · mental stagnation (styāna) · doubt (saṃśaya) · carelessness (pramāda) · laziness (ālasya) · sensual non-restraint (avirati) · false vision (bhrānti-darśana) · failure to attain a stage (alabdha-bhūmikatva) · instability in an attained stage (anavasthitatva)

FOUR ACCOMPANYING SYMPTOMS -> suffering (duḥkha) · dejection (daurmanasya) · bodily tremor (aṅgamejayatva) · disturbed inhalation and exhalation (śvāsa-praśvāsa)

REMEDIES -> dedication to the Lord · practice of one principle · friendliness, compassion, gladness and equanimity · breath regulation · suitable supports

What the diagram shows: a graded eight-stage programme with an explicit ethical foundation, the technical composite formed by its last three members, and the standard obstacle-and-remedy list that completes the practical picture.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The eight limbs are the mediating architecture of the whole syllabus clause.** The clause names mind-field, modification, afflictions, absorption and isolation; the limbs are the path that connects them. UPSC expects them in any fuller answer even though they are not separately printed.

2. **The restraints are five and universal.** Non-violence, truthfulness, non-stealing, disciplined continence and non-possessiveness. When unrestricted by class or birth, place, time or circumstance, they constitute the universal great vow. This matters philosophically: no exceptional context licenses violence, falsehood or possessiveness for the practitioner.

3. **The observances are five and inward-facing.** Purity, contentment, austerity, self-study and dedication to the Lord. Note the overlap with preparatory discipline: austerity, self-study and dedication appear in both, which is a deliberate structural link and a good line to write.

4. **Posture is a seat, not a display.** Classical posture is the establishment of a steady and comfortable position; its significance is freedom from bodily distraction, since a body at war with itself obstructs one-pointedness.

5. **Breath is the hinge.** Regulation of breathing refines the psycho-physical economy, steadies

attention and weakens agitation.

6. **Withdrawal is release, not mutilation.** The senses are freed from compulsive extroversion; it is the transition from embodied preparation to explicitly internal work.

7. **The internal three are graded, not synonymous.** Concentration is effortful fixing; meditation is sustained continuity; absorption is consummated integration in which the object alone shines. Treating them as synonyms is one of the most common errors in this topic.

8. **Combined discipline is a technical composite.** The last three, applied together to one object, constitute the inner technical core of Yoga's contemplative method - the progressive refinement of intentionality until cognition becomes translucent to the structure of its object.

9. **"External" does not mean unimportant.** It means preparatory with respect to the subtler operations of meditative consciousness. The distinction is one of function, not of value.

10. **The nine obstacles and four symptoms are a complete list worth memorising.** Disease, mental stagnation, doubt, carelessness, laziness, sensual non-restraint, false vision, failure to attain a stage, and instability in an attained stage; with suffering, dejection, bodily tremor and disturbed breathing as accompaniments.

11. **The remedies open the door to theism.** Dedication to the Lord is one of the important means of overcoming obstacles, alongside practice of one principle, the four attitudes of friendliness, compassion, gladness and equanimity, breath regulation and suitable supports. This is precisely why questions on absorption so often open into the role of God: Yoga's God is a practice-enabling doctrine, not a creation-first one.

Qualification to keep. The eight limbs are not a syllabus noun. Present them as the practical architecture that the named nouns require, and keep them proportionate - a ten-mark answer on absorption should not spend half its length listing postures.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **The eight limbs in order**, with the external/internal division.
- **The five restraints and the universal great vow (YS 2.31).**
- **The five observances**, including dedication to the Lord.
- **Combined discipline** as concentration plus meditation plus absorption on one object.
- **The nine obstacles and four accompanying symptoms.**
- **The remedies**, including dedication to the Lord and the four attitudes.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yoga begins its technical programme with how one treats other beings, and that ordering is a philosophical claim: a mind at war with its own conduct cannot be asked to become one-pointed without being asked to fight itself.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **eight-limbed discipline (aṣṭāṅga-yoga)**
- **restraints (yama) and observances (niyama)**
- **universal great vow (sārvabhauma-mahāvratā)**
- **posture (āsana), breath regulation (prāṇāyāma), withdrawal (pratyāhāra)**
- **concentration (dhāraṇā), meditation (dhyāna), absorption (samādhi)**
- **external and internal limbs (bahiraṅga / antaraṅga)**
- **combined discipline (saṃyama)**
- **obstacles (antarāya)**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The eight limbs are not a sequence of techniques but a graded removal of the conditions that make restraint impossible.

Named evidence. The first five limbs - restraints, observances, posture, breath regulation and withdrawal - are external, and the restraints become a universal great vow when unrestricted by birth, place, time or circumstance; the last three - concentration, meditation and absorption - are internal and, applied to one object, form combined discipline; and nine obstacles with four accompanying symptoms are listed, with dedication to the Lord among the remedies.

Analysis. Read in this way the ordering becomes an argument rather than a syllabus: ethics removes gross disturbance, posture and breath calm embodiment, withdrawal cuts sensory dispersion, and the internal three unify the mental stream so that discriminative knowledge can mature. This is also why Yoga answers the question "is meditation sufficient without ethics?" in the negative, since meditative power can otherwise coexist with affliction and egoity.

Qualification. The external limbs are preparatory in function rather than inferior in value, and the eight-limb scheme, though indispensable to a fuller answer, is not itself a printed syllabus term and must be kept proportionate to the demand.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

The limbs are the mediating machinery of **2021 Q6(a)** - the removal of afflictions is executed through them - and they supply the "stages" vocabulary that **2022 Q5(c)** must contextualise. The obstacle list and its remedies are the natural bridge into the Lord's role in that same question.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** treat concentration, meditation and absorption as synonyms.
- Do **not** call the external limbs unimportant.
- Do **not** describe posture as the goal or as physical culture.
- Do **not** confuse combined discipline with preparatory discipline. One is limbs 6-8; the other is austerity, self-study and dedication.

RAPID REVISION

- Eight limbs: restraints · observances · posture · breath · withdrawal || concentration · meditation · absorption.
- First five external; last three internal; last three on one object = combined discipline.
- Five restraints become the universal great vow when unconditioned.
- Nine obstacles + four symptoms; remedies include dedication to the Lord and the four attitudes.
- One line: *ethics is not the porch of the technique; it is part of the technique.*

SESSION 13 - MEDITATIVE ABSORPTION (SAMĀDHI): THE TWO CLASSIFICATIONS THAT MUST NOT BE CONFLATED

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Absorption is where attention becomes so unified and transparent that the object alone stands there. Yoga classifies it twice - once by the *factor* accompanying it, once by the *object-level and conceptual overlay* - and the single most punished error in this topic is merging the two lists.

Technical definition. Absorption (**samādhī**) is meditative absorption in which the mind-field becomes radically unified and transparent. Object-supported absorption (**samprajñāta**) retains a cognitive support and is therefore called with-seed (**sabīja**, *Yoga-sūtra* 1.46); *Yoga-sūtra* 1.17 characterises it through four accompanying factors - gross deliberation (**vitarka**), subtle reflection (**vicāra**), refined joy (**ānanda**) and bare I-am-ness (**asmitā**). Separately, *Yoga-sūtra* 1.42-1.44 classifies meditative coalescence (**samāpatti**) into **savitarkā/nirvitarkā** for gross objects and **savicārā/nirvicārā** for subtle objects. Supra-cognitive absorption (**asamprajñāta**, *Yoga-sūtra* 1.18) is defined as preceded by the practice of the idea of cessation and as having impression-residue (**saṃskāra-śeṣa**).

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

You can classify a university course by year-level and by mode of assessment. Both classifications are correct; both describe the same course; and neither is the other. If someone said "the four years of the degree are essay, examination, dissertation and viva", you would recognise the mistake immediately.

That is precisely the mistake Yoga candidates make. *Yoga-sūtra* 1.17 classifies object-supported absorption by the factor that accompanies it - deliberation, reflection, joy, I-am-ness. *Yoga-sūtra* 1.42-1.44 classifies coalescence by object-level and by whether conceptual-verbal overlay is present or absent. Writing "the four types of samprajñāta listed by Patañjali are savitarka, nirvitarka, savicāra and nirvicāra" mixes a year-list with an assessment-list, and it is the error the 2020 and 2022 questions are best placed to expose.

VISUAL - TWO GRIDS OVER ONE ASCENT, AND WHERE THEY MEET

OBJECT-SUPPORTED ABSORPTION (samprajñāta)
= WITH SEED (sabiḥa, YS 1.46)

GRID A - YS 1.17: WHICH FACTOR ACCOMPANIES THE ABSORPTION	
vitarka	gross object-level deliberative grasp
vicāra	subtle object-level reflection
ānanda	refined lucid joy - NOT ordinary pleasure
asmitā	bare I-am-ness - NOT the binding affliction, but the extremely subtle objectification of the I-sense
+-----	
GRID B - YS 1.42-1.44: COALESCENCE (samāpatti) BY OBJECT-LEVEL AND OVERLAY	
savitarkā	gross (sthūla) object · mixed with word-object-knowledge construction (śabda-artha-jñāna-vikalpa)
nirvitarkā	gross object · memory and verbal construction purified
savicārā	subtle (sūkṣma) object · subtle reflective consideration remains
nirvicārā	subtle object · even subtle reflective overlay stilled
YS 1.45 extends the subtle domain up to the undifferentiated (aliṅga)	
YS 1.46 states that these coalescences remain WITH SEED	
+-----	
GRID A asks: what accompanies it? GRID B asks: what is it on, and how clean?	
Commentators MAP the two grids; they do not IDENTIFY them.	

----- THE MOVE BEYOND -----

- YS 1.47 clarity (vaiśāradya) of nirvicārā -> inner clarity of the self-field (adhyātma-prasāda)
- YS 1.48 therein the insight is TRUTH-BEARING (ṛtambharā) -> see Session 14
- YS 1.18 SUPRA-COGNITIVE ABSORPTION (asamprajñāta):
preceded by practice of the idea of cessation (virāma-pratyaya)
and having IMPRESSION-RESIDUE (saṃskāra-śeṣa)
- YS 1.51 when THAT TOO is restrained, everything being restrained,
absorption is SEEDLESS (nirbija)

TWO SENSES OF "SEED" - THE TRAP
with-seed (YS 1.46) = with OBJECT-SUPPORT
seedless (YS 1.51) = without the residual IMPRESSION
-> losing the object-support does not by itself make an absorption seedless.

What the diagram shows: two independent classification grids inside object-supported absorption, the *sūtra* sequence that leads beyond it, and the two distinct senses of "seed" that the terminology trap depends on.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- Absorption is not passivity.** It is the highest refinement of attention and the threshold of liberating discernment. Saying so at the start pre-empts the "trance" misreading.
- Object-supported absorption keeps a support.** A subtle seed of cognition remains; the mind is profoundly stilled but not free of object-reference. It is called with-seed at *Yoga-sūtra* 1.46 because an object-support is present.
- Grid A is the fourfold characterisation of Yoga-sūtra 1.17.** Gross deliberation, subtle reflection, refined joy and bare I-am-ness. Two of these need protecting from misreading: the joy is a purified meditative affect attached to the lucid quality, not ordinary pleasure; and the I-am-ness is not the binding affliction of Session 10 but an extremely subtle objectification of the I-sense.
- Therefore joy and I-am-ness are not a contested later addition.** They are explicitly present

in the sūtra's own fourfold characterisation. What is interpretively delicate is only how later commentators map them onto the coalescence sequence.

5. **Grid B is the coalescence analysis of Yoga-sūtra 1.42-1.44.** The sa-/nir- prefix marks the presence or absence of conceptual-verbal overlay, specifically the word-object-knowledge construction; the vitarka/vicāra distinction marks gross versus subtle object.

6. **The sūtra sequence continues past the four coalescences.** *Yoga-sūtra* 1.45 extends the subtle domain up to the undifferentiated condition of nature; 1.46 declares all of these with-seed; 1.47 makes the clarity of subtle coalescence yield inner clarity of the self-field; 1.48 declares the insight there truth-bearing.

7. **Supra-cognitive absorption is defined by two things, not one.** *Yoga-sūtra* 1.18: it is preceded by the practice of the idea of cessation, and it has impression-residue. Both halves must be written, because the second half is what makes the next distinction necessary.

8. **Seedless absorption is a further condition, not a synonym.** *Yoga-sūtra* 1.51: when *that too* - the residual impression left by the preceding stage - is restrained, everything being restrained, absorption is seedless. The safe formula is: *supra-cognitive = modifications stopped, impression-residue remains; seedless = even that residue restrained.*

9. **Two routes are associated with the supra-cognitive movement.** *Yoga-sūtra* 1.19 gives a condition-based route associated with disembodied beings and those merged in primordial nature; *Yoga-sūtra* 1.20 gives the means-based route for other practitioners through faith, energy, mindfulness, absorption and wisdom. Commentators warn that condition-based absorption or nature-mergence need not equal final discriminative isolation. These are routes or bases, not a third main classification.

10. **The relation between impression and restraint explains why calm is not release.** Even when active modifications cease, latent impressions can remain as residual potency - which is exactly the impression-residue of *Yoga-sūtra* 1.18 - so the path must proceed to the restraint of even the subtle seed.

11. **The reply to "is supra-cognitive absorption just sleep?" is structural.** Sleep is itself one of the five modifications; supra-cognitive absorption is the cessation of modifications through discipline. The difference lies in both genesis and value: sleep is natural obscuration, absorption is luminous restraint.

Qualification to keep. The commentarial status of joy and I-am-ness - whether they are independent coalescences, supervening aspects of the subtle stage, or higher refinements beyond the four named sa-/nir- coalescences - is genuinely disputed. Report the dispute; do not resolve it.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.17** - object-supported absorption characterised by deliberation, reflection, joy and I-am-ness.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.42-1.44** - the four coalescences by object-level and overlay.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.45-1.48** - the subtle domain up to the undifferentiated; with-seed status; clarity of subtle coalescence; truth-bearing insight.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.18** - supra-cognitive absorption with impression-residue.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.51** - seedless absorption when even that residue is restrained.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.19-1.20** - the condition-based and means-based routes.
- **The crystal-and-flower image** for coalescence: the mind becomes so object-coloured that the object seems to shine through it.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yoga classifies absorption twice because it is answering two different questions - what accompanies the absorption, and what it rests on - and the candidate who collapses the two lists has answered neither question.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- absorption (samādhi)
- object-supported absorption (samprajñāta), with seed (sabīja)
- deliberation (vitarka), reflection (vicāra), joy (ānanda), I-am-ness (asmitā)
- coalescence (samāpatti); savitarkā / nirvitarkā / savicārā / nirvicārā
- word-object-knowledge construction (śabda-artha-jñāna-vikalpa)
- undifferentiated (aliṅga)
- supra-cognitive absorption (asamprajñāta), impression-residue (saṃskāra-śeṣa)
- seedless (nirbīja); condition-based (bhava-pratyaya), means-based (upāya-pratyaya)

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Yoga's account of absorption is governed by two independent classifications and one terminological distinction, and precision about all three is what a question on the stages of absorption actually tests.

Named evidence. *Yoga-sūtra* 1.17 characterises object-supported absorption by deliberation, reflection, joy and I-am-ness; *Yoga-sūtra* 1.42-1.44 classifies coalescence as savitarkā and nirvitarkā for gross objects and savicārā and nirvicārā for subtle objects, with 1.46 declaring these with-seed; *Yoga-sūtra* 1.18 defines supra-cognitive absorption as preceded by the practice of cessation and as having impression-residue; and *Yoga-sūtra* 1.51 declares absorption seedless when even that residue is restrained.

Analysis. The two grids are not rival lists but different criteria applied to one ascent - the first tracking the accompanying factor and the second tracking object-level and conceptual purity - so that mapping them is a commentarial task rather than a textual identity; and the with-seed and seedless terms use "seed" in two different senses, object-support in the first case and residual impression in the second, which is why the loss of an object-support does not by itself yield seedless absorption.

Qualification. Whether joy and I-am-ness are independent coalescences, supervening aspects of the subtle stage or higher refinements beyond the four named coalescences remains commentarially disputed, and the disputed status should be reported rather than silently resolved in either direction.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2020 Q5(b) - "Explain the difference between Samprajñāta Samādhi and Asamprajñāta Samādhi" - is answered from this session, and the distinguishing marks are the object-support on one side and the impression-residue on the other.

2022 Q5(c) - "the nature and different stages of Samādhi as per Pātañjala yoga" - requires both grids, the seed distinction and the culmination, before it turns to the Lord.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** list savitarka, nirvitarka, savicāra and nirvicāra as "the four types of samprajñāta given by Patañjali".
- Do **not** equate supra-cognitive absorption with seedless absorption.
- Do **not** read the joy-factor as ordinary pleasure or the I-am-ness factor as the binding affliction.
- Do **not** promote the condition-based and means-based routes into a third main classification.
- Do **not** reverse object-supported and supra-cognitive absorption.

RAPID REVISION

- Grid A (YS 1.17): deliberation · reflection · joy · I-am-ness - factors of object-supported absorption.
- Grid B (YS 1.42-1.44): savitarkā/nirvitarkā (gross) · savicārā/nirvicārā (subtle) - coalescences.
- YS 1.46: all coalescences are with-seed. YS 1.45: subtle domain up to the undifferentiated.
- YS 1.18: supra-cognitive = cessation-practice + impression-residue.
- YS 1.51: seedless = even that residue restrained.
- YS 1.19-1.20: condition-based and means-based routes - bases, not a third class.

- One line: *two grids, one ascent, and two different meanings of "seed".*

SESSION 14 - TRUTH-BEARING INSIGHT, POWERS AND THE CLOUD OF DHARMA

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Near the top of the path something remarkable happens: the mind becomes so clear that it grasps its object with a precision ordinary inference and testimony cannot reach. Yoga names it, uses it - and then insists it must also go. Alongside it come extraordinary capacities, which Yoga names, credits and then explicitly calls obstacles.

Technical definition. Truth-bearing insight (**ṛtambharā prajñā**) is the special lucidity arising with the clarity of subtle coalescence (**nirvicāra-vaiśāradya**), whose field is a particular object (**viśeṣa-artha**) rather than the universals reached by testimony (**śruta**) and inference (**anumāna**); its impression obstructs other impressions, and when even it ceases, seedless absorption becomes possible. Extraordinary capacities (**siddhi**) are attainments in the outward-turned state but obstacles to absorption (**samādhāv upasargāḥ**, *Yoga-sūtra* 3.37). Cloud-of-dharma absorption (**dharmamegha-samādhi**) is the highest absorption immediately preceding isolation.

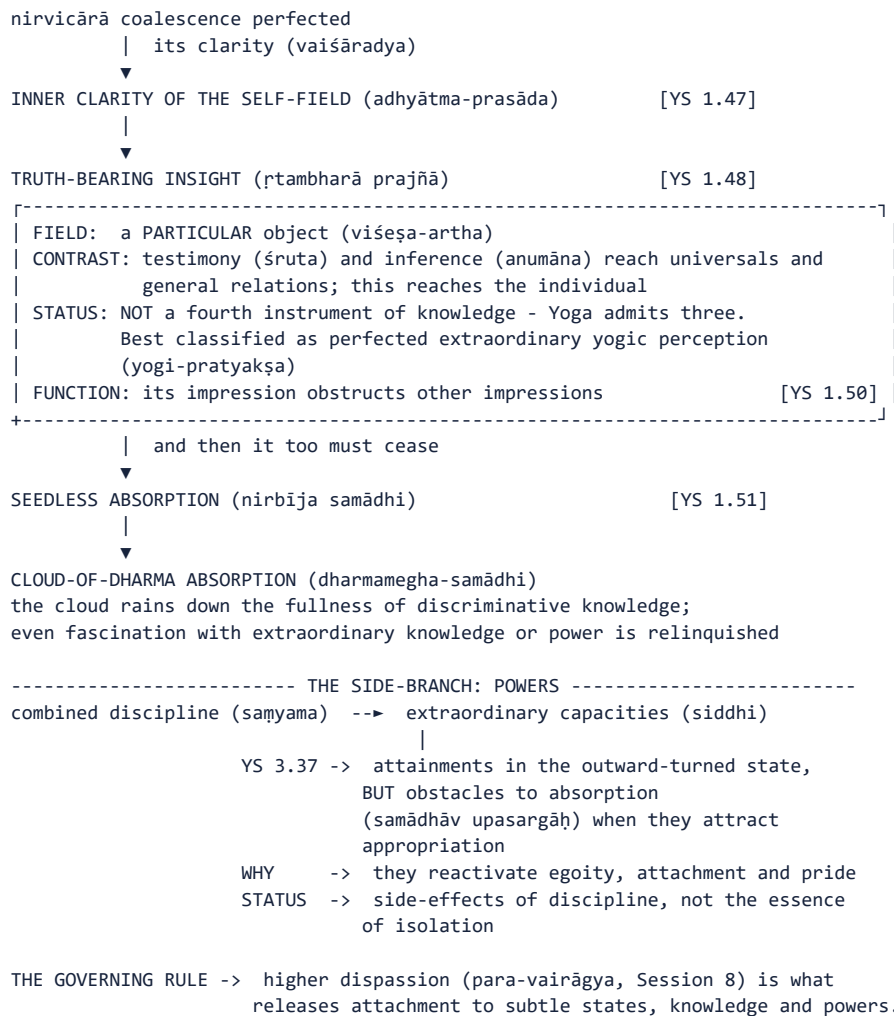
SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

There is a sharp internal logic in this session, and it is worth seeing before the details.

Yoga's whole problem is that the witness gets identified with mental forms. Now suppose practice succeeds and produces the most exalted mental form imaginable - an insight of flawless truth, plus the power to know distant things. What is the danger? Exactly the same danger as before, only more seductive. A practitioner who says "I possess extraordinary insight" has re-created egoity at a higher altitude.

So Yoga does something unusual for a mystical tradition: it builds the demotion of its own summit experiences into its doctrine. Truth-bearing insight is a ladder; powers are side-effects and liabilities; and the final absorption is defined by the relinquishing of even the fascination with knowing.

VISUAL - THE LADDER THAT MUST BE LEFT BEHIND



What the diagram shows: a single vertical ascent in which each rung is used and then surrendered, and a side-branch of capacities that the doctrine explicitly demotes.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **Truth-bearing insight has a stated source.** It arises with the clarity of subtle coalescence and is linked to the inward clarity that follows the perfection of nirvicārā coalescence.
2. **Its distinguishing feature is its field.** Testimony and inference normally reach universals or general relations; truth-bearing insight has a particular object as its field. Yogic insight therefore reaches the individual in a way ordinary testimony and inference do not.
3. **Its function is competitive, not merely revelatory.** The impression born of truth-bearing insight counteracts ordinary afflicted and dispersive impressions. It is an unafflicted modification cancelling afflicted ones, exactly as Session 6 predicted.
4. **It is not a fourth instrument of knowledge.** Yoga accepts three - perception, inference and authoritative testimony. Truth-bearing insight is best classified as perfected extraordinary yogic perception, an extraordinary refinement of perception rather than a new independent means.
5. **The objection is sharp and should be voiced.** If truth-bearing insight is still a mental modification, how can it help liberation rather than bind?
6. **The reply is the ladder.** Unafflicted modifications can cancel afflicted ones; the truth-bearing impression blocks lower impressions and then itself ceases. It is a ladder that must finally be left behind, and when even its impression ceases, seedless absorption becomes possible.
7. **A caution about comparison must be stated.** Truth-bearing insight should not simply be equated

with Aurobindo's knowledge by identity or supermind. The resemblance is thematic only: here it is a purified mental modification that must finally cease; there, supramental knowledge is reinterpreted as a permanent, world-affirming gnosis.

8. **Extraordinary capacities are real in the doctrine and demoted by it.** Higher concentrations may yield such capacities; *Yoga-sūtra* 3.37 states that they are attainments in the outward-turned state but obstacles to absorption when they attract appropriation.

9. **The reason for the demotion is precise.** Powers are not intrinsically liberation and can reactivate egoity, attachment and pride. They belong to the side-effects of combined discipline, not to the essence of isolation.

10. **Cloud-of-dharma absorption is the culmination of non-attachment, not of ambition.** The image is a cloud of dharma raining down the fullness of discriminative knowledge; at this level even fascination with extraordinary knowledge or powers is relinquished, and the practitioner no longer seeks omniscience, attainment or display.

Qualification to keep. Reporting extraordinary capacities is doctrinal exposition, not empirical endorsement. The exam-safe register is: the classical text owns these claims and subordinates them to liberation; their independent verification is not part of the philosophical case.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.47-1.48** - clarity of subtle coalescence, inner clarity of the self-field, and truth-bearing insight.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.50** - the impression of truth-bearing insight obstructs other impressions.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.51** - seedless absorption when even that impression is restrained.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 3.37** - capacities as attainments outwardly and obstacles to absorption.
- **The three instruments of knowledge** - perception, inference, testimony - and the classification of yogic insight as perfected perception.
- **The cloud-of-dharma image.**

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The most disciplined thing about Yoga is what it says about its own successes: its highest insight is classified as a ladder, its extraordinary powers are classified as obstacles, and its final absorption is defined by the surrender of interest in both.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- truth-bearing insight (*ṛtambharā prajñā*)
- clarity of subtle coalescence (*nirvicāra-vaiśāradya*)
- inner clarity of the self-field (*adhyātma-prasāda*)
- particular object (*viśeṣa-artha*)
- extraordinary yogic perception (*yogi-pratyakṣa*)
- extraordinary capacity (*siddhi*); obstacles to absorption (*samādhāv upasargāḥ*)
- cloud-of-dharma absorption (*dharmamegha-samādhi*)
- higher dispassion (*para-vairāgya*)

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Yoga's treatment of its own summit attainments is deflationary by design, and this is a philosophical strength rather than a piece of pious modesty.

Named evidence. Truth-bearing insight arises with the clarity of subtle coalescence and has a particular object as its field, unlike testimony and inference; its impression obstructs other impressions; when even that impression is restrained, absorption becomes seedless; extraordinary capacities are declared attainments in the outward-turned state but obstacles to absorption when appropriated; and cloud-of-dharma absorption is reached only when fascination with knowledge and power has been relinquished.

Analysis. Each demotion follows from the school's own diagnosis, since the disease was identification of the witness with mental forms, and an exalted mental form is still a mental form - which is why the summit of the path had to be defined by relinquishment rather than by acquisition, and why higher dispassion rather than further attainment is the operative virtue at that altitude.

Qualification. Truth-bearing insight is not admitted as a fourth instrument of knowledge but is classified as perfected extraordinary perception, and its similarity to later integral conceptions of knowledge by identity is thematic only, since in Yoga it must finally cease.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

This session completes **2022 Q5(c)** by supplying the culmination that the "stages of Samādhī" must reach, and it supplies the decisive final movement of **2021 Q6(a)**, since cloud-of-dharma absorption is the transition at which afflictions and action cease. It also protects **2020 Q5(b)** from the seedless/supra-cognitive conflation.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** call truth-bearing insight a fourth instrument of knowledge.
- Do **not** present extraordinary capacities as evidence of liberation.
- Do **not** equate cloud-of-dharma absorption with every use of supra-cognitive or seedless absorption.
- Do **not** endorse extraordinary capacities as verified fact; report them as text-owned.

RAPID REVISION

- Truth-bearing insight: from clarity of subtle coalescence; field is the particular; perfected perception, not a fourth instrument.
- Its impression blocks other impressions; then it too ceases -> seedless absorption.
- Powers: attainments outwardly, obstacles to absorption when appropriated.
- Cloud of dharma: fullness of discriminative knowledge; even fascination with knowing is dropped.
- One line: *every rung of this ladder is used and then surrendered.*

SESSION 15 - THE LORD (ĪŚVARA): SPECIAL WITNESS, SACRED SYLLABLE AND A LIMITED THEISM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Yoga believes in God - and then spends most of its doctrine explaining what its God does not do. He does not make the world, does not run it, and does not hand out liberation. What he is, is the one being who was never entangled, and therefore the best possible thing for an entangled mind to concentrate on.

Technical definition. The Lord (Īśvara) is defined in Yoga as a special conscious witness (**puruṣa-viśeṣa**) untouched by affliction (**kleśa**), action (**karma**), fruition (**vipāka**) and karmic deposit (**āśaya**). In him lies the unsurpassed seed of omniscience; he is the teacher of the ancients, unlimited by time; and he is denoted by the sacred syllable (**praṇava**, OM). Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna) is a positive observance, a component of preparatory discipline and an independent means conducive to absorption and to the removal of obstacles.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Ask what problem a God is being introduced to solve. In Nyāya, God explains why atoms combine and why the moral order is enforced - a cosmological and administrative problem. In Advaita, the personal God is the highest reality under the empirical standpoint - a metaphysical problem.

In Yoga, neither. The problem is practical: minds cannot hold still, obstacles derail practice, and the ego resists surrender. A being who is conscious, unlimited in knowledge, unconditioned by time and demonstrably never entangled is the single most effective object such a mind could take. That is why Yoga's theism is real - the Lord genuinely exists in this system - and bounded: he is instrumental, not constitutive, in liberation.

VISUAL - WHAT THE LORD IS, WHAT HE DOES, AND WHAT HE IS NOT

----- WHAT HE IS (the definition) -----	
a SPECIAL CONSCIOUS WITNESS (puruṣa-viśeṣa)	
untouched by: affliction (kleśa) · action (karma) · fruition (vipāka)	
· karmic deposit (āśaya) [YS 1.24]	
in him lies the UNSURPASSED SEED OF OMNISCIENCE [YS 1.25]	
TEACHER OF THE ANCIENTS, not limited by time [YS 1.26]	
denoted by the SACRED SYLLABLE (praṇava, OM) [YS 1.27]	
practice: repetition of it with contemplation of its meaning [YS 1.28]	
+-----	
----- WHAT HE DOES -----	----- WHAT HE IS *NOT* -----
object of meditation -> one-pointed devotion	NOT the material cause of the world
stabilises the mind	- primordial nature remains that
aid through dedication -> surrender reduces	NOT the Nyāya creator / efficient
egoity and attachment	cause and moral governor
remover of obstacles -> counters the nine	NOT a saviour who arbitrarily grants
antarāyas	liberation
perfect model -> exemplifies untouched,	NOT one of the ordinary bound
unsurpassed status	witnesses
teacher principle -> anchor of timeless	NOT the substitute for discriminative
transmission and authority	knowledge
+-----	

THE GROUNDS - AND THE SOURCE CONTROL

Patañjali's own grounds are compact and practice-facing:

- special witness · unsurpassed seed of omniscience · timeless teacherhood
- sacred-syllable-mediated contemplation

LATER Yoga commentators add scripture, maximal degrees of knowledge/power, and the need for intelligent coordination of witness and nature.

-> Do NOT project the full later creator/administrator proof-set back onto Patañjali.

THE EXAM FORMULA -> the Lord is INSTRUMENTAL, not CONSTITUTIVE, in liberation.

What the diagram shows: a definition with its sūtra anchors, a two-column positive/negative characterisation, and the source-control rule that separates Patañjali's grounds from later elaboration.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **A separate treatment is necessary even though the syllabus clause does not name God.** Yoga's distinctiveness from Sāṃkhya cannot be explained without the Lord, and UPSC repeatedly asks for his role.
2. **The definition is the doctrinal core.** A special conscious witness untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit. Reproducing the fourfold "untouched by" list is worth marks by itself.
3. **He is special, not different in kind.** He belongs to the category of conscious witness; his distinction is that he was never entangled. This is why Yoga's theism does not disturb the dualist ontology.
4. **Omniscience is stated as an unsurpassed seed.** The gradation of knowledge reaches its limit in him, which is the form the omniscience claim takes in this system.
5. **Timeless teacherhood anchors transmission.** He is the teacher even of the ancients, being unconditioned by time - a claim about authority rather than about creation.
6. **The sacred syllable makes theology practicable.** He is denoted by the sacred syllable, whose repetition with contemplation of its meaning is a canonical practice. This links theology, language, sound and contemplative concentration in one discipline.
7. **He is not a creator in the Nyāya sense.** Primordial nature remains the material basis of worldly evolution; evolution proceeds through the witness-and-nature framework, not through divine creation. Yoga's God therefore differs sharply from the Nyāya God as efficient cause of the world-order.
8. **He is not a devotional saviour.** Devotion is accepted, but the structure of liberation remains

impersonal in one crucial sense: it depends on the practitioner's own discriminative knowledge. Later devotional theologies must not be read back into classical Yoga.

9. **His positive roles are five and should be listed.** Object of meditation; aid through dedication; remover of obstacles; perfect model; teacher principle.

10. **This is exactly why Yoga is called theistic Sāṃkhya.** It preserves the Sāṃkhyan dualistic ontology and adds the Lord. The addition is not decorative - it changes the psychological and devotional resources of the path - while leaving the basic dualism intact.

11. **The theism is genuine but limited, and the limits must be stated.** Yoga affirms a real Lord; but he is not material cause, not clearly the Patañjala creator of the cosmos, and not the external giver of isolation.

12. **The classic objection from Godless Sāṃkhya must be answered.** If Sāṃkhya's ontology already explains liberation, why add a Lord? Yoga's answer is pragmatic and soteriological: he offers a unique focus of devotion, removes obstacles and supports absorption. The addition is justified by practical efficacy rather than by an overhaul of metaphysical fundamentals.

13. **And the follow-up objection must be conceded correctly.** If liberation depends on discriminative knowledge, is the Lord redundant? The exact answer is: not redundant, but non-final. He is a privileged aid, not a substitute for discernment.

Qualification to keep. The strongest and safest single sentence on this topic is that the Lord is *instrumental, not constitutive*, in liberation. It concedes what must be conceded, protects the theism from inflation, and answers both the Sāṃkhya objection and the redundancy objection at once.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.24** - a special conscious witness untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.25** - the unsurpassed seed of omniscience.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.26** - teacher of the ancients, unlimited by time.
- **Patañjali, Yoga-sūtra 1.27-1.28** - denoted by the sacred syllable; its repetition with contemplation of meaning.
- **The five positive roles** - object of meditation, aid through dedication, remover of obstacles, perfect model, teacher principle.
- **The label seśvara-sāṃkhya*** against Sāṃkhya's Godless tendency.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yoga's God is defined by an absence and employed for a presence: he is the one witness never entangled, and precisely that makes him the most effective object for a mind trying to disentangle itself.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- the Lord (Īśvara)
- special conscious witness (puruṣa-viśeṣa)
- untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit (kleśa-karma-vipāka-āśaya)
- unsurpassed seed of omniscience
- teacher of the ancients
- sacred syllable (praṇava, OM)
- dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna)
- theistic Sāṃkhya (seśvara-sāṃkhya)
- instrumental, not constitutive

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Yoga's theism is genuine and bounded, and the boundary is not a weakness of the doctrine but its design.

Named evidence. The Lord is defined as a special conscious witness untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit; in him lies the unsurpassed seed of omniscience; he is the teacher of the ancients, unconditioned by time; he is denoted by the sacred syllable, whose repetition with contemplation of its meaning is canonical; and dedication to him is at once a positive observance, a component of preparatory discipline and an independent means to absorption.

Analysis. Every one of these predicates is practice-facing rather than cosmological, which is why the school can admit a real God without disturbing an ontology in which primordial nature remains the material basis of the world; and it is why the Lord's function is exhaustively described by concentration-support, obstacle-removal, exemplarity and pedagogic authority rather than by creation or judgement.

Qualification. Because liberation finally follows discriminative knowledge, the Lord must be described as instrumental rather than constitutive; and the fuller theoretical proof-set from scripture, maximal degrees and cosmic coordination belongs to later commentators and should not be projected back onto the aphorisms.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2025 Q7(b) - "Explain the nature of God and its role in Kaivalya in yoga philosophy" - is this session plus Session 16, and a strong answer establishes four points: he is a special witness; he is untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit; he aids concentration, removes obstacles and is the object of sacred-syllable-mediated devotion; and he neither creates the world in the Nyāya sense nor bestows isolation independently of discriminative knowledge. **2022 Q5(c)** requires the same material in its second half, and the routed **2018 Q6(a)** compares this account directly with the Nyāya proofs.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** describe the Lord as the material cause or as the Nyāya efficient cause of the world.
- Do **not** make him a saviour who grants liberation.
- Do **not** attribute the later theoretical proof-set to Patañjali.
- Do **not** say the Lord is redundant; say he is non-final.
- Do **not** treat "theistic Sāṃkhya" as meaning the metaphysics changed. It did not.

RAPID REVISION

- Definition: special conscious witness untouched by affliction, action, fruition, deposit.
- Unsurpassed seed of omniscience · teacher of the ancients · denoted by the sacred syllable.
- Five roles: meditation-object · aid through dedication · obstacle-remover · model · teacher.
- Not material cause · not Nyāya creator · not saviour · not a substitute for discernment.
- Patañjali's grounds are compact; the theoretical proof-set is later.
- One line: *instrumental, not constitutive*.

SESSION 16 - ISOLATION (KAIVALYA): DISCRIMINATIVE KNOWLEDGE, INVOLUTION AND SELF-ABIDANCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. The end-state. Not union, not merger, not extinction, and not merely the absence of pain - but the witness standing alone, unconfused, with nature's performance for it concluded.

Technical definition. Isolation (**kaivalya**) is aloneness or absolute distinctness: the isolation of the conscious witness (**puruṣa**) from primordial material nature (**prakṛti**) and its evolutes. It is reached through discriminative discernment (**viveka-khyāti**), matured by higher dispassion (**para-vairāgya**) and consummated in cloud-of-dharma absorption (**dharmamegha-samādhi**), whereupon the constituent qualities undergo involution (**pratiprasava**) back toward their source and consciousness abides in its own form (**svarūpa-pratiṣṭhā**).

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

The obvious objection comes first, and every good answer meets it in the opening paragraph: if the witness was always pure, always free and never actually changed, then what exactly is achieved?

Yoga's answer is precise. Nothing is achieved *in* the witness. What ends is a relation - the appropriation of nature's changing forms as "I". Liberation is therefore not the production of a new essence but the ending of a misidentification at the level of experience and bondage. The witness does not become free; it stops being read as bound.

The farmer image makes it concrete. A farmer irrigating a field does not push the water. He breaches the embankment, and water flows by its own nature. Discipline removes obstructions; it does not manufacture the freedom of the witness.

VISUAL - THE ROAD TO ISOLATION AND THE FOUR THINGS IT IS NOT



What the diagram shows: a single causal road from practice to isolation, a negative fence around the term, and the three canonical images that make the transition intelligible.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The word means aloneness.** Isolation, aloneness, absolute distinctness - the isolation of the witness from nature and its evolutes. UPSC tests this term almost entirely through contrasts, so the definition must be guarded from the first line.

2. **The paradox must be resolved, not avoided.** The witness is eternally pure, inactive and free; yet through ignorance the mind's modifications are appropriated as self. Isolation is the cessation of *that false relation* at the level of experience and bondage.

3. **Discriminative discernment is the decisive cognition.** It discerns the absolute difference between witness and nature. Yoga therefore remains deeply cognitivist at the summit: absorption is indispensable, but its soteriological function is to *mature* discernment.
4. **Higher dispassion prevents a late failure.** Without it, subtle egoity can survive advanced practice, because the practitioner may still crave powers, experiences and exalted cognitive states.
5. **Cloud-of-dharma absorption is the final transition.** It is the ripened summit of perfected discipline and discernment, not a divine grace replacing effort.
6. **Involution describes what happens to nature's side.** With liberation, the constituent qualities cease to function for the liberated witness and resolve back toward their source. It is a reversal of the evolutionary process for soteriological purposes.
7. **Self-abidance is the positive description.** Isolation may be expressed as the abiding of consciousness in its own nature - which simply completes the logic of the founding aphorism: when modifications cease, the seer stands in itself.
8. **The contrast with Advaita liberation is structural.** Yoga has many witnesses; Advaita has one Brahman as ultimate reality. Yoga's liberation is isolation of the witness from nature; Advaita's is realisation of the identity of self and Brahman. Yoga has no Brahman doctrine and no merger. Therefore isolation is *disentanglement*, not identity.
9. **The contrast with Nyāya release is equally structural.** Nyāya's release is often described as the cessation of pain and bondage; Yoga's isolation is the positive self-abidance of pure consciousness. The exam-safe line is that Nyāya emphasises the cessation of suffering while Yoga emphasises the isolation and self-abidance of the witness.
10. **The Lord's role must be stated with precision here.** He assists the aspirant but does not grant isolation as an external gift; liberation finally depends on the practitioner's own discriminative discernment. He remains the perfect model, the object of devotion and the remover of obstacles.
11. **Liberation-while-living language is admitted only with a qualification.** The potter's-wheel image allows a careful account: the witness is no longer bound, though bodily and mental processes may continue until their residual cause is spent.
12. **The negative-isolation objection must be met.** Critics see isolation as a stark separation lacking fullness. Yoga replies that its positive side is abiding in pure consciousness free from all alien admixture; its positivity is not ecstatic union but unconfused self-abidance. This remains a genuinely contested description, and the contest should be reported.

Qualification to keep. Whether isolation should be described as blissful self-abidance or as austere aloneness is interpreted differently by expositors. Present the positive reading as Yoga's own self-description and note that the value of contentless pure consciousness can be questioned by schools that define fulfilment through knowledge, relation, bliss or activity.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **The definition** - aloneness, isolation of the witness from nature and its evolutes.
- **The road** - practice and dispassion -> preparatory discipline and eight limbs -> attenuation of afflictions -> stable absorption -> discriminative discernment -> higher dispassion -> cloud-of-dharma absorption -> isolation.
- **Involution (pratiprasava)** of the constituent qualities.
- **Abiding in one's own nature (svarūpa-pratiṣṭhā).**
- **The farmer (kṣetrika), burnt-seed and potter's-wheel images.**
- **The contrast tables** with Advaita liberation and Nyāya release.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Isolation is the only liberation in Indian philosophy that is defined by a subtraction: nothing is gained, nothing is joined, and what ends is a sentence - "I am this" - that was never true.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- isolation (kaivalya)
- discriminative discernment (viveka-khyāti)
- higher dispassion (para-vairāgya)
- cloud-of-dharma absorption (dharmamegha-samādhi)
- involution of the qualities (pratiprasava)
- abiding in one's own nature (svarūpa-pratiṣṭhā)
- farmer image (kṣetrika); burnt seed (dagdha-bīja); potter's wheel
- liberation while living (jīvanmukti) - with qualification

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Isolation is best defined negatively before it is defined positively, because almost every error on this term comes from importing a rival school's positive content.

Named evidence. Isolation is the aloneness of the conscious witness from primordial nature and its evolutes; it is reached through discriminative discernment matured by higher dispassion and consummated in cloud-of-dharma absorption; the constituent qualities then undergo involution back toward their source; and consciousness abides in its own nature, as the founding aphorism already promised.

Analysis. Because the witness was never altered, the achievement cannot be a change in it, and the account therefore has to be given entirely in terms of what ceases - the appropriation of changing forms, the functioning of the qualities for that witness, and the machinery of action and fruition; the farmer image captures the same logic by making discipline an obstruction-remover rather than a producer of freedom.

Qualification. Whether isolation is austere aloneness or blissful self-abidance is interpretively contested, and the liberation-while-living register is admissible only with the potter's-wheel qualification, since the witness is unbound while an already-moving psycho-physical momentum may still run out.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2021 Q6(a) ends here - "How does the removal of these lead to kaivalya?" - and **2025 Q7(b)** requires precisely the Lord-plus-isolation combination, in which the Lord assists but discriminative discernment liberates. The definition and its four negations are also the safest closing paragraph for **2020 Q5(b)** and **2024 Q7(b)**.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** describe isolation as union with God or as identity with Brahman.
- Do **not** describe it as annihilation of consciousness.
- Do **not** reduce it to mere painlessness; that is closer to the Nyāya description of release.
- Do **not** say the mind is destroyed as a substance; its binding modifications cease and its function is reabsorbed.
- Do **not** say the Lord grants isolation.

RAPID REVISION

- Isolation = aloneness of the witness from nature and its evolutes.
- Road: practice/dispassion -> discipline and limbs -> afflictions thinned -> stable absorption -> discriminative discernment -> higher dispassion -> cloud of dharma -> isolation.
- Involution of the qualities; abiding in one's own nature.
- Four negations: not union · not Brahman-identity · not annihilation · not mere painlessness.
- Images: farmer breaches the embankment · burnt seed · potter's wheel.

SESSION 17 - THE REALIST POLEMIC, INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES, CRITICISMS AND THE GRADED VERDICT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Yoga is usually taught as a practice manual. Its fourth chapter shows that it is not: it argues, against Buddhist idealism, that objects are really out there, that the mind is itself an object for the witness, and that a mind cannot be both lamp and lit thing at once. This session is where Yoga defends itself and where the honest scorecard is drawn up.

Technical definition. The isolation chapter (**kaivalya-pāda**) contains a realist polemic against consciousness-only idealism (**vijñānavāda / yogācāra**), resting on four arguments: the object is not dependent on a single mind (**ekacitta-tantra**); the mind is not self-illuminating (**na tat svābhāsam**) because it is itself something seen (**drśya**) for the witness; the mind cannot apprehend itself and its object in one act; and an object is known when the mind is coloured (**uparakta**) by it. The chapter presupposes a three-term realism of object (**viśaya**), mental modification (**citta-vṛtti**) and witness (**puruṣa**).

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Here is the disagreement in one exchange.

The idealist says: everything you call an external object could be explained as cognition alone. You never encounter an object; you encounter a cognition. Why postulate more?

Yoga answers with a thought-experiment. If an object depended on one mind, it would vanish the moment that mind stopped attending to it. It does not. Two people find the same pot, and it is there tomorrow. Then Yoga adds the sharper point: your own mind is something *you know*. Whatever knows the mind cannot be the mind. So the school needs three terms, not one - and the third term is the witness it had already introduced for entirely different reasons.

VISUAL - THE FOUR REALIST ARGUMENTS AND THE SCORECARD

PRIMA-FACIE POSITION (pūrvapakṣa) - Consciousness-only (vijñānavāda / yogācāra):
what is taken as an external object is explicable as cognition-only.

YOGA'S ESTABLISHED CONCLUSION (siddhānta) - Sāṃkhya-realism, in four moves:

1	OBJECT-INDEPENDENCE (ekacitta-tantra)	an object is not dependent on one mind (ekacitta-tantra); if it were, it would vanish when that mind ceased to cognise it. Persistence and common availability support realism.
2	THE MIND'S KNOWNNESS	the mind is not self-illuminating (na tat svābhāsam) because it is itself something seen (dṛśya) for the witness. Mind-only theory struggles to terminate the regress of cognitions cognising cognitions.
3	AGAINST SIMULTANEOUS SELF-COGNITION	the mind cannot fully apprehend itself and its object in the same act, as though it were both lamp and illuminated object.
4	THE COLOURING ARGUMENT (uparāga)	an object is known when the mind is coloured (uparakta) by it; whether an object is known or unknown depends on the mind's colouring, which implies the object is not identical with the cognition.

COUNTER -> the idealist replies that shared karmic traces explain intersubjective appearance without external objects.

REJOINDER-> shared appearance is better explained by a common object plus many minds;
residual burden: Yoga must still say how an external object colours an insentient but subtle mind.

----- THE GRADED VERDICT -----

STRONG

rigorous phenomenology of mental process: modification, memory, sleep, impression, affliction, absorption
integrates psychology, ethics and metaphysics into one system
supplies an operational path rather than mere speculation
the realist arguments show genuine metaphysical commitment

WEAK

inherits the witness-nature interaction problem; mere proximity does not satisfy every critic
the Lord's explanatory role is limited: aid, not creator, material cause or final giver
the value of contentless pure consciousness can be questioned by schools defining fulfilment by knowledge, relation, bliss or activity

CONTESTED -> commentarial status of joy and I-am-ness as separate coalescences;
whether isolation is blissful self-abidance or austere aloneness;
the historical unity and layering of the sūtra tradition

What the diagram shows: a full dialectical exchange with the counter and rejoinder retained, and an explicit three-column scorecard for evaluative directives.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- The realist polemic establishes that Yoga is metaphysically committed.** It is not only a praxis manual; the isolation chapter defends a position about what exists. This is the single most valuable "value-addition" point available in this topic.
- The four arguments should be given by name.** Object-independence, the mind's knownness, the impossibility of simultaneous self-cognition, and colouring.
- The three-term realism is the presupposition.** Object, mental modification and witness are analytically distinct. The crystal image works here too: the crystal becomes coloured by the flower, but the flower is not created by the crystal's colouration.
- The idealist counter is strong and must be stated.** Shared karmic traces can explain intersubjective object-appearance without external objects.
- The rejoinder concedes a residual burden.** Yoga insists that shared appearance is better explained by a common object plus multiple minds, but must still explain how an external object colours an insentient though subtle mind.

6. **Against Sāṃkhya, the difference is method plus theism.** Same ontology and same twenty-five principles; Godless there, God-admitting here; explanatory metaphysics there, practical psychology and absorption here. Yoga does not reject Sāṃkhya - it operationalises it.

7. **Against Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, four axes separate them.** The internal organ (broad mind-field versus atomic internal sense plus a self-substance); God (special witness and meditative aid versus creator, efficient cause and moral governor); liberation (isolation of the witness versus cessation of suffering); and instruments of knowledge (three versus four).

8. **Against Advaita Vedānta, four axes again.** Ultimate reality (many witnesses plus nature versus non-dual Brahman); bondage (confusion of witness with mind and nature versus ignorance and superimposition); liberation (isolation versus identity-realisation); God (meditative aid and special witness versus qualified Brahman at the empirical level).

9. **Against Buddhism, four axes again.** Self (enduring witness versus no permanent self); affliction (afflictions rooted in ignorance versus the affliction-craving-ignorance nexus); meditation (aimed at witness-nature discrimination versus insight into impermanence, non-self and dependent origination); liberation (isolation versus cessation of conditioned suffering).

10. **The eight standing criticisms and their replies should be rehearsed.** (i) How can an inactive witness be bound? - bondage is misidentification through reflection, not an alteration of the witness. (ii) How can an insentient mind cognise? - it becomes luminous by reflecting the witness. (iii) Why restrain valid cognition? - even true cognition is a modification; it serves as an unaffected ladder and is then transcended. (iv) Is supra-cognitive absorption merely sleep? - no; sleep is a modification, absorption is the disciplined cessation of modifications. (v) Why add a Lord to a sufficient Sāṃkhya? - for practical efficacy, not metaphysical necessity. (vi) Does discriminative knowledge make the Lord redundant? - non-final rather than redundant. (vii) Is isolation merely negative? - its positive side is abiding in pure consciousness free from alien admixture. (viii) Is meditation enough without ethics? - no; without the restraints and observances, meditative power can coexist with affliction and egoity.

11. **The graded verdict is the marks-bearing close.** Strengths: rigorous phenomenology; integration of psychology, ethics and metaphysics; an operational path; genuine metaphysical commitment. Weaknesses: the interaction problem; the Lord's limited explanatory role; the questionable value of contentless consciousness. Contested: the commentarial status of joy and I-am-ness; the character of isolation; the layering of the textual tradition.

12. **Ready verdict lines by mark-weight.** At ten marks: Yoga is best read as a disciplined psychology of mental restraint grounded in Sāṃkhya dualism and completed in isolation. At fifteen: its strength lies in linking mental discipline, moral causation and liberation; its vulnerability lies in the unexplained proximity of an inactive witness and an active nature. At twenty: Yoga is philosophically richer than a praxis manual - a realist metaphysics, a subtle moral psychology and a graded meditative epistemology - though its dualism and limited Lord leave live objections for Advaita, Nyāya and Buddhist critics.

Qualification to keep. Controlled Western comparison is permitted as garnish only, never as substitute: suspension of the natural attitude beside restraint; the thinking self beside the inactive witness; transcendental apperception beside egoity; a third kind of knowledge beside truth-bearing insight; habituation beside practice-and-dispassion; the unconscious beside impressions and latent tendencies. One or two lines, after the Indian case is complete.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **The four realist arguments of the isolation chapter**, with their technical terms.
- **The three-term realism** - object, mental modification, witness.
- **The four comparison axes** used against Sāṃkhya, Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, Advaita and Buddhism.
- **The eight standing criticisms and Yoga's replies.**
- **The graded verdict**, in its strong, weak and contested columns.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The isolation chapter is Yoga's refusal to be filed as a technique: it argues that objects are real, that the mind is known rather than self-knowing, and that a system with a method still owes the world a metaphysics.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- consciousness-only (vijñānavāda / yogācāra)
- not dependent on a single mind (ekacitta-tantra)
- not self-illuminating (na tat svābhāsam); object seen (dṛśya)
- colouring (uparāga / uparakta)
- prima-facie position and established conclusion (pūrvapakṣa / siddhānta)
- momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda); no permanent self (nairātmyavāda)
- release (apavarga) versus isolation (kaivalya)
- graded verdict

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Yoga's fourth chapter converts the school from a discipline with a borrowed metaphysics into a participant in the central realism debate of Indian philosophy.

Named evidence. It argues that an object is not dependent on a single mind and would otherwise vanish when unattended; that the mind is not self-illuminating because it is itself something seen for the witness; that the mind cannot be both lamp and illuminated object in one act; and that knowledge occurs when the mind is coloured by an object that therefore stands outside the cognition.

Analysis. Each argument does double duty, since the same three-term structure that defeats consciousness-only idealism is the structure Yoga already needed to explain how an insentient instrument can appear conscious - which is why the realist polemic and the reflection theory are two faces of one commitment rather than separate doctrines.

Qualification. The idealist counter from shared karmic traces retains genuine force, and Yoga's own residual burden is unchanged: it must still explain precisely how an external object colours an insentient though subtle mind, which is the same interaction problem that its critics press at the witness-nature joint.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

This session supplies the evaluative close of **2024 Q7(b)** - an *appraisal* directive requires the scorecard - and the comparative half of the routed **2018 Q6(a)** on the Nyāya and Yoga proofs of God. Its criticisms-and-replies bank is the standard source of the final paragraph in **2021 Q6(a)** and **2025 Q7(b)**.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** present Yoga as a practice manual without metaphysical commitments.
- Do **not** let a Western parallel replace the Indian argument.
- Do **not** claim Yoga refutes idealism decisively; state the counter and the residual burden.
- Do **not** collapse isolation into release; the emphases differ.

RAPID REVISION

- Four realist arguments: object-independence · the mind's knownness · no simultaneous self-cognition · colouring.
- Three-term realism: object · modification · witness.
- Axes for comparison: self · God · causation · liberation · instruments of knowledge.
- Eight criticisms with replies; concede residual force each time.
- Verdict: strong phenomenology and method; weak on interaction and on the Lord's role; contested on the upper absorptions and on the character of isolation.
- One line: *a school with a method still owes the world a metaphysics - and Yoga pays.*

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct position was fixed **independently for each question** from a randomised draw, so there is no rotation, cycle or seed-derived sequence to exploit; the four positions occur eight times each and twice in every consecutive block of eight, and no position repeats on consecutive questions. Option length, specificity, grammar and formatting are balanced so that the correct answer is not visually identifiable. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

Composition: 24 core diagnostics (items 1-24) covering all seventeen teaching sessions, then 8 remedial drills (items 25-32) targeting the errors this topic reliably produces.

CORE DIAGNOSTICS

MCQ 1. What the word "Yoga" names in Patañjali's system

Which statement gives the Pātañjala definition of Yoga together with its stated consequence?

A. Restraint of the modifications of the mind-field, upon which the seer abides in its own nature B. Union of the individual self with a universal creator, upon which the world is seen as divine C. Steadiness of posture and breath, upon which the body becomes a fit vehicle for devotion D. Performance of prescribed action without desire, upon which merit ceases to accumulate

Answer: A. Restraint of the modifications of the mind-field, upon which the seer abides in its own nature

- **A:** Correct - the founding aphorism defines Yoga as restraint of the modifications of the mind-field, and the next aphorism supplies the consequence that the seer then abides in its own nature.
- **B:** The union gloss belongs to devotional usage and to later popular exposition; Patañjali never defines Yoga as union with a creator, and Yoga's Lord is not a creator in that sense anyway.
- **C:** Posture and breath regulation are the third and fourth of eight limbs; they are means within the discipline and cannot serve as the definition of the state the discipline produces.
- **D:** Desireless action is the formula of the *Bhagavad-gītā*'s discipline of action, not the Pātañjala definition, which is stated in terms of mental modification and its restraint.

Examiner trap 1: Candidates translate the school's name before reading its definition, and so import "union" from ordinary Sanskrit usage into a text that defines Yoga by cessation instead.

MCQ 2. Locating Yoga in relation to Sāṃkhya

Which statement best describes Yoga's relation to Sāṃkhya as the tradition itself presents it?

A. Yoga replaces Sāṃkhya's dualism with a monism in which nature is an appearance of consciousness B. Yoga retains Sāṃkhya's ontology and adds a graded discipline together with a special witness C. Yoga rejects the twenty-five principles and substitutes a purely psychological account of mind D. Yoga accepts Sāṃkhya's atheism and differs only in prescribing posture and breath regulation

Answer: B. Yoga retains Sāṃkhya's ontology and adds a graded discipline together with a special witness

- **A:** Yoga is emphatically dualist; the monist reading belongs to Advaita Vedānta, and the isolation chapter argues *against* reducing objects to consciousness rather than for it.
- **B:** Correct - the tradition's own labels, Sāṃkhya-exposition and theistic Sāṃkhya, record exactly this: the same ontology, plus a practical soteriology, plus the Lord.
- **C:** The twenty-five principles are accepted and simply not re-argued; Yoga restates only as much metaphysics as its psychology requires, which is a division of labour and not a rejection.
- **D:** Classical Sāṃkhya is Godless while Yoga admits a Lord, so this option reverses the single most important doctrinal difference between the two schools.

Examiner trap 2: The phrase "Yoga is Sāṃkhya plus God" is repeated so often that candidates forget the second half of the addition - the entire graded psychology and method that the school actually owns.

MCQ 3. The four chapters of the base text

Match each chapter of the *Yoga-sūtra* with the material it principally carries.

Chapter	Principal material
1. absorption chapter (samādhi-pāda)	P. afflictions, action and the eight limbs
2. practice chapter (sādhana-pāda)	Q. mind-object realism and isolation
3. isolation chapter (kaivalya-pāda)	R. definition, modifications, the Lord, absorption

A. 1-P, 2-Q, 3-R B. 1-Q, 2-R, 3-P C. 1-R, 2-P, 3-Q D. 1-P, 2-R, 3-Q

Answer: C. 1-R, 2-P, 3-Q

- **A:** Assigns the afflictions and eight limbs to the absorption chapter and isolation to the practice chapter, reversing two of the three pairings entirely.
- **B:** Places mind-object realism in the absorption chapter and the definition in the practice chapter, which inverts the text's actual centre of gravity in both cases.
- **C:** Correct - the first chapter defines Yoga and treats modifications, the Lord and absorption; the second treats afflictions, action and the limbs; the fourth treats realism and isolation.
- **D:** Correctly places isolation but wrongly assigns the afflictions to the first chapter and the definition to the second, so two of three pairings fail.

Examiner trap 3: The powers chapter is quietly omitted from such lists, and candidates who have memorised only three chapter-names begin misassigning combined discipline and the extraordinary capacities.

MCQ 4. Source control over the five levels of the mind-field

Consider the following statements about the fivefold classification of mind-levels.

1. It is a five-item aphorism stated by Patañjali in the absorption chapter.
2. It is standard in Vyāsa's commentarial exposition and in the tradition that follows him.
3. Its use is nevertheless legitimate in answering the 2019 question on mind-levels.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statement 1 only, since every classification used in Yoga answers must come from the aphorisms B. Statements 2 and 3 only, because the scheme is commentarial in origin yet doctrinally standard C. Statements 1 and 3 only, as the aphorisms list the levels and the paper expected that list D. All three statements, since commentarial and aphoristic material carry identical attribution

Answer: B. Statements 2 and 3 only, because the scheme is commentarial in origin yet doctrinally standard

- **A:** Rejects a classification that the tradition genuinely uses, and asserts a sourcing rule the school never adopts, since much standard Yoga doctrine is commentarial.
- **B:** Correct - the scheme belongs to the commentarial layer beginning with Vyāsa, and it remains entirely usable provided it is attributed to that layer rather than to Patañjali.
- **C:** Accepts the legitimate use but keeps the false attribution, which is exactly the error the source-control rule exists to prevent.
- **D:** Collapses the very distinction the question tests; commentarial standing and aphoristic standing are not interchangeable when a question is source-sensitive.

Examiner trap 4: Because the fivefold scheme appears in almost every textbook without attribution, candidates promote it into the sūtra text and then defend it as though Patañjali had enumerated it.

MCQ 5. What the mind-field includes

Which statement accurately describes the constitution of the mind-field in Yoga?

A. It is the atomic internal sense through which the self contacts objects one cognition at a time B. It is the conscious principle that illuminates objects and appropriates them as its own states C. It is the gross physical brain considered as the seat of memory, emotion and decision-making D. It is the unified inner apparatus of determinative intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind

Answer: D. It is the unified inner apparatus of determinative intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind

- **A:** The atomic, partless internal sense belongs to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, where the self is a separate substance; Yoga's mind-field is composite, transformable and karmically loaded.
- **B:** The mind-field is a product of nature and therefore insentient; it appears conscious only by reflecting the witness, and appropriation is a defect rather than its definition.
- **C:** Classical Yoga does not identify the mind-field with a gross bodily organ; it is a subtle evolute of nature, and identifying it with the body confuses two levels of the scheme.
- **D:** Correct - Yoga gathers intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind into a single operative continuum, since bondage and release both concern the whole mental field.

Examiner trap 5: Candidates translate the mind-field as "mind" and then silently substitute the sensory mind alone, losing the intellect and the ego-maker that carry discrimination and appropriation.

MCQ 6. The derivation of the inner components

Which statement about the origin of the mind-field's components is stated correctly?

A. Intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind all arise directly from the lucid side of the ego-maker B. Intellect arises from the ego-maker, which in turn arises from the sensory mind's activity C. Intellect evolves first, the ego-maker from intellect, and the sensory mind from its lucid side D. All three arise directly from primordial material nature without any intermediate evolute

Answer: C. Intellect evolves first, the ego-maker from intellect, and the sensory mind from its lucid side

- **A:** This is the standard misstatement; only the sensory mind arises directly from the lucid side of the ego-maker, and the whole's lucid predominance is not a derivation of each part.
- **B:** Reverses the sequence completely, since the sensory mind is the last of the three to evolve and cannot be the source of the intellect that precedes it.
- **C:** Correct - the order runs from nature to intellect, from intellect to the ego-maker, and from the ego-maker's lucid side to the sensory mind.
- **D:** Removes the intermediate evolutes altogether, which destroys the graded evolutionary scheme Yoga inherits from Sāṃkhya and uses to place the mind-field.

Examiner trap 6: The true statement that the mind-field is lucid-predominant as a whole is converted into the false statement that each of its three components derives from lucid ego-maker.

MCQ 7. How an insentient instrument comes to seem conscious

Which statement states Yoga's reflection theory and its protective clause correctly?

A. The witness is genuinely modified by contact with the mind and thereby acquires experience B. The mind is intrinsically luminous and merely borrows its objects from the external world C. The mind and the witness fuse into a single conscious substance during every act of knowing D. The mind mirrors the witness's light, and the whole transformation occurs on the mind's side

Answer: D. The mind mirrors the witness's light, and the whole transformation occurs on the mind's side

- **A:** Contradicts the definition of the witness as unchanging; if the witness were really modified, bondage would be an alteration of it and the school's soteriology would collapse.
- **B:** Reverses the doctrine, since the mind is transparent rather than luminous and borrows both the colour of objects and the light of the witness.
- **C:** Fusion would abolish the dualism, and it would make the isolation chapter's careful separation of object, modification and witness unintelligible.
- **D:** Correct - the relation is mere proximity, with all change occurring in the mind, which is precisely what keeps the witness unaffected while bondage is experientially real.

Examiner trap 7: The crystal analogy is quoted correctly and then interpreted as though the crystal really became red, which smuggles genuine modification back into the witness.

MCQ 8. Naming the confusion at the heart of bondage

Which affliction is defined as the identification of the seer with the instrument of seeing?

A. Egoity (asmitā), the confusion of the conscious witness with the determinative intellect B. Attachment (rāga), the pursuit that follows on remembered pleasure and its repetition C. Ignorance (avidyā), the reversal that takes the non-eternal, impure and painful as their opposites D. Clinging to life (abhiniveśa), the instinctive self-preservation found even in the learned

Answer: A. Egoity (asmitā), the confusion of the conscious witness with the determinative intellect

- **A:** Correct - egoity is precisely the conflation of the seer's power with the power of the instrument of seeing, which is why the ego says "I think, I act, I suffer".
- **B:** Attachment is the memory-driven pursuit of the agreeable; it presupposes the ego-confusion but is not itself the identification of seer with instrument.
- **C:** Ignorance is the root affliction and is defined by four reversals, not by the specific seer-instrument confusion, which is its immediate derivative.
- **D:** Clinging to life is instinctive self-preservation carried by impressions; it is the fifth affliction and is notable for surviving learning, not for defining the seer-confusion.

Examiner trap 8: Ignorance and egoity are treated as interchangeable names for one confusion, which erases the root-and-derivative structure the twenty-mark question on afflictions is built on.

MCQ 9. Which mind-levels are fit for Yoga

Consider the following statements about the five levels of the mind-field.

1. Only the one-pointed and restrained levels are fully fit for authentic Yoga.
2. The dull level is a condition of calm and is therefore mildly favourable to practice.
3. The distracted level attains lucidity occasionally without sustained inward collection.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 2 and 3 only, because dullness and distraction are both partially prepared conditions B. Statement 3 only, since fitness is decided by the strength of attention rather than by its quality C. Statements 1 and 3 only, because dullness is obscuration rather than calm and is never yoga-fit D. All three statements, since every level short of restraint is a stage of graded preparation

Answer: C. Statements 1 and 3 only, because dullness is obscuration rather than calm and is never yoga-fit

- **A:** Endorses the false claim about dullness, which is ruled by the inert quality and produces torpor, delusion and confusion rather than any usable stillness.
- **B:** Drops the correct fitness rule and replaces the school's quality-based criterion with a strength-of-attention criterion the classification explicitly rejects.
- **C:** Correct - the one-pointed and restrained levels alone are fully fit, and the distracted level is exactly the condition of occasional lucidity without stable collection.
- **D:** Endorses the dullness error and additionally treats obscuration as preparation, which reverses the doctrine's assessment of the inert quality.

Examiner trap 9: A quiet, heavy, unresponsive mind is mistaken for a calm one, and the inert level is promoted into a preliminary stage of meditation.

MCQ 10. The 2019 applied classification

How does Yoga's mind-level scheme classify a scientist, a God-realised devotee and a self-realised practitioner respectively?

A. Distracted, one-pointed and restrained, since outward focus is not yet yogic restraint B. One-pointed, restrained and beyond all levels, since intense concentration is already yogic C. Scattered, distracted and one-pointed, since no living person attains the restrained level D. Restrained, one-pointed and distracted, since disciplined enquiry surpasses ordinary devotion

Answer: A. Distracted, one-pointed and restrained, since outward focus is not yet yogic restraint

- **A:** Correct - intense but outward-directed and result-attached focus is distraction; one-pointed devotion centred on the Lord is the one-pointed level; stilled modifications are the restrained level.
- **B:** Promotes the scientist on the strength of concentration alone and then invents a level beyond the fivefold scheme, which the classification does not contain.
- **C:** Denies that the restrained level is attainable, which contradicts the scheme's own statement that it is the culmination of yogic discipline rather than an ideal limit.
- **D:** Inverts the assignment by ranking analytic enquiry above devotion, whereas the criterion is the ruling quality and the stability of inward collection, not cognitive power.

Examiner trap 10: The question rewards justification rather than assignment, so candidates who name the three levels correctly but omit the ruling-quality argument still lose most of the marks.

MCQ 11. The exhaustive list of mental modifications

Which set gives the five modifications of the mind-field recognised by Patañjali?

A. Perception, inference, comparison, postulation and non-apprehension as five valid instruments B. Waking, dreaming, deep sleep, the fourth state and the turbulent state of ordinary experience C. Attachment, aversion, ignorance, egoity and the instinctive clinging to continued existence D. Valid cognition, error, verbal construction, sleep and memory, each afflicted or unafflicted

Answer: D. Valid cognition, error, verbal construction, sleep and memory, each afflicted or unafflicted

- **A:** Lists instruments of valid knowledge drawn from other schools' epistemologies; Yoga admits only three instruments, and instruments are not the same as modifications.
- **B:** Gives the Upaniṣadic and Vedāntic scheme of states of consciousness, which belongs to a different tradition and answers a different question.
- **C:** Lists the five afflictions rather than the five modifications; afflictions colour mental life whereas modifications are the forms mental life takes.
- **D:** Correct - the five modifications are exactly these, and each may be afflicted or unafflicted according to whether it sustains bondage or serves release.

Examiner trap 11: The afflictions and the modifications are both five in number, and the coincidence leads candidates to substitute one list for the other under time pressure.

MCQ 12. Sleep, valid cognition and the afflicted division

Consider the following statements about Yoga's treatment of mental modifications.

1. Sleep is a positive modification grounded on absence-content rather than an absence of modification.
2. Valid cognition is excluded from the modifications because true knowledge cannot bind.
3. The afflicted and unafflicted division qualifies modifications and not the afflictions themselves.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 1 and 2 only, since sleep leaves a trace while truth is exempt from restraint B. Statement 2 only, because the afflicted division applies equally to modifications and afflictions C. Statements 1 and 3 only, because valid cognition is itself one of the five modifications D. All three statements, since Yoga restrains only those modifications that are false or afflicted

Answer: C. Statements 1 and 3 only, because valid cognition is itself one of the five modifications

- **A:** Accepts the false exemption of valid cognition, which Yoga explicitly lists first among the five modifications precisely to deny any such exemption.
- **B:** Keeps the exemption error and adds a second one, since afflictions are inherently afflictive and can never be described as unafflicted.
- **C:** Correct - the waking report "I slept and knew nothing" establishes sleep as a positive mode, and the afflicted division qualifies modifications alone.
- **D:** Restricts restraint to false modifications, which contradicts the doctrine that what binds is form as such rather than falsity.

Examiner trap 12: The plausible principle that truth cannot bind is imported from outside, and it silently deletes Yoga's most distinctive epistemological claim.

MCQ 13. Why cessation is prescribed

Which sequence states Yoga's reason for prescribing the cessation of mental modifications?

A. Modifications are intrinsically evil, so their removal is a moral purification of the practitioner B. Modifications obscure the Lord, so their cessation permits the devotee to perceive him directly C. Modifications exhaust the mind's energy, so their cessation restores its natural cognitive power D. The mind takes the form of its object, the witness is reflected there, the form is appropriated

Answer: D. The mind takes the form of its object, the witness is reflected there, the form is appropriated

- **A:** Moralises a structural claim; Yoga's objection is not to the moral quality of mental forms but to the appropriation of any form by the witness.
- **B:** Makes the Lord the object of the whole discipline, but liberation follows discriminative discernment and the Lord is an aid rather than the terminus.
- **C:** Substitutes an energetic account for a cognitive one, whereas the school's argument turns on misidentification and not on the depletion of mental resources.
- **D:** Correct - form-taking, reflection and appropriation together make the stream of modifications the running mechanism of bondage, so restraint is causal rather than cosmetic.

Examiner trap 13: Because "restraint" sounds ascetic, candidates supply a moral or energetic justification and never state the appropriation argument the question is actually asking for.

MCQ 14. Yoga's instruments of valid knowledge

Which statement about Yoga's epistemology is accurate?

A. Yoga admits four instruments and treats yogic insight as the fourth, superior to the other three B. Yoga admits three instruments and classifies perfected yogic insight as extraordinary perception C. Yoga admits two instruments, perception and inference, following the Buddhist epistemologists D. Yoga admits six instruments and adds yogic insight as a seventh available only to practitioners

Answer: B. Yoga admits three instruments and classifies perfected yogic insight as extraordinary perception

- **A:** Inflates the count and promotes truth-bearing insight into an independent instrument, which the school declines to do even at the summit of the path.
- **B:** Correct - perception, inference and authoritative testimony are the three, and truth-bearing insight is best classified as perfected extraordinary yogic perception.
- **C:** Gives the Buddhist two-instrument count; Yoga retains authoritative testimony because scriptural authority is available to it as an orthodox school.
- **D:** Gives the Advaita six-instrument count and then adds a seventh, compounding an inherited error with an invented one.

Examiner trap 14: The impressive description of truth-bearing insight tempts candidates to award it the status of a new instrument, exactly the inflation the school refuses.

MCQ 15. The two means of restraint

Which statement about sustained practice and dispassion is correct?

A. Practice becomes firm through long, uninterrupted and devoted cultivation, and works with dispassion B. Practice alone produces restraint, while dispassion is a later consequence of successful absorption C. Dispassion alone produces restraint, since effort belongs to the active quality and must be avoided D. Practice and dispassion are alternative routes, and a practitioner adopts whichever suits temperament

Answer: A. Practice becomes firm through long, uninterrupted and devoted cultivation, and works with dispassion

- **A:** Correct - the two are jointly responsible for restraint, and practice is firmly grounded only when pursued for a long time, without interruption and with devoted seriousness.
- **B:** Makes dispassion a by-product, whereas the text makes it a co-equal means without which practice becomes a permanent tug-of-war against undiminished desire.
- **C:** Rejects effort altogether, which would leave detachment as a mood without the continuity needed to overcome the pull of accumulated impressions.
- **D:** Turns two jointly necessary means into a temperamental choice, which is precisely the reading the joint-responsibility statement excludes.

Examiner trap 15: Only one of the three conditions of firm practice is usually reproduced, so an answer that names duration but omits uninterruptedness and devoted seriousness loses easy marks.

MCQ 16. The three yogic transformations of the mind

Which set names the three specifically yogic transformations of the mind-field?

A. Transformation of property, of temporal character and of condition, applying to any substrate B. Restraint-transformation, absorption-transformation and one-pointedness-transformation C. Gross, subtle and undifferentiated transformation, corresponding to the three object-levels D. Scattered, distracted and restrained transformation, corresponding to three of the mind-levels

Answer: B. Restraint-transformation, absorption-transformation and one-pointedness-transformation

- **A:** Names the general threefold transformation applicable to any substrate of nature, which frames the yogic three but is not itself the specifically yogic set.
- **B:** Correct - impressions of restraint overpower impressions of emergence, many-pointedness gives way to unity, and similar cognitions succeed one another toward one object.
- **C:** Borrows the object-level vocabulary of the coalescence analysis and misapplies it to the theory of transformation, which concerns the mind's own changing states.
- **D:** Converts three mind-levels into transformations, confusing a classification of conditions with an account of how conditions change into one another.

Examiner trap 16: The general threefold transformation and the yogic threefold transformation are both triads, so candidates merge them into a single list of three or six items.

MCQ 17. The root affliction and its content

Which statement gives the content of ignorance as Yoga defines it?

A. Failure to have studied the aphorisms and their commentaries under a qualified teacher B. The absence of extraordinary perception, which alone discloses objects in their particularity C. Doubt about the existence of the Lord and about the authority of the scriptural tradition D. Taking the non-eternal as eternal, the impure as pure, the painful as pleasant, the non-self as self

Answer: D. Taking the non-eternal as eternal, the impure as pure, the painful as pleasant, the non-self as self

- **A:** Reduces the root affliction to a deficit of instruction, whereas Yoga insists that afflictions survive learning and are carried by impressions rather than by opinions.
- **B:** Confuses the absence of an advanced attainment with the presence of a positive misorientation; ignorance is a reversal, not a missing faculty.
- **C:** Names doubt, which is one of the nine obstacles to practice rather than the definition of the root affliction.
- **D:** Correct - these four reversals constitute ignorance, and the fourth of them is what generates egoity and, through it, the remaining afflictions.

Examiner trap 17: Ignorance is glossed as "lack of knowledge", and the four reversals - each separately markable - are replaced by a single vague sentence.

MCQ 18. Reading the four states of an affliction

A practitioner reports that a long-standing attachment is no longer felt. Which inference is warranted on Yoga's account of the four states?

A. The affliction may be dormant, attenuated or merely interrupted, so absence of feeling proves little B. The affliction has been destroyed, since afflictions are known directly and cannot hide from introspection C. The affliction has necessarily become fully active elsewhere, since afflictive force is conserved D. The affliction has ripened into fruition, since unfelt afflictions discharge themselves as experience

Answer: A. The affliction may be dormant, attenuated or merely interrupted, so absence of feeling proves little

- **A:** Correct - dormancy is seed-like and reactivable, attenuation is genuine thinning, and interruption is merely the temporary dominance of an opposing tendency.
- **B:** Assumes introspective transparency, which the four-state analysis exists to deny; a dormant affliction is precisely one that is not presently manifest.
- **C:** Invents a conservation principle the doctrine does not contain, and confuses the interrupted state with a displacement of afflictive force to another object.
- **D:** Confuses states of an affliction with the ripening of the karmic deposit, which is a separate doctrine concerning birth, life-span and experience.

Examiner trap 18: The interrupted state is read as progress, so a practitioner whose attachment is merely overridden by fear is reported as having weakened attachment.

MCQ 19. The engine of bondage

Which sequence states the causal chain from affliction to rebirth as Yoga presents it?

A. Action, affliction, deposit, fruition and rebirth, since action is what first colours the mind B. Afflictions, action, karmic deposit, fruition as birth, life-span and experience, and rebirth C. Fruition, deposit, action, afflictions and rebirth, since experience is the origin of all reaction D. Afflictions, absorption, deposit, discriminative knowledge and rebirth in a more favourable state

Answer: B. Afflictions, action, karmic deposit, fruition as birth, life-span and experience, and rebirth

- **A:** Reverses the first two links; action binds because it is already coloured by the afflictions, so affliction cannot be downstream of action.
- **B:** Correct - the chain begins in affliction, deposits through action, ripens threefold as birth, life-span and experience, and closes as renewed birth.
- **C:** Inverts the whole chain and makes experience the origin, which removes the psychological first link that gives Yoga its point of intervention.
- **D:** Inserts absorption and discriminative knowledge into the chain of bondage, whereas those are the means by which the chain is interrupted.

Examiner trap 19: Fruition is written as a single item, and the threefold specification of birth, life-span and experience - which is where the doctrinal precision lies - is omitted.

MCQ 20. The first therapy

Which set gives the three components of preparatory discipline and its stated purpose?

A. Austerity, self-study and dedication to the Lord, prescribed to thin afflictions and prepare absorption B. Restraints, observances and posture, prescribed to purify conduct before internal work begins C. Concentration, meditation and absorption, prescribed to unify attention upon a single object D. Purity, contentment and austerity, prescribed to establish the observances of the eight-limbed path

Answer: A. Austerity, self-study and dedication to the Lord, prescribed to thin afflictions and prepare absorption

- **A:** Correct - these three constitute preparatory discipline, and the text states its purpose as the attenuation of the afflictions and the cultivation of absorption.
- **B:** Names the first three limbs of the eight-limbed discipline, which is a different and larger scheme, though it overlaps with preparatory discipline at several points.
- **C:** Names the three internal limbs, which together on one object form combined discipline rather than the preparatory therapy prescribed for afflictions.
- **D:** Selects three of the five observances; austerity, self-study and dedication do belong to the observances, but purity and contentment are not part of preparatory discipline.

Examiner trap 20: Preparatory discipline and combined discipline are both three-part composites with similar names, and candidates routinely exchange one for the other.

MCQ 21. The eight limbs and what combines

Which statement about the eight-limbed discipline is correct?

A. The last five limbs are external and the first three internal, since ethics presupposes absorption B. Concentration, meditation and absorption are three names for one undifferentiated meditative state C. The first five are external limbs, and the last three applied to one object form combined discipline D. Posture is the culminating limb, since bodily steadiness is the final condition of isolation

Answer: C. The first five are external limbs, and the last three applied to one object form combined discipline

- **A:** Reverses the grouping; restraints, observances, posture, breath regulation and withdrawal are the external five, and they precede rather than presuppose the internal three.
- **B:** Collapses a graded sequence, whereas concentration is effortful fixing, meditation is sustained continuity, and absorption is the state in which the object alone shines.
- **C:** Correct - the external and internal division falls after the fifth limb, and the internal three directed at one object constitute combined discipline.
- **D:** Promotes the third limb to the summit; posture serves freedom from bodily distraction and is neither the culmination nor the goal of the discipline.

Examiner trap 21: "External" is read as "unimportant", so candidates dismiss the ethical limbs and then cannot answer why Yoga denies that meditation alone suffices.

MCQ 22. Two classifications of absorption

Which statement correctly separates the two classifications used in the absorption chapter?

A. Both lists are identical, and the four coalescences are simply Patañjali's four kinds of object-supported absorption B. The first list belongs to the powers chapter and the second to the isolation chapter, so they never interact C. Object-supported absorption is classified by object-level, and coalescence is classified by the presence of the Lord as support D. Object-supported absorption is characterised by deliberation, reflection, joy and I-am-ness; coalescence is classified by object-level and overlay

Answer: D. Object-supported absorption is characterised by deliberation, reflection, joy and I-am-ness; coalescence is classified by object-level and overlay

- **A:** This is the conflation the trap box exists to prevent; the fourfold characterisation and the four coalescences answer different questions about the same ascent.
- **B:** Misplaces both lists; they occur together in the absorption chapter, which is why their relation is a live commentarial question in the first place.
- **C:** Swaps the criteria of the two grids and introduces the Lord as a classificatory principle, which no absorption taxonomy in the chapter uses.
- **D:** Correct - one grid names the accompanying factor, the other names the object-level and whether conceptual-verbal overlay is present, and commentators map rather than identify them.

Examiner trap 22: The four coalescences are written as "the four types of samprajñāta given by Patañjali", a sentence that is fluent, familiar and wrong.

MCQ 23. Impression-residue and seedlessness

Which statement distinguishes supra-cognitive absorption from seedless absorption correctly?

- A. Supra-cognitive absorption is seedless by definition, since the cessation of modification removes all residue B. Seedless absorption precedes supra-cognitive absorption, since the object-support is lost before modifications cease
- C. Supra-cognitive absorption is defined by impression-residue; seedless absorption is the restraint of even that residue D. Both terms name deep sleep, distinguished only by whether the practitioner has previously undertaken discipline

Answer: C. Supra-cognitive absorption is defined by impression-residue; seedless absorption is the restraint of even that residue

- **A:** Equates the two terms, ignoring that the defining aphorism of supra-cognitive absorption expressly states that impressions remain as residue.
- **B:** Reverses the order and confuses the two senses of seed, since with-seed refers to object-support while seedless refers to the residual impression.
- **C:** Correct - supra-cognitive absorption is preceded by the practice of cessation and retains impression-residue, and absorption becomes seedless when even that residue is restrained.
- **D:** Assimilates both to sleep, which is one of the five modifications and therefore the opposite of the disciplined cessation of modifications.

Examiner trap 23: The word "seed" is used in two distinct senses within a few aphorisms, and candidates who track only one sense collapse two genuinely different conditions.

MCQ 24. Truth-bearing insight and extraordinary capacities

Consider the following statements about the upper reaches of the path.

1. Truth-bearing insight has a particular object as its field, unlike testimony and inference.
2. Extraordinary capacities are declared obstacles to absorption when they attract appropriation.
3. Cloud-of-dharma absorption is attained by acquiring omniscience and displaying the capacities.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

- A. Statements 1 and 3 only, since the culminating absorption is defined by completed knowledge B. Statements 1 and 2 only, because the culmination requires relinquishing interest in both C. Statement 3 only, as truth-bearing insight and the capacities belong to preparatory stages D. All three statements, since insight, power and culmination form one ascending acquisition

Answer: B. Statements 1 and 2 only, because the culmination requires relinquishing interest in both

- **A:** Accepts the acquisition reading of the culminating absorption, which reverses the doctrine that even fascination with extraordinary knowledge is relinquished there.
- **B:** Correct - insight reaches the particular where testimony and inference reach universals, capacities are obstacles when appropriated, and the culmination is defined by relinquishment.
- **C:** Demotes truth-bearing insight to a preparatory stage and endorses the acquisition reading, compounding two independent errors.
- **D:** Treats the whole upper path as a sequence of acquisitions, which is precisely the reading higher dispassion is introduced to block.

Examiner trap 24: The powers chapter is read as a catalogue of achievements rather than as a warning, so the school's own demotion of its summit attainments is never reported.

REMEDIAL DRILLS

MCQ 25. Repairing the conflated absorption lists

A candidate writes: "Patañjali gives four types of samprajñāta samādhi - savitarka, nirvitarka, savicāra and nirvicāra." What is the minimum correction?

A. Replace "four" with "two", since only the gross and subtle levels are genuinely distinguished B. Replace "samprajñāta" with "asamprajñāta", since the four named items belong beyond object-support C. Note that these four are coalescences, while object-supported absorption is characterised by deliberation, reflection, joy and I-am-ness D. Delete the sentence entirely, since Patañjali offers no classification of absorption at all

Answer: C. Note that these four are coalescences, while object-supported absorption is characterised by deliberation, reflection, joy and I-am-ness

- **A:** Leaves the category error untouched; reducing the count does not correct the attribution of the coalescence list to the fourfold characterisation.
- **B:** Moves the four items to the wrong side of the divide, since the coalescences are expressly declared with-seed and therefore belong to object-supported absorption.
- **C:** Correct - the sentence assigns the coalescence names to the fourfold characterisation, and the correction is to restore the two grids with their proper criteria.
- **D:** Overcorrects into falsehood, since the absorption chapter contains two explicit classifications and a great deal of taxonomic detail.

Examiner trap 25: Candidates who notice the error often over-correct by denying that Patañjali classifies absorption at all, losing the taxonomy the question was testing.

MCQ 26. Repairing the seedless equation

A candidate writes: "Asamprajñāta samādhi is nirbīja samādhi." Which correction is required?

A. None, since the two terms are synonyms in the aphorisms and in the commentarial tradition B. Replace both with cloud-of-dharma absorption, which is the only absorption the aphorisms name C. Add that seedless absorption is a lower stage reached before the modifications finally cease D. State that supra-cognitive absorption retains impression-residue and becomes seedless when that is restrained

Answer: D. State that supra-cognitive absorption retains impression-residue and becomes seedless when that is restrained

- **A:** Denies a distinction the aphorisms make explicitly, since one is defined by residual impression and the other by the restraint of even that residue.
- **B:** Eliminates two correctly named conditions in favour of a third, and misdescribes the aphorisms, which name several absorptions.
- **C:** Reverses the order, treating the culminating condition as a preliminary and leaving the residual impression unaccounted for.
- **D:** Correct - seedlessness is best treated as the culminating condition reached within the supra-cognitive phase, not as another name for it.

Examiner trap 26: Because both terms are negative in form, candidates assume they are two translations of one idea and never notice that they negate different things.

MCQ 27. Repairing the creator-God import

A candidate writes: "Yoga's Īśvara is the efficient cause who arranges atoms and dispenses the fruits of action." What is wrong?

A. Nothing, since Yoga adopts the Nyāya proofs of God wholesale and merely adds devotional practice B. Yoga's Lord is a special witness untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit, and is not that creator C. Yoga denies the existence of any Lord, so the whole sentence attributes a doctrine the school rejects D. Yoga's Lord is the material cause of the world, so the error lies only in the word "efficient"

Answer: B. Yoga's Lord is a special witness untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit, and is not that creator

- **A:** Attributes the Nyāya proof-set to Yoga, whose own grounds are compact and practice-facing: a special witness, unsurpassed omniscience, timeless teacherhood and the sacred syllable.
- **B:** Correct - primordial nature remains the material basis of evolution, and the Lord's stated functions are concentration-support, obstacle-removal, exemplarity and pedagogic authority.
- **C:** Denies Yoga's theism altogether, which erases the very feature that distinguishes it from classical Sāṃkhya.
- **D:** Substitutes a worse error, since making the Lord the material cause would collapse the distinction between witness and nature on which the whole system rests.

Examiner trap 27: Having learned the Nyāya proofs thoroughly, candidates transfer them to Yoga and thereby lose the precise contrast the routed 2018 question was constructed to test.

MCQ 28. Repairing the description of isolation

A candidate writes: "Kaivalya is the merger of the individual self with the Lord." What is the required correction?

A. Replace "the Lord" with "Brahman", since Yoga's terminus is non-dual identity-realisation B. Replace "merger" with "gradual approach", since the union is asymptotic rather than complete C. Accept the sentence, since devotion to the Lord is one of the means prescribed for isolation D. Replace the whole description with the isolation of the witness from nature through discriminative knowledge

Answer: D. Replace the whole description with the isolation of the witness from nature through discriminative knowledge

- **A:** Substitutes the Advaita account, which Yoga explicitly does not hold, since it retains many witnesses and has no Brahman doctrine at all.
- **B:** Retains the union framework and merely weakens it, whereas Yoga's terminus is disentanglement rather than any degree of joining.
- **C:** Confuses a means with the goal; devotion to the Lord aids concentration and removes obstacles but does not make isolation a union with him.
- **D:** Correct - isolation is aloneness, the isolation of the witness from nature and its evolutes, reached through discriminative discernment and consummated in the cloud-of-dharma absorption.

Examiner trap 28: The presence of a Lord in the system makes union language feel natural, and candidates conclude that a theistic school must have a unitive liberation.

MCQ 29. Repairing the narrowed mind-field

A candidate writes: "Citta is the internal sense, atomic and partless, by which the self perceives." What is wrong?

A. The description belongs to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika; Yoga's mind-field is the composite of intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind
B. The description is correct, since Yoga borrows its psychology from the realist schools without alteration
C. The description understates the case, since Yoga's mind-field is conscious rather than merely instrumental
D. The description is correct except that Yoga treats the internal sense as eternal rather than as produced

Answer: A. The description belongs to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika; Yoga's mind-field is the composite of intellect, ego-maker and sensory mind

- **A:** Correct - Yoga's mind-field is broad, composite, transformable and karmically loaded, whereas the atomic internal sense belongs to a school with a separate self-substance.
- **B:** Yoga's psychology is inherited from Sāṃkhya rather than from the realist schools, and the whole point of the term is to unify what Nyāya keeps apart.
- **C:** Makes the mind-field conscious, which contradicts its status as a product of nature and destroys the need for the reflection theory.
- **D:** Adds eternality to an error, whereas the mind-field is an evolute of nature and undergoes real transformation across practice.

Examiner trap 29: Cross-school revision leaves the atomic internal sense as the default meaning of "mind", and it is then carried unnoticed into a Yoga answer.

MCQ 30. Repairing the misapplied afflicted division

A candidate writes: "The five kleśas may each be kliṣṭa or akliṣṭa depending on the practitioner." What is wrong?

A. The division applies only to ignorance, since the derivative afflictions are always afflictive
B. The division applies only to those afflictions that are dormant rather than to those fully active
C. The division qualifies mental modifications; afflictions are afflictive by definition and admit no unafflicted form
D. The division is correct but incomplete, since a third neutral category also exists in the scheme

Answer: C. The division qualifies mental modifications; afflictions are afflictive by definition and admit no unafflicted form

- **A:** Grants an exemption to ignorance, which is the root affliction and the least plausible candidate for an unafflicted variety.
- **B:** Confuses the afflicted division with the four states, which describe intensity rather than moral character.
- **C:** Correct - any of the five modifications may be afflicted or unafflicted, whereas the afflictions themselves are inherently binding.
- **D:** Invents a third category the scheme does not contain, and leaves the original misapplication uncorrected.

Examiner trap 30: The two fivefold lists sit close together in revision notes, and the division that belongs to one is applied to the other without any sense of contradiction.

MCQ 31. Repairing the misplaced scientist

A candidate writes: "The scientist is ekāgra because sustained concentration is the mark of that level." What is the correct assessment?

A. The conclusion holds, since the scheme measures concentration and the scientist concentrates intensely B. The scientist is distracted, since focus remains outward-turned and result-attached without stable inward collection C. The scientist is restrained, since disciplined enquiry stills the modifications more effectively than devotion D. The scheme cannot be applied to professions at all, so no assignment of any level is defensible

Answer: B. The scientist is distracted, since focus remains outward-turned and result-attached without stable inward collection

- **A:** Adopts a strength-of-attention criterion, whereas the scheme classifies by the ruling quality and by whether the mind can remain inwardly collected.
- **B:** Correct - the distracted level is precisely occasional lucidity within a life still governed by the active quality, which describes intense outward research exactly.
- **C:** Promotes the scientist two levels and asserts a comparison the scheme does not make, since the restrained level is the arrest of all modifications.
- **D:** Refuses an application the 2019 paper itself required, and abandons the justification the question awards marks for.

Examiner trap 31: The word "one-pointed" is heard as a compliment rather than as a technical description, so the most impressive worldly mind is awarded the highest available level.

MCQ 32. Repairing the posture-and-powers confusion

A candidate writes: "Yoga is the perfection of posture, and the extraordinary powers it produces are the sign of liberation." What is wrong?

A. Posture is one of eight limbs and not the definition, and the capacities are obstacles to absorption when appropriated B. Posture is indeed the definition, but the capacities belong to preparatory discipline rather than to liberation C. Both claims are correct within the powers chapter, though the isolation chapter takes a stricter line D. Posture is the definition and the capacities are its natural fruit, so only the word "sign" is inaccurate

Answer: A. Posture is one of eight limbs and not the definition, and the capacities are obstacles to absorption when appropriated

- **A:** Correct - Yoga is defined as restraint of the modifications of the mind-field, and the capacities are declared attainments in the outward-turned state but obstacles to absorption.
- **B:** Retains the postural definition and relocates the capacities to preparatory discipline, which consists of austerity, self-study and dedication to the Lord.
- **C:** Sets the chapters against each other, whereas the demotion of the capacities is stated within the powers chapter itself.
- **D:** Keeps both errors and quibbles over a single word, leaving the definition and the doctrinal status of the capacities uncorrected.

Examiner trap 32: Modern postural practice supplies the default meaning of the word "yoga", and it survives into the answer as a definition that the aphorisms never give.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Ownership. Yoga owns seven primary parts in the 2018-2025 Paper I corpus, one in each year from 2019 to 2025; 2018 is the only year with no primary-owned Yoga part. One further question is routed here and fully solved because Yoga's proof of God is expressly the comparative subject under examination, although its primary owner is Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika.

Status of the model answers. UPSC Mains publishes no official answer key or model answer. Every solution below is independent learner practice written to the stated word band and directive, and it is never presented as an official key.

VERIFIED PREVIOUS-YEAR QUESTIONS - 8 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Solved PYQ 1 - 2019, Question 7(b), 15 marks

Printed question. How would Yoga philosophy comprehend the Citta-levels of a Scientist, a God-realized Devotee and a Self-realized Yogi? Justify your answer.

Directive read. "Comprehend" and "justify" asks for a classification *and* the ground of each assignment. Bare labelling earns very little.

Model answer (282 words).

Yoga classifies the mind-field (**citta**) into five operative levels according to the constituent quality that rules it: scattered (**kṣipta**, active quality dominant), dull (**mūḍha**, inert quality dominant), distracted (**vikṣipta**, mixed with occasional lucidity), one-pointed (**ekāgra**, lucid quality dominant) and restrained (**niruddha**, all modifications arrested). Only the last two are fully fit for authentic Yoga. The scheme is standard in Vyāsa's commentarial exposition rather than a five-item aphorism of Patañjali, and it should be used with that attribution.

A scientist absorbed in an empirical problem displays formidable attention, but the attention is outward-directed, result-dependent and interrupted by ambition, anxiety and sensory dispersion. Lucidity flashes; the active quality still rules the life in which it flashes. On Yoga's own criterion - ruling quality and stability of inward collection, not force of attention - such a mind is **distracted**. This is the decisive judgement of the question, because it denies that intellectual excellence is by itself a yogic accomplishment.

A God-realised devotee whose mind is one-pointedly centred on the Lord (**Īśvara**) has a lucid-dominant mind resting on a single support. Dedication to the Lord (**Īśvara-praṇidhāna**) both stabilises the mind-field and removes the nine obstacles (**antarāya**), so the devotee occupies the **one-pointed** level and is genuinely fit for the discipline.

A self-realised practitioner in whom the modifications have been stilled occupies the **restrained** level - not blank unconsciousness, but the consummation of disciplined inwardness correlated with the highest absorption and with the approach to isolation (**kaivalya**).

The justification is therefore one principle applied three times: the levels grade minds by which quality governs them and by whether inward collection is sustained. On that grading a distracted genius sits below a one-pointed devotee, and only stabilised discrimination reaches the summit.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2020, Question 5(b), 10 marks

Printed question. Explain the difference between Samprajñāta Samādhi and Asamprajñāta Samādhi.

Directive read. "Explain the difference" requires exact definitions and the precise mark of distinction, not a general description of meditation.

Model answer (181 words).

Absorption (**samādhi**) is the state in which the mind-field becomes radically unified and transparent. Patañjali distinguishes two principal forms.

Object-supported absorption (**samprajñāta**) retains a cognitive support; a subtle seed of cognition remains, and it is therefore called with-seed (**sabīja**). *Yoga-sūtra* 1.17 characterises it by four accompanying factors - gross deliberation (**vitarka**), subtle reflection (**vicāra**), refined lucid joy (**ānanda**) and bare I-am-ness (**asmitā**). The separate coalescence analysis of *Yoga-sūtra* 1.42-1.44 further classifies object-absorption as savitarkā and nirvitarkā for gross objects and savicārā and nirvicārā for subtle objects; these two grids must not be conflated.

Supra-cognitive absorption (**asamprajñāta**) is defined at *Yoga-sūtra* 1.18 as preceded by the practice of the idea of cessation and as having impression-residue (**saṃskāra-śeṣa**). No object stands forth as support; the modifications have ceased, yet latent impressions may remain.

The difference is therefore twofold: presence or absence of an object-support, and the reduction of mental activity to a bare residue. A further condition follows: when even that residue is restrained, absorption becomes seedless (**nirbīja**, *Yoga-sūtra* 1.51). Supra-cognitive absorption is not sleep, which is itself one of the five modifications.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2021, Question 6(a), 20 marks

Printed question. Explain with reference to Yoga Philosophy, the nature of kleśas. How does the removal of these lead to kaivalya?

Directive read. Two demands: a doctrinal exposition of the afflictions, then a *causa*/ demonstration that their removal yields isolation. The second half must be a mechanism, not a restatement.

Model answer (358 words).

The afflictions (**kleśa**) are not surface thoughts but the causal colourings of mental life that generate binding action and sustain the cycle of rebirth. Yoga lists five: ignorance (**avidyā**), egoity (**asmitā**), attachment (**rāga**), aversion (**dveṣa**) and clinging to life (**abhiniveśa**). Ignorance is the root and the field in which the rest grow; it is defined as taking the non-eternal for the eternal, the impure for the pure, the painful for the pleasant and the non-self for the self. Egoity is the identification of the seer with the instrument of seeing. Attachment and aversion follow remembered pleasure and remembered pain. Clinging to life is instinctive and, significantly, present even in the learned - which shows that afflictions are carried by impressions rather than by opinions.

Afflictions operate at four intensities: dormant (**prasupta**), attenuated (**tanu**), interrupted (**vicchinna**) and fully active (**udāra**). Dormancy is not destruction, and interruption is merely the temporary dominance of an opposing tendency, so the absence of felt affliction is weak evidence of progress.

Their removal leads to isolation through a stated causal chain. Afflictions motivate action; action deposits a karmic store (**karmāśaya**) rooted in the afflictions; the store ripens as a threefold fruition (**vipāka**) of birth (**jāti**), life-span (**āyus**) and experience (**bhoga**); and that experience generates fresh reaction, closing the loop in renewed birth. Because the first link is psychological, the engine can be jammed at its source.

Yoga's therapy is graded accordingly. Preparatory discipline (**kriyā-yoga**) - austerity (**tapas**), self-study (**svādhyāya**) and dedication to the Lord (**Īśvara-praṇidhāna**) - is prescribed expressly to attenuate the afflictions and prepare absorption. The eight-limbed discipline purifies conduct, embodiment and attention. Meditation burns the subtle forms of affliction that ethical restraint alone cannot reach. As the mind-field is purified, absorption stabilises and discriminative discernment (**viveka-khyāti**) matures.

With higher dispassion (**para-vairāgya**) the practitioner ceases to crave even powers and exalted states, and cloud-of-dharma absorption (**dharmamegha-samādhi**) rains down the fullness of discernment. Afflictions and binding action cease; the constituent qualities undergo involution (**pratiprasava**) for that witness; and consciousness abides

in its own nature (**svarūpa-pratiṣṭhā**). This is isolation (**kaivalya**) - not union, not annihilation, but the ending of a misidentification whose machinery has been dismantled at the root.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2022, Question 5(c), 10 marks

Printed question. Discuss the nature and different stages of Samādhi as per Pātañjala yoga and examine the role of Īśvara in it.

Directive read. Two directives in one part: "discuss" the taxonomy, then "examine" the Lord's role - which requires a judgement about how far that role extends.

Model answer (189 words).

Absorption (**samādhi**) in Pātañjala Yoga is the highest refinement of attention, not passivity, and it is the threshold of liberating discernment. Object-supported absorption (**samprajñāta**) retains a support and is with-seed (**sabīja**); *Yoga-sūtra* 1.17 characterises it by deliberation, reflection, joy and bare I-am-ness, while *Yoga-sūtra* 1.42-1.44 separately classifies coalescence (**samāpatti**) as savitarkā and nirvitarkā for gross objects and savicārā and nirvicārā for subtle ones. The clarity of subtle coalescence yields truth-bearing insight (**ṛtambharā prajñā**). Supra-cognitive absorption (**asamprajñāta**) has impression-residue; when even that is restrained, absorption is seedless (**nirbīja**); cloud-of-dharma absorption (**dharmamegha-samādhi**) is the culmination.

The Lord (**Īśvara**) is a special conscious witness (**puruṣa-viśeṣa**) untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit, denoted by the sacred syllable (**praṇava**). Dedication to him (**Īśvara-praṇidhāna**) is a positive observance, a component of preparatory discipline and an independent means to absorption; it stabilises the mind-field and removes the nine obstacles (**antarāya**).

Examined strictly, however, his role is instrumental and not constitutive. He is neither material cause nor the Nyāya creator, and he does not bestow isolation; liberation still follows the practitioner's own discriminative discernment. Yoga's theism is therefore real but bounded - practice-enabling rather than creation-first.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2023, Question 7(c), 15 marks

Printed question. Explain Citta and its modifications in the philosophy of Yoga. Why does Yoga philosophy prescribe cessation of modifications of Citta? Give reasons in support of your answer.

Directive read. Three demands in sequence: define the mind-field, list and explain the modifications, and supply reasons for cessation. The third demand is an argument, so it should be numbered.

Model answer (294 words).

The mind-field (**citta**) is the unified inner apparatus of determinative intellect (**buddhi**), ego-maker (**ahaṁkāra**) and sensory mind (**manas**). It is a product of primordial material nature and therefore insentient (**jaḍa**), yet as a working whole it is lucid-predominant and so transparent enough to take the form of objects and to mirror the conscious witness (**puruṣa**). It is the psychological instrument of experience, not the self.

A modification (**citta-vṛtti**) is any operative form the mind-field assumes. Patañjali classifies them exhaustively as five: valid cognition (**pramāṇa**) through perception, inference and authoritative testimony; error (**viparyaya**), as in taking nacre for silver; verbal construction (**vikalpa**), as in "the horn of a hare"; sleep (**nidrā**), a positive mode grounded on absence-content and evidenced by the waking report "I slept and knew nothing"; and memory (**smṛti**), the non-loss and re-presentation of experienced content. Each may be afflicted (**kliṣṭa**) or unafflicted (**akliṣṭa**).

Cessation is prescribed for five connected reasons. First, the mind-field by nature takes the form of whatever it attends to. Second, the witness's consciousness is reflected in that form. Third, in the absence of discriminative knowledge the changing form is appropriated in the first person - "I know", "I suffer", "I desire", "I remember". Fourth, the stream of modifications is therefore not a symptom of bondage but its running mechanism. Fifth, restraining the stream uncovers the already-free nature of the seer, as a pool reflects the sky faithfully once its ripples settle.

Two qualifications complete the answer. Restraint (**nirodha**) is revelatory rather than destructive: it removes concealment, not consciousness, and does not annihilate the mind as a substance. And valid cognition is included among the modifications deliberately, because what binds the seer is not the falsity of a mental form but the fact that it is a form at all.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2024, Question 7(b), 15 marks

Printed question. "So long as there are changes and modifications in citta, the self is reflected therein, and, in the absence of discriminative knowledge, identifies itself with them." Present an appraisal of Yoga Soteriology in the light of the above statement.

Directive read. "Appraisal" is evaluative. The statement must first be unpacked doctrinally, then weighed - strengths, weaknesses and what remains contested.

Model answer (286 words).

The quoted statement compresses Yoga's entire diagnosis. The mind-field really changes, since Yoga inherits real transformation (**pariṇāmavāda**) and recognises transformations of restraint, absorption and one-pointedness in a persisting substrate. Because the mind-field is lucid-predominant and transparent, the witness's light is reflected in it (**pratibimba**); and because the relation is mere proximity (**sannidhi-mātra**), the whole transformation occurs on the mind's side while the witness remains unchanged (**aparīṇāmin**). Where discriminative discernment (**viveka-khyāti**) is absent, the borrowed light is read as the mind's own and the witness's witnesshood is read as agency - the conflation named egoity (**asmitā**).

Appraised positively, the soteriology is strong. It supplies a rigorous phenomenology of mental process - modification, memory, sleep, impression, affliction, absorption. It integrates psychology, ethics and metaphysics, since restraints, moral causation and mental restraint form one system. It offers an operational path rather than speculation: practice and dispassion, preparatory discipline, the eight limbs and graded absorption. And the isolation chapter's realist arguments against consciousness-only idealism show genuine metaphysical commitment.

The weaknesses are equally locatable. Mere proximity names the relation between an inactive witness and an active nature more clearly than it explains it, and Advaita and Nyāya press exactly there. The Lord's explanatory role is limited: he aids practice but is neither creator nor material cause nor the giver of isolation. And the value of contentless pure consciousness can be questioned by schools that define fulfilment through knowledge, relation, bliss or activity.

Two matters remain genuinely contested: the commentarial status of joy and I-am-ness within the absorption taxonomy, and whether isolation is austere aloneness or blissful self-abidance. The balanced verdict is that Yoga's account of how bondage operates is more secure than its account of how the two principles are related at all.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2025, Question 7(b), 15 marks

Printed question. Explain the nature of God and its role in Kaivalya in yoga philosophy.

Directive read. "Explain the nature of God and its role" requires the definition first and then a precise statement of how far that role extends - including what it does not do.

Model answer (263 words).

Yoga defines the Lord (**Īśvara**) as a special conscious witness (**puruṣa-viśeṣa**) untouched by affliction (**kleśa**), action (**karma**), fruition (**vipāka**) and karmic deposit (**āśaya**). In him lies the unsurpassed seed of omniscience; he is the teacher even of the ancients, being unconditioned by time; and he is denoted by the sacred syllable (**praṇava**, OM), whose repetition with contemplation of its meaning is a canonical practice. He is special, not different in kind: he belongs to the category of conscious witness, and his distinction is that he was never entangled. This admission is what makes Yoga theistic Sāṃkhya (**seśvara-sāṃkhya**) against Sāṃkhya's Godless tendency.

His positive roles are five: object of meditation, aid through dedication (**Īśvara-praṇidhāna**), remover of the nine obstacles (**antarāya**), perfect model of untouched status, and timeless teacher-principle anchoring transmission.

His role in isolation (**kaivalya**) must be stated with precision. Isolation is the aloneness of the witness from primordial nature and its evolutes, reached through discriminative discernment (**viveka-khyāti**), matured by higher dispassion (**para-vairāgya**) and consummated in cloud-of-dharma absorption (**dharmamegha-samādhi**), after which the constituent qualities undergo involution (**pratiprasava**) and consciousness abides in its own nature. The Lord assists this process by stabilising the mind-field and clearing obstacles, but he does not grant isolation as an external gift.

Four negations therefore complete the answer: he is not the material cause; he is not the Nyāya creator and efficient cause of the world-order; he is not a saviour who bestows liberation arbitrarily; and he is not a substitute for discernment. The exact formula is that the Lord is **instrumental, not constitutive**, in liberation - not redundant, but

non-final.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2018, Question 6(a), 20 marks (routed; primary owner Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika)

Printed question. How do the Naiyāyikas prove the existence of God? Do the Yoga philosophers prove God in the same way? If yes, how? And if no, why? Give reasons for your answer.

Why it is solved here. The comparison is the question's subject, and its second half is entirely Yoga-owned material. The Nyāya half is summarised only as far as the comparison requires; the full Nyāya proof-set belongs to its own owner.

Model answer (383 words).

The Naiyāyikas argue for God as the efficient cause (**nimitta-kāraṇa**) of the world-order. Their proofs are inferential and cosmological in character: effects such as the composite world require an intelligent maker; atoms, being unintelligent, cannot combine without an intelligent director; the moral order requires an administrator who dispenses the fruits of action, since unseen merit cannot by itself allot results; the authority of scripture requires a trustworthy author; and the gradation of knowledge and power terminates in an omniscient and omnipotent being. Later Nyāya develops these into a systematic set of inferences to a creator who is efficient but not material cause.

Yoga does not prove God in this way, and the difference is structural rather than incidental. Patañjali's own grounds are compact and practice-facing. The Lord (**Īśvara**) is defined as a special conscious witness (**puruṣa-viśeṣa**) untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit; in him lies the unsurpassed seed of omniscience; he is the teacher of the ancients, unlimited by time; and he is denoted by the sacred syllable (**praṇava**), through which he becomes a contemplative support. These are characterisations of a being fit to be meditated upon, not inferences from the world to its maker.

The reasons for the divergence are three. First, ontology: Yoga inherits Sāṃkhya's dualism, in which primordial material nature (**prakṛti**) is the material basis of all evolution, so no creator is required to explain the world's arising. Second, method: Yoga's problem is practical - minds cannot hold still, obstacles derail practice, the ego resists surrender - and a never-entangled conscious witness is the most effective object such a mind can take. Third, soteriology: liberation follows discriminative discernment (**viveka-khyāti**), so the Lord is instrumental rather than constitutive and cannot be argued for as the necessary cause of release.

A source caution belongs here. Later Yoga commentators do add more theoretical arguments - from scripture, from maximal degrees of knowledge and power, and from the need for intelligent coordination of witness and nature - and these move closer to Nyāya's style. But the full creator-and-administrator proof-set should not be projected back onto Patañjali.

The verdict: both schools are theistic and both are realist, but Nyāya's God is proved as the world's efficient cause and moral governor, while Yoga's Lord is described as a uniquely free witness and employed as an unequalled aid to concentration.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

These six questions are written in the style and directive-vocabulary of the paper. They are original practice items, not previous-year questions.

Original 1 - 10 marks

Question. Explain why Yoga includes valid cognition among the modifications of citta that must be restrained. Answer in about 175 words.

Model answer (168 words).

Yoga classifies all mental events into five modifications, and valid cognition (**pramāṇa**) - through perception, inference and authoritative testimony - is listed first. Its inclusion is deliberate, not careless.

The school's diagnosis is that the conscious witness (**puruṣa**) is misidentified with the forms the mind-field assumes. What binds is therefore *form*, not falsity. A true cognition is an accurate form and remains a form; the witness can appropriate it exactly as it appropriates an error, saying "I know" with the same misplaced first person.

Yoga nevertheless does not abolish cognition at once. Any modification may be afflicted (**kliṣṭa**) or unafflicted (**akliṣṭa**), and unafflicted valid cognition - of impermanence, of the distinction between witness and nature - is therapeutically indispensable. Even truth-bearing insight (**ṛtambharā prajñā**) works by producing an impression that blocks lower impressions.

But a ladder is climbed and left behind. When the unafflicted modification has done its work, it too must subside; and when even its impression is restrained, absorption becomes seedless. Restraint is thus revelatory, not a devaluation of truth.

Original 2 - 10 marks

Question. Discuss the significance of the claim that abhiniveśa is present even in the learned. Answer in about 175 words.

Model answer (168 words).

Clinging to life (**abhiniveśa**) is the fifth affliction, ordinarily expressed as fear of death. Yoga adds that it is found even in the learned, and this qualification carries substantial doctrinal weight.

First, it establishes that afflictions are not beliefs. If clinging were an intellectual error, instruction would remove it. Its survival in the learned shows that it is carried by impressions (**saṃskāra**) and latent tendencies (**vāsanā**) rather than by opinions.

Second, it justifies Yoga's method against a purely argumentative rival. If discriminative knowledge could be produced by exposition alone, the eight-limbed discipline would be superfluous. The claim therefore explains why Yoga is *Sāṃkhya made trainable*.

Third, it explains the four states of affliction. A learned person may report no fear, yet the affliction may be dormant (**prasupta**) or merely interrupted (**vicchinna**) by a stronger tendency; only meditative burning of the subtle form and finally discriminative discernment destroy the seed.

The claim thus links Yoga's psychology, its method and its critique of merely doctrinal knowledge in a single observation.

Original 3 - 15 marks

Question. Examine the view that Yoga's reflection theory succeeds as phenomenology but not as metaphysics. Answer in about 275 words.

Model answer (275 words).

Yoga's reflection theory holds that the mind-field (**citta**), being lucid-predominant and transparent though insentient (**jaḍa**), mirrors the light of the conscious witness (**puruṣa**), while the witness, being unchanging (**aparīṇāmin**), remains untouched. The resulting conflation of the seer's power with the instrument's power is egoity (**asmitā**), and the relation is described as mere proximity (**sannidhi-mātra**).

As phenomenology the theory is impressive. It explains the unity of an experience that seems to have a single conscious owner while its components are distributed across an object, a mental modification and a witness. It explains why bondage feels total and why liberation can nevertheless be described as a correction rather than a rescue. It generates a workable therapy, since the misreading occurs in the instrument and the instrument can be disciplined. And it supplies exact analogies - the crystal coloured by a nearby flower, the magnet moving iron by presence alone.

As metaphysics it is more exposed. Reflection normally presupposes some real relation between mirror and original; if the two principles are ontologically disjoint, the relation is precisely what has not been explained. Saying that all transformation occurs on the mind's side protects the witness but relocates rather than answers the difficulty. Advaita presses by collapsing the duality into one consciousness; Nyāya presses by making consciousness an adventitious property of a substantial self; and the isolation chapter's own realist argument, that an object is known when the mind is coloured by it, reproduces the same puzzle at the object-end.

The examined verdict is therefore that mere proximity names the relation more clearly than it explains it - which is a real limitation, though not a refutation of the phenomenology it protects.

Original 4 - 15 marks

Question. Distinguish clearly between the two classifications of samādhi in the Samādhi-pāda, and explain why their conflation damages an answer. Answer in about 275 words.

Model answer (255 words).

The absorption chapter uses two classifications, applied to one meditative ascent by different criteria.

The first, at *Yoga-sūtra* 1.17, characterises object-supported absorption (**samprajñāta**) by four accompanying factors: gross deliberation (**vitarka**), subtle reflection (**vicāra**), refined lucid joy (**ānanda**) and bare I-am-ness (**asmitā**). Two of these require protection: the joy is a purified meditative affect attached to the lucid quality, not ordinary pleasure; and the I-am-ness is not the binding affliction but an extremely subtle objectification of the I-sense.

The second, at *Yoga-sūtra* 1.42-1.44, classifies coalescence (**samāpatti**) by object-level and by conceptual-verbal overlay: savitarkā and nirvitarkā for gross (**sthūla**) objects, savicārā and nirvicārā for subtle (**sūkṣma**) objects, the *nir*-members being purified of the word-object-knowledge construction. *Yoga-sūtra* 1.45 extends the subtle domain to the undifferentiated (**aliṅga**), and 1.46 declares all of these with-seed (**sabīja**).

Conflation damages an answer in three ways. Factually, it produces the false sentence that Patañjali lists savitarka, nirvitarka, savicāra and nirvicāra as the four kinds of object-supported absorption, when the sūtra's own fourfold characterisation is different. Structurally, it destroys the distinction between *what accompanies* an absorption and *what it rests on*, which is the very distinction a question on stages is testing. Consequentially, it obscures the terminological trap around "seed": with-seed at 1.46 means with object-support, whereas seedless (**nirbīja**) at 1.51 means without the residual impression, so losing an object-support does not by itself make an absorption seedless.

The safe formulation is that commentators *map* the two grids without identifying them, and that the mapping of joy and I-am-ness remains commentarily disputed.

Original 5 - 20 marks

Question. Critically examine the claim that Yoga is merely a practical discipline built on a borrowed metaphysics. Answer in about 375 words.

Model answer (345 words).

The claim has an obvious basis. Yoga accepts Sāṃkhya's dualism of conscious witness (**puruṣa**) and primordial material nature (**prakṛti**), the three constituent qualities, the twenty-five principles (**tattva**), real transformation (**pariṇāmavāda**) and liberation by discrimination. It re-argues none of these. The tradition's own labels - Sāṃkhya-exposition and theistic Sāṃkhya (**seśvara-sāṃkhya**) - record the debt openly.

Three considerations nonetheless defeat the word "merely".

First, Yoga owns a substantial body of doctrine. The mind-field (**citta**) as a unified apparatus, the fivefold classification of modifications, the afflicted and unafflicted division, the five afflictions with their four states, the moral causation of action and fruition, the eight-limbed discipline, the two absorption taxonomies, truth-bearing insight, cloud-of-dharma absorption and isolation are not restatements of Sāṃkhya but Yoga's own subject matter.

Second, Yoga is metaphysically committed in its own right. The isolation chapter contains a genuine realist polemic against consciousness-only idealism: an object is not dependent on a single mind, since it would otherwise vanish when unattended; the mind is not self-illuminating because it is itself something seen for the witness; the mind cannot be both lamp and illuminated object in one act; and knowledge occurs when the mind is coloured (**uparakta**) by an object standing outside the cognition. A praxis manual does not argue like this.

Third, the admission of the Lord (**Īśvara**) is a doctrinal difference, not decoration. A special conscious witness untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit changes the psychological and devotional resources of the path, even though the ontology stays dualist.

The critical qualifications must nevertheless be conceded. Yoga adds nothing to the account of what ultimately exists; its Lord is explanatorily limited, being neither material cause nor creator nor the giver of isolation; and it inherits, unresolved, the interaction problem between an inactive witness and an active nature.

The examined verdict is therefore that Yoga is not derivative but complementary. Sāṃkhya supplies the metaphysical grammar; Yoga turns it into a disciplined technology of liberation with a subtle moral psychology, a graded meditative epistemology and a defended realism - while remaining vulnerable at exactly the joint its parent school left open.

Original 6 - 20 marks

Question. Analyse the causal mechanism by which Yoga claims that disciplined attention can end rebirth, and assess how far the claim is defensible. Answer in about 375 words.

Model answer (360 words).

Yoga's claim depends on a chain whose first link is psychological. The afflictions (**kleśa**) - ignorance, egoity, attachment, aversion and clinging to life - motivate action; action deposits a karmic store (**karmāśaya**) that is rooted in the afflictions (**kleśa-mūla**); that store ripens as a threefold fruition (**vipāka**) of birth (**jāti**), life-span (**āyus**) and experience (**bhoga**); and the experience generates fresh reaction, closing the loop. Continuity is carried by impressions (**saṃskāra**) and latent tendencies (**vāsanā**), which is why the cycle is self-reinforcing rather than merely repetitive.

The intervention follows from the structure. Because action binds by being coloured, the target is the colouring rather than the acting - which is what the fourfold classification of action as white, black, mixed and neither-white-nor-black records. Preparatory discipline (**kriyā-yoga**) attenuates the afflictions; the eight limbs remove gross disturbance in conduct, embodiment and sense; meditation burns subtle forms that ethical restraint cannot reach; absorption stabilises; and discriminative discernment (**viveka-khyāti**) destroys the seed. Cloud-of-dharma absorption (**dharmamegha-samādhi**) marks the end of afflictions and binding action, after which the constituent qualities undergo involution (**pratiprasava**) for that witness.

The transformation-doctrine supplies the missing premise: the mind-field really changes across practice, in transformations of restraint, absorption and one-pointedness, upon a persisting substrate (**dharmin**). Without a bearer, accumulation and graded acquisition would be unintelligible.

How far is this defensible? Internally it is coherent and unusually well-integrated: psychology, ethics and soteriology are one system, and the burnt-seed image answers the scale objection by distinguishing seeds of future bondage from an already-moving momentum, as a potter's wheel turns after the push stops.

The pressures are three. The Buddhist momentarist can reconstruct continuity through a causal series without a substrate, so the persisting mind is a postulate rather than a demonstration. The witness-nature relation remains named as mere proximity rather than explained. And the whole chain presupposes a morally ordered cosmos in which subtle mental causes ripen beyond a single episode of experience - a presupposition the Cārvāka denies and Yoga can defend only by appeal to disciplined extraordinary perception, which is not publicly checkable.

The assessment: the mechanism is impressively economical given its premises, and it is those premises rather than the mechanism that remain contestable.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Prerequisite before this block is usable

Nothing in this block is needed for a complete 10-, 15- or 20-mark answer on any question the 2018-2025 corpus has asked. The Basic block above is answer-complete on its own. Use these three modules only in the *evaluative* paragraph of a fifteen- or twenty-mark answer, and only after the core exposition is finished. One enrichment move is the maximum; two look like padding.

The rule of thumb: if removing the sentence would leave the answer incomplete, the sentence belonged in the core and should have been written there instead.

ADVANCED MODULE 1 - Is the Lord philosophically necessary to Yoga?

The issue. Does Yoga *need* the Lord (*Īśvara*) to complete its philosophy, or is he mainly a privileged practical aid within an ontology that could stand without him?

The two readings. A stronger theistic reading treats the Lord as central to Yoga's distinctive identity, since the admission of a special conscious witness is precisely what separates the school from Godless Sāṃkhya and supplies its devotional and pedagogic resources. A pragmatic reading holds that the ontology is basically Sāṃkhyan and that the Lord functions primarily as an unsurpassed support for concentration and an obstacle-remover.

The objection. If liberation finally depends on discriminative discernment (*viveka-khyāti*), the Lord appears dispensable: everything he supplies is facilitative, and a practitioner who attains discernment by other means attains isolation nonetheless.

The reply. Yoga can concede that the Lord is instrumental rather than constitutive while still insisting that the instrument is uniquely powerful. Dedication to him is at once a positive observance, a component of preparatory discipline and an independent means to absorption - a triple role no other support carries - and the aphorisms present him as the one witness demonstrably untouched by affliction, action, fruition and deposit.

Where the pressure remains. The traditional Yoga case for the Lord's *necessity* is weaker than Nyāya's creator-argument, because Yoga cannot appeal to the world's need for an intelligent maker without abandoning primordial nature as material basis. Mīmāṃsā presses from the other side, arguing that a non-creator Lord is otiose.

Source trail. Patañjali, *Yoga-sūtra*; Vyāsa, *Yoga-bhāṣya*; and modern expositions of the sūtras.

One-line exam use. "Whether the Lord is necessary or only uniquely useful remains disputed; the safe claim is that he is instrumental, not constitutive."

ADVANCED MODULE 2 - How sharply should the upper absorptions be distinguished?

The issue. Is supra-cognitive absorption (*asamprajñāta*) simply seedless cessation, and how sharply should it be distinguished from cloud-of-dharma absorption (*dharmamegha-samādhi*)?

The two readings. Some commentarial readings compress the upper stages, treating supra-cognitive, seedless and cloud-of-dharma absorption as substantially one condition described from different angles. Others keep fine distinctions between cessation with impression-residue, the restraint of even that residue, and the final culmination in which afflictions and binding action cease.

The objection. These refinements look like scholastic overgrowth: the sūtras are compressed, the distinctions are drawn largely by later hands, and no practical consequence obviously follows from choosing one reading.

The reply. For UPSC they are optional, but they earn their place because they explain why "seedless" does not always mean "already final" in one flat sense. The core distinction - that *Yoga-sūtra* 1.18 defines supra-cognitive absorption by impression-residue and *Yoga-sūtra* 1.51 defines seedlessness by the restraint of that residue - is Basic material and is not optional; only the further question of how cloud-of-dharma absorption relates to both belongs here.

Where the pressure remains. Any position taken is a reconstruction. The honest register is to report the compression and the fine-grained readings as alternatives rather than to adjudicate.

Source trail. Patañjali, *Yoga-sūtra*; Vyāsa, *Yoga-bhāṣya*; Vācaspati Miśra, *Tattvavaiśārādī*.

One-line exam use. "Commentators differ over whether the upper absorptions are one condition variously described or genuinely distinct stages."

ADVANCED MODULE 3 - What liberates: absorption or knowledge?

The issue. In Yoga, what does the liberating work - meditative absorption itself, or the discriminative knowledge that absorption matures?

The two readings. An absorption-heavy reading treats meditative cessation as decisive, since the founding aphorism defines Yoga by restraint and the whole practical apparatus aims at it. A cognition-heavy reading treats absorption as serving discriminative discernment, which does the liberating work; on this reading Yoga is cognitivist at the summit exactly as Sāṃkhya is.

The objection. If knowledge liberates, Yoga collapses into Sāṃkhya with a devotional supplement, and the eight limbs become psychologically useful but philosophically inessential.

The reply. Yoga answers that its distinctive psychology explains how such discriminative knowledge is actually stabilised and made existentially efficacious. Sāṃkhya can argue the distinction between witness and nature; it does not explain why an argued distinction fails to dislodge afflictions carried in impressions. Clinging to life surviving in the learned is Yoga's own evidence for this.

Where the pressure remains. The reply concedes that the *content* of liberating knowledge is Sāṃkhyan and defends only its *stabilisation*, which some critics will regard as a difference of psychology rather than of philosophy.

Source trail. Patañjali, *Yoga-sūtra*; Vyāsa, *Yoga-bhāṣya*; standard modern surveys of Indian philosophy.

One-line exam use. "Absorption is indispensable but instrumental; what liberates is discriminative discernment matured through it."

What not to over-study

- Exhaustive commentarial enumerations of absorption sub-levels.
- The full catalogue of extraordinary capacities in the powers chapter.
- Specialist disputes about the dating and layering of the sūtra collection.
- Sectarian devotional overlays that turn Yoga into a devotional system.
- Modern wellness and public-health claims about postural practice, which are not evidence about Pātañjala metaphysics.

When this block would stop being optional

These modules would be promoted into core material if a future paper asked directly whether the Lord is necessary to Yoga, whether cloud-of-dharma absorption differs from supra-cognitive absorption in a philosophically weighty way, or whether knowledge or absorption is primary in liberation. Until then, they belong in the evaluative paragraph and nowhere else.

Three genuinely contested matters to report as contested

1. **The commentarial status of joy and I-am-ness.** Whether they are independent coalescences, supervening aspects of the subtle stage, or higher refinements beyond the four named coalescences remains debated. Their presence in the fourfold characterisation of object-supported absorption is not in doubt; only their mapping is.
2. **The character of isolation.** Whether isolation should be described as blissful self-abidance or as austere aloneness is interpreted differently by expositors, and the school's own texts admit both registers.
3. **The unity and layering of the textual tradition.** The historical composition of the sūtra collection and its relation to the commentarial tradition are open scholarly questions. Do not build an answer on a dating claim.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Compressed revision notes covering every session. Read the seventeen parts in order for a full recall pass, or use any single part as a targeted refresher. The final entry is the complete ASCII master flow diagram for the topic.

A. What Yoga is, and what it inherits

- **Definition.** Yoga is the restraint of the modifications of the mind-field (*yogaś-citta-vṛtti-nirodhaḥ*, *Yoga-sūtra* 1.2).
- **Consequence.** Then the seer abides in its own nature (*tadā draṣṭuḥ svarūpe'vasthānam*, 1.3).
- **Alternative.** Otherwise the seer takes the form of the modifications (1.4). That is bondage.
- **Inherited from Sāṃkhya:** many conscious witnesses, one primordial material nature, three constituent qualities, twenty-five principles, pre-existence of the effect, real transformation, bondage as non-discrimination and release by discrimination.
- **Owned by Yoga:** mind-field psychology, the five modifications, the afflicted/unafflicted division, practice and dispassion, the five afflictions, moral causation of action, the eight limbs, the absorption taxonomies, combined discipline, the Lord, discriminative discernment, cloud-of-dharma absorption and isolation.
- **Labels.** Sāṃkhya-exposition (*sāṃkhya-pravacana*); theistic Sāṃkhya (*seśvara-sāṃkhya*) against Sāṃkhya's Godless (*nirīśvara*) tendency.
- **Recall line.** *Sāṃkhya supplies the map; Yoga supplies the training.*

B. Text, commentary and source control

- **Base text:** Patañjali's *Yoga-sūtra*, four chapters (*pāda*).
- 1. **Absorption (*samādhi-pāda*)** - definition, modifications, practice and dispassion, the Lord, object-supported and seedless absorption.
- 2. **Practice (*sādhana-pāda*)** - afflictions, action, the seen and the seer, the eight limbs.
- 3. **Powers (*vibhūti-pāda*)** - combined discipline, the three transformations, extraordinary capacities.
- 4. **Isolation (*kaivalya-pāda*)** - mind-object realism, latent tendencies, discriminative knowledge, cloud-of-dharma absorption, isolation.
- **Reading tradition:** Vyāsa, *Yoga-bhāṣya* -> Vācaspati Miśra, *Tattvavaiśārādī* -> Vijnānabhikṣu, *Yogavārttika*.
- **Commentarial, not aphoristic:** the five mind-levels; the four-stage analysis of lower dispassion; the expanded theoretical proof-set for the Lord.
- **Contested:** dating, layering and unity of the *sūtra* tradition. Identify; do not date.

C. The mind-field

- **Definition.** The unified inner apparatus of determinative intellect (*buddhi*), ego-maker (*ahaṃkāra*) and sensory mind (*manas*).
- **Nature.** A product of primordial material nature, therefore insentient (*jaḍa*); as a working whole lucid-predominant, therefore transparent.
- **Derivation.** Nature -> intellect -> ego-maker -> sensory mind from the ego-maker's lucid side. *Only the sensory mind derives directly from lucid ego-maker.*
- **Functions.** Intellect ascertains; ego-maker appropriates; sensory mind coordinates and doubts.
- **Contrasts.** Broader than Nyāya's atomic internal sense with its separate self-substance; not Advaita's inner instrument under beginningless ignorance.
- **Why it matters.** Bondage runs through the mind-field, so release must be worked there; the witness cannot be altered.

D. Reflection and misidentification

- **Model.** Reflection (**pratibimba**; also **chāyā**) - the mind mirrors the witness's light.
- **Double borrowing.** Colour from the object (**uparāga**); light from the witness.
- **Protective clause.** Mere proximity (**sannidhi-mātra**): all transformation is on the mind's side; the witness is unchanging (**apariṇāmin**).
- **The confusion.** Borrowed light read as owned light + witnesshood read as agency = egoity (**asmitā**), the conflation of the seer's power with the instrument's (**sva-svāmi-śakti**).
- **Images.** Crystal (**sphaṭika**) near a red flower; magnet moving iron by presence alone.
- **Objection.** Reflection presupposes a relation; disjoint principles have none.
- **Reply and residue.** All change is on the mind's side - but mere proximity *names* the relation more clearly than it *explains* it.

E. The five levels of the mind-field

Level	Ruling quality	Character	Fit?
scattered (kṣipta)	active	runs object to object	no
dull (mūḍha)	inert	torpor and obscurance, not calm	no
distracted (vikṣipta)	mixed, occasional lucidity	attends and analyses, cannot stay collected	partially prepared
one-pointed (ekāgra)	lucid	sustained one-pointedness	yes
restrained (niruddha)	modifications arrested	consummated inwardness	yes, culmination

- **Decisive step:** distracted -> one-pointed.
- **2019 application:** scientist = distracted; God-realised devotee = one-pointed; self-realised practitioner = restrained.
- **Attribution:** commentarial (Vyāsa onward), not a five-item aphorism.

F. The five modifications

Modification	Definition	Example
valid cognition (pramāṇa)	perception, inference, authoritative testimony	smoke -> fire
error (viparyaya)	false cognition not matching the object	nacre taken for silver
verbal construction (vikalpa)	cognition from words with no referent	"the horn of a hare"
sleep (nidrā)	positive mode on absence-content	"I slept and knew nothing"
memory (smṛti)	non-loss and re-presentation of experience	recollection of past pain

- **Orthogonal cut:** each may be afflicted (**kliṣṭa**) or unafflicted (**akliṣṭa**).
- **Never applies to afflictions**, which are inherently afflictive.
- **Ladder rule:** unafflicted modifications cancel afflicted ones and then themselves subside.
- **Recall line.** *What binds is form, not falsity.*

G. Why cessation is prescribed, and the instruments of knowledge

1. The mind-field takes the form of whatever it attends to.
 2. The witness's consciousness is reflected in that form.
 3. In ignorance the form is appropriated: "I know", "I suffer", "I desire", "I remember".
 4. Therefore the stream of modifications *sustains* bondage - it is mechanism, not symptom.
 5. Therefore restraint *uncovers* the already-free seer.
- **Register:** restraint is revelatory, not destructive; it removes concealment, not consciousness.
 - **Image:** the settled pool reflecting one clear sky.
 - **Instruments:** three - perception (**pratyakṣa**), inference (**anumāna**), authoritative testimony (**āgama/śabda**). Not four (Nyāya), not six (Advaita), not two (Buddhist).
 - **Yogic insight:** perfected extraordinary perception (**yogi-pratyakṣa**), not a fourth instrument - and still a modification.

H. Practice and dispassion

- **Joint responsibility** (*Yoga-sūtra* 1.12): neither alone suffices.
- **Firm practice** (**abhyāsa**): long time + without interruption + with devoted seriousness.
Function: continuity against old impressions.
- **Lower dispassion** (**apara- / vaśīkāra-vairāgya**, 1.15): mastery over thirst for seen *and scripturally promised* objects.
- **Higher dispassion** (**para-vairāgya**, 1.16): non-thirst even for the constituent qualities, following knowledge of the witness; releases attachment to subtle states, insight and powers.
- **Commentarial ladder inside lower dispassion:** effort toward control (**yatamāna**) -> separation (**vyatireka**) -> single residual desire (**ekendriya**) -> mastery (**vaśīkāra**).
- **Failure modes:** practice without dispassion = strain; dispassion without practice = mood.

I. Transformation of the mind-substrate

- **Three yogic transformations:** restraint (**nirodha-pariṇāma**), absorption (**samādhi-pariṇāma**), one-pointedness (**ekāgratā-pariṇāma**).
- **Three general transformations:** property (**dharma**), temporal character (**lakṣaṇa**), condition (**avasthā**) - of a persisting substrate (**dharmin**).
- **Why needed:** habituation, deposit, retrieval and stable acquisition presuppose a bearer.
- **Against Buddhism:** momentariness (**kṣaṇikavāda**) denies the bearer; Yoga needs it - but the Buddhist series-account retains force.
- **Against Advaita:** apparent transformation (**vivartavāda**) denies the change; Yoga's change is real.
- **Guard:** the substrate is nature, not a self.

J. The five afflictions and their four states

- **Ignorance** (**avidyā**) - root; four reversals: non-eternal -> eternal, impure -> pure, painful -> pleasant, non-self -> self.
- **Egoity** (**asmitā**) - seer identified with the instrument of seeing.
- **Attachment** (**rāga**) - pursuit following remembered pleasure.
- **Aversion** (**dveṣa**) - flight following remembered pain.
- **Clinging to life** (**abhiniveśa**) - instinctive, present *even in the learned*.
- **Four states:** dormant (**prasupta**) · attenuated (**tanu**) · interrupted (**vicchinna**) ·

fully active (**udāra**).

- **Diagnostic rule:** "I no longer feel it" is compatible with three of the four states.
- **Therapy ladder:** gross expression -> discipline; subtle form (**sūkṣma**) -> meditation; seed -> discriminative discernment.

K. The engine of bondage and the first therapy

- **Chain:** afflictions -> action -> karmic deposit (**karmāśaya**, rooted in afflictions) -> fruition (**vipāka**) -> rebirth.
- **Fruition is threefold:** birth (**jāti**), life-span (**āyus**), experience (**bhoga**).
- **Carriers:** impressions (**saṃskāra**), latent tendencies (**vāsanā**).
- **Four colours of action:** white (**śukla**), black (**kṛṣṇa**), mixed (**śukla-kṛṣṇa**), neither-white-nor-black (**aśukla-akṛṣṇa**) - the last is the practitioner's.
- **Preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga):** austerity (**tapas**) + self-study (**svādhyāya**) + dedication to the Lord (**Īśvara-praṇidhāna**); stated purpose: attenuate afflictions, cultivate absorption.
- **Scale objection and reply:** liberating knowledge burns seeds of *future* bondage; burnt seed (**dagdha-bīja**) keeps its shape and cannot germinate; the potter's wheel explains residual embodiment.

L. The eight-limbed discipline

- **External (bahiraṅga):** restraints (**yama**) · observances (**niyama**) · posture (**āsana**) · breath regulation (**prāṇāyāma**) · withdrawal (**pratyāhāra**).
- **Internal (antaraṅga):** concentration (**dhāraṇā**) · meditation (**dhyāna**) · absorption (**samādhi**).
- **Five restraints:** non-violence, truthfulness, non-stealing, disciplined continence, non-possessiveness - the **universal great vow (sārvabhauma-mahāvratā)** when unrestricted by birth, place, time or circumstance (*Yoga-sūtra* 2.31).
- **Five observances:** purity, contentment, austerity, self-study, dedication to the Lord.
- **Combined discipline (saṃyama):** limbs 6 + 7 + 8 on one object.
- **Nine obstacles (antarāya):** disease, mental stagnation, doubt, carelessness, laziness, sensual non-restraint, false vision, failure to attain a stage, instability in an attained stage.
- **Four symptoms:** suffering, dejection, bodily tremor, disturbed inhalation and exhalation.
- **Remedies:** dedication to the Lord; practice of one principle; friendliness, compassion, gladness and equanimity; breath regulation; suitable supports.
- **Guard:** "external" means preparatory, not unimportant; the three internal limbs are graded, not synonymous.

M. Absorption - the two grids

- **Object-supported (samprajñāta) = with-seed (sabīja, 1.46).**
- **Grid A (1.17):** deliberation (**vitarka**) · reflection (**vicāra**) · refined joy (**ānanda**) · bare I-am-ness (**asmitā**). *Joy ≠ ordinary pleasure; I-am-ness ≠ the binding affliction.*
- **Grid B (1.42-1.44):** savitarkā / nirvitarkā (gross, **sthūla**) · savicārā / nirvicārā (subtle, **sūkṣma**); *nir-* = purified of word-object-knowledge construction (**śabda-artha-jñāna-vikalpa**). 1.45 extends the subtle domain to the undifferentiated (**aliṅga**).
- **Rule:** commentators *map* the grids; they are not the same list.
- **Supra-cognitive (asamprajñāta, 1.18):** preceded by practice of the idea of cessation (**virāma-pratyaya**); has impression-residue (**saṃskāra-śeṣa**).

- **Seedless (nirbīja, 1.51):** even that residue restrained.
- **Two senses of seed:** object-support (1.46) versus residual impression (1.51).
- **Two routes (1.19-1.20):** condition-based (**bhava-pratyaya**; disembodied / nature-merged) and means-based (**upāya-pratyaya**; faith, energy, mindfulness, absorption, wisdom) - bases, not a third class.
- **Not sleep:** sleep is one of the five modifications.

N. The upper reaches: insight, powers, cloud of dharma

- **Truth-bearing insight (ṛtambharā prajñā, 1.48):** arises with the clarity of subtle coalescence (**nirvicāra-vaiśāradya**) and inner clarity of the self-field (**adhyātma-prasāda**, 1.47).
- **Its field:** a particular object (**viśeṣa-artha**), unlike testimony (**śruta**) and inference (**anumāna**), which reach universals.
- **Its function (1.50):** its impression obstructs other impressions.
- **Its status:** perfected extraordinary yogic perception, *not* a fourth instrument; still a modification; must itself cease.
- **Caution:** not to be equated with later integral conceptions of knowledge by identity.
- **Extraordinary capacities (siddhi, 3.37):** attainments in the outward-turned state but obstacles to absorption (**samādhāv upasargāḥ**) when appropriated; they reactivate egoity, attachment and pride.
- **Cloud-of-dharma absorption (dharmamegha-samādhi):** highest absorption before isolation; even fascination with knowledge and power is relinquished.

O. The Lord

- **Definition (1.24):** a special conscious witness (**puruṣa-viśeṣa**) untouched by affliction (**kleśa**), action (**karma**), fruition (**vipāka**) and deposit (**āśaya**).
- **1.25:** the unsurpassed seed of omniscience.
- **1.26:** teacher even of the ancients, unlimited by time.
- **1.27-1.28:** denoted by the sacred syllable (**praṇava**, OM); repetition with contemplation of its meaning.
- **Five roles:** object of meditation · aid through dedication · remover of obstacles · perfect model · teacher-principle.
- **Five negations:** not material cause · not the Nyāya creator and efficient cause · not a devotional saviour · not one of the bound witnesses · not a substitute for discernment.
- **Source control:** the theoretical proof-set from scripture, maximal degrees and cosmic coordination is *later commentarial*, not Patañjali's.
- **Formula: instrumental, not constitutive** - non-final rather than redundant.

P. Isolation

- **Definition:** aloneness (**kaivalya**) - isolation of the witness from primordial nature and its evolutes.
- **Road:** practice and dispassion -> preparatory discipline and eight limbs -> attenuation and destruction of afflictions -> stable absorption -> discriminative discernment (**viveka-khyāti**) -> higher dispassion (**para-vairāgya**) -> cloud-of-dharma absorption -> isolation.
- **On nature's side:** involution (**pratiprasava**) of the constituent qualities; the mind's function is exhausted.
- **On the witness's side:** abiding in one's own nature (**svarūpa-pratiṣṭhā**).

- **Four negations:** not union with God · not identity with Brahman · not annihilation of consciousness · not mere painlessness. (And not destruction of mind as a substance.)
- **Images:** the farmer (**kṣetrika**) breaching an embankment; the burnt seed; the potter's wheel.
- **Contrast with Advaita liberation:** many witnesses versus one Brahman; disentanglement versus identity-realisation.
- **Contrast with Nyāya release (apavarga):** Nyāya emphasises cessation of suffering; Yoga emphasises isolation and self-abidance.
- **Liberation while living:** admissible only with the potter's-wheel qualification.

Q. Realism, debates, criticisms and the verdict

- **Realist polemic (isolation chapter) against consciousness-only (vijñānavāda / yogācāra):**
 1. **Object-independence** - an object is not dependent on a single mind (**ekacitta-tantra**); otherwise it would vanish when unattended.
 2. **The mind's knownness** - the mind is not self-illuminating (**na tat svābhāsam**) because it is itself something seen (**drśya**) for the witness.
 3. **No simultaneous self-cognition** - the mind cannot be both lamp and illuminated object in one act.
 4. **Colouring** - an object is known when the mind is coloured (**uparakta**) by it.
- **Three-term realism:** object (**viśaya**) · modification (**citta-vṛtti**) · witness (**puruṣa**).
- **Counter and residue:** shared karmic traces can explain intersubjective appearance; Yoga must still say how an external object colours an insentient mind.
- **Comparison axes:** self · God · causation · liberation · instruments of knowledge.
- **vs Sāṃkhya:** same ontology; Godless there, Lord-admitting here; metaphysics there, practice here.
- **vs Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika:** broad mind-field vs atomic internal sense; meditative Lord vs creator; isolation vs release; three instruments vs four.
- **vs Advaita:** many witnesses + nature vs non-dual Brahman; isolation vs identity.
- **vs Buddhism:** enduring witness vs no-self; discrimination-aimed meditation vs impermanence-aimed insight; isolation vs cessation of conditioned suffering.
- **Eight criticisms with replies:** inactive witness bound (misidentification) · insentient mind cognising (reflection) · restraining true cognition (form, not falsity) · absorption as sleep (genesis and value differ) · Lord redundant to Sāṃkhya (practical efficacy) · Lord redundant to discernment (non-final) · isolation merely negative (self-abidance) · meditation without ethics (insufficient).
- **Graded verdict.**
 - **Strong:** rigorous phenomenology; integration of psychology, ethics and metaphysics; an operational path; genuine metaphysical commitment.
 - **Weak:** the witness-nature interaction problem; the Lord's limited explanatory role; the contestable value of contentless consciousness.
 - **Contested:** the status of joy and I-am-ness; the character of isolation; the layering of the textual tradition.
- **Ready verdicts.** 10 marks - a disciplined psychology of mental restraint grounded in Sāṃkhya dualism and completed in isolation. 15 marks - strong in linking mental discipline, moral causation and liberation; vulnerable at the unexplained proximity of inactive witness and active nature. 20 marks - richer than a praxis manual,

offering a realist metaphysics, a subtle moral psychology and a graded meditative epistemology, though its dualism and limited Lord leave live objections for Advaita, Nyāya and Buddhist critics.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

This is the terminal-friendly, data-complete master flow. It is authored separately from the graphical package and is validated against the same Basic, Advanced and previous-year ledger. The same 24 panels are installed as a standalone text artifact and rendered as a standalone PDF.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/24: The controlling question, the definition and the inheritance

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/24: The controlling question, the definition and the inheritance

SYLLABUS ITEM 17, PRINTED VERBATIM: "Yoga; Citta; Cittavṛtti; Klesas; Samadhi; Kaivalya."
normalised: Yoga · citta · citta-vṛtti · kleśa · samādhi · kaivalya

CONTROLLING QUESTION how does a mind stop handing the witness something to be?

+---- THE DEFINITION AND ITS TWO COMPANIONS (Yoga-sūtra 1.2 - 1.4) -----+
| 1.2 yogaś-citta-vṛtti-nirodhaḥ Yoga = restraint of the modifications of the |
| mind-field. A STATE, not an activity. |
| 1.3 tadā draṣṭuḥ svarūpe'vasthānam . then the seer abides in its own nature. |
| 1.4 otherwise the seer takes the FORM of the modifications |
| => this is what bondage IS. |
+-----+

WHAT IS INHERITED (Sāṃkhya owns; Yoga restates only what its psychology needs)
many conscious witnesses (puruṣa) · one primordial material nature (prakṛti)
three constituent qualities (guṇa) · twenty-five principles (tattva)
effect pre-exists in cause (satkāryavāda) · real transformation (pariṇāmavāda)
bondage = non-discrimination · release = discriminative knowledge

WHAT YOGA OWNS (this is the answerable syllabus item)
mind-field psychology · five modifications · afflicted / unafflicted division
practice + dispassion · five afflictions · moral causation of action · eight limbs
absorption taxonomies · combined discipline · the Lord · discriminative discernment
cloud-of-dharma absorption · isolation

THE PUBLIC SIGNATURE
Sāṃkhya = nirīśvara (Godless) Yoga = seśvara-sāṃkhya (theistic Sāṃkhya)
also called sāṃkhya-pravacana (Sāṃkhya-exposition)

+-----+
| ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE |
| Yoga does not add a new world to Sāṃkhya's world; it adds a discipline to |
| Sāṃkhya's argument – which is why its definition is a psychological state and |
| not a metaphysical thesis. |
+-----+

! TRAP 1: do not define Yoga as union with God. Patañjali defines it by cessation.
! TRAP 2: do not write that Yoga rejects Sāṃkhya. It operationalises Sāṃkhya.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/24: Textual identity, the four chapters and source control

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/24: Textual identity, the four chapters and source control

PATAÑJALI, YOGA-SŪTRA – four chapters (pāda), each with a centre of gravity

1. SAMĀDHI-PĀDA (absorption)	definition · five modifications · practice and dispassion · the Lord · object-supported and seedless absorption
2. SĀDHANA-PĀDA (practice)	preparatory discipline · five afflictions and four states · action, deposit, fruition · the seen and the seer · the eight limbs
3. VIBHŪTI-PĀDA (powers)	combined discipline (dhāraṇā + dhyāna + samādhi) · three transformations of the mind · extraordinary capacities AND their demotion
4. KAIVALYA-PĀDA (isolation)	mind / object realism against idealism · latent tendencies · discriminative knowledge · cloud-of-dharma absorption · involution of the qualities · isolation

THE READING TRADITION (the operative form in which the system is taught)

Vyāsa, YOGA-BHĀṢYA -> Vācaspati Miśra, TATTVAVAIŚĀRADĪ -> Vijñānabhikṣu,
YOGAVĀRTTIKA

+---- SOURCE-CONTROL LEDGER – label the layer you are quoting -----+		
	COMMENTARIAL, NOT A SŪTRA LIST	WHY IT MATTERS
	the five mind-levels (citta-bhūmi)	usable, incl. for the 2019 paper; attribute
		to Vyāsa-onward exposition, not to Patañjali
	the four stages of lower dispassion	Patañjali's own definition (1.15) is mastery
	(yatamāna, vyatireka, ekendriya,	over thirst for seen and heard-of objects
	vaśīkāra)	
	the expanded theoretical proof-set	Patañjali's grounds are compact and
	for the Lord	practice-facing; do not project later proofs
+-----+		

! TRAP 3: the historical layering and dating of the sūtra tradition are DISPUTED.
Identify the received Pātañjala system; never build an answer on a date.

ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE: the Yoga-sūtra is a text of headings and the tradition that reads
it is a text of paragraphs; a Yoga answer earns authority by never confusing the two.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/24: The mind-field - constitution, derivation and contrasts

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/24: The mind-field – constitution, derivation and contrasts

```
PRIMORDIAL MATERIAL NATURE (prakṛti)
| evolution
v
DETERMINATIVE INTELLECT (buddhi / mahat)
|
v
EGO-MAKER (ahaṁkāra)
| from its LUCID (sattva-predominant) side only
v
SENSORY MIND (manas)
```

ALL THREE TAKEN TOGETHER AS ONE OPERATIVE CONTINUUM = THE MIND-FIELD (citta)

COMPONENT	ROLE	WHY YOGA FILES IT UNDER citta
buddhi (intellect)	ascertainment, decision	discrimination and resolve here
ahaṁkāra (ego-maker)	appropriation as "I"	ownership and doership arise here
manas (sensory mind)	co-ordination, doubt	sense-data received and arranged

NATURE OF THE MIND-FIELD

a product of prakṛti => jaḍa (insentient) in itself
lucid-predominant as a WORKING WHOLE => transparent, able to take object-form
and to mirror consciousness
therefore: the PSYCHICAL INSTRUMENT of experience, NOT the self

! TRAP 4: only manas derives DIRECTLY from lucid ahaṁkāra. Sattva-predominance is a property of the whole; it is not a derivation of intellect and ego from lucid ego.

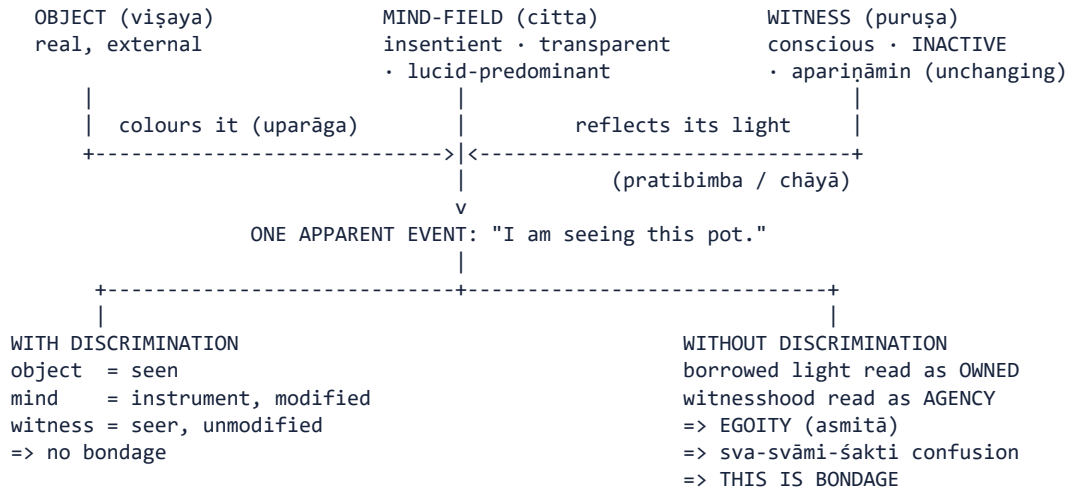
CONTRAST GRID

SCHOOL	INTERNAL ORGAN	KEY DIFFERENCE FROM YOGA
Sāṃkhya	buddhi / ahaṁkāra / manas kept analytically distinct	Yoga gathers them functionally into one field
Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	manas: atomic, partless internal sense + a separate self-substance	Yoga's citta is broad, composite, transformable
Advaita Vedānta	antaḥkaraṇa under avidyā within a Brahman framework	Yoga keeps many puruṣas and has NO Brahman doctrine

ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE: gathering intellect, ego and sense-mind under one name is a claim that bondage is suffered by the WHOLE interior and cannot be cured faculty by faculty.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/24: Reflection, mere proximity and the birth of egoity

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/24: Reflection, mere proximity and the birth of egoity



THE PROTECTED CLAIM

relation = SANNIDHI-MĀTRA (mere proximity). ALL transformation is on the mind's side.
the witness neither acts nor changes. Bondage is phenomenological and epistemic.

IMAGES THAT DO THE WORK

sphaṭika (clear crystal) beside a red flower -> looks red; neither is altered
magnet and iron -> mere presence moves the iron

OBJECTION -> reflection normally presupposes a REAL relation between mirror and original;
ontologically disjoint principles have none.

REPLY -> all change is on the citta side; the witness is untouched.

RESIDUE ! -> mere proximity NAMES the relation more clearly than it EXPLAINS it.
Advaita presses by collapsing the duality; Nyāya by making consciousness an
adventitious property of a substantial self.

2024 ANCHOR: "So long as there are changes and modifications in citta, the self is
reflected therein, and, in the absence of discriminative knowledge, identifies itself
with them." -> this panel IS that question.

ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE: bondage is devastating in experience and unreal in metaphysics –
the mirror is in trouble; the lamp never was.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/24: The five levels of the mind-field and the 2019 application

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/24: The five levels of the mind-field and the 2019 application

LEVEL (citta-bhūmi)	RULING QUALITY	CHARACTER	FIT FOR YOGA?
kṣipta (scattered)	rajas (active)	runs object to object; activity without integration	NO pre-yogic
mūḍha (dull)	tamas (inert)	torpor, delusion, inertia: OBSCURATION, not calm	NO pre-yogic
vikṣipta (distracted)	mixed, occasional sattva flashes	attends, infers, analyses, briefly concentrates; cannot remain inwardly collected	NO only partly prepared
ekāgra (one-pointed)	sattva (lucid)	sustained one-pointedness on a chosen support	YES yoga-fit
niruddha (restrained)	modifications arrested	consummation of disciplined inwardness; NOT blankness	YES culmination

kṣipta -> mūḍha -> vikṣipta ==||== ekāgra -> niruddha
||

THE DECISIVE STEP: occasional concentration
becomes SUSTAINED one-pointedness

2019 APPLIED READING (Q7(b), 15 marks – "justify your answer")

SCIENTIST vikṣipta. Intense but OUTWARD-directed, result-attached,
interrupted. High intellectual focus is NOT yogic restraint.

GOD-REALISED DEVOTEE .. ekāgra. Lucid-dominant mind on a single support; dedication
to the Lord stabilises the field and removes the obstacles.

SELF-REALISED YOGIN ... niruddha. Modifications stilled; correlated with the highest
absorption and the approach to isolation.

! TRAP 5: the criterion is RULING QUALITY and stability of inward collection, never the
force of attention. A distracted genius sits below a one-pointed devotee.

! TRAP 6: the fivefold scheme is Vyāsa-onward commentarial exposition, not a sūtra list.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/24: The five modifications and the afflicted / unafflicted cut

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/24: The five modifications and the afflicted / unafflicted cut

ALL MENTAL EVENTS = FIVE MODIFICATIONS (citta-vṛtti) – claimed EXHAUSTIVE

pramāṇa (valid cognition)	cognition via perception, inference, authoritative testimony	smoke seen -> fire correctly inferred
viparyaya (error)	false cognition not matching the object as it is	nacre taken for silver
vikalpa (verbal construction)	cognition from WORDS ALONE with no corresponding object	"the horn of a hare"; intelligible without referent
nidrā (sleep)	a POSITIVE mode grounded on absence-content	waking report: "I slept and knew nothing"
smṛti (memory)	non-loss and re-presentation of experienced content	recollection of past pain or pleasure

EACH OF THE FIVE SPLITS ORTHOGONALLY

+-----+-----+	+-----+
v	v
KLIṢṬA (afflicted)	AKLIṢṬA (unafflicted)
coloured by avidyā and the other afflictions; bondage-producing e.g. memory feeding a grievance testimony used for vanity	purified, redirected toward discrimination and detachment e.g. valid cognition of impermanence

THE LADDER RULE

unafflicted modifications CANCEL afflicted ones and then THEMSELVES SUBSIDE.
a ladder is climbed and left behind; it is not carried to the top floor.

WHY VALID COGNITION IS ON THE LIST

what binds the seer is not the FALSITY of a mental form but the fact that it is a FORM.
Yoga accepts three instruments of knowledge; it simply denies that truth exempts a
mental form from being a mental form.

- ! TRAP 7: the kliṣṭa / akliṣṭa division qualifies MODIFICATIONS only. Afflictions are inherently afflictive; there is no "unafflicted ignorance".
- ! TRAP 8: sleep is a modification, not the absence of modification, and not liberation.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/24: Why cessation is prescribed, and the epistemology that limits it

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/24: Why cessation is prescribed, and the epistemology that limits it

THE FIVE-STEP DERIVATION (this is the 2023 "give reasons" answer, numbered)

- STEP 1 the mind-field takes the FORM of whatever it attends to
|
STEP 2 the witness's consciousness is REFLECTED in that form
|
STEP 3 in ignorance the changing form is APPROPRIATED in the first person:
"I know" · "I suffer" · "I desire" · "I remember"
|
STEP 4 therefore the stream of modifications SUSTAINS bondage –
it is the running MECHANISM, not a symptom
|
STEP 5 therefore restraint UNCOVERS the already-free seer

```
+-----+
| NIRODHA IS REVELATORY, NOT DESTRUCTIVE: it removes concealment, not consciousness. |
| IMAGE: when ripples settle, the pool reflects one clear sky. Nothing was added to |
| the water and nothing was taken from the sky. |
+-----+
```

EPISTEMOLOGY IN THE SAME FRAME – THE SCHOOL POLICING ITS OWN ENTHUSIASM

THREE INSTRUMENTS ADMITTED	WHAT IS NOT ADDED
pratyakṣa (perception)	NO fourth instrument for yogic insight
anumāna (inference)	truth-bearing insight = PERFECTED PERCEPTION
āgama / śabda (testimony)	(yogi-pratyakṣa), and it is STILL a modification, so it too must finally cease

count check: Yoga 3 · Sāṃkhya 3 · Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika 4 · Buddhist epistemologists 2
· Advaita commonly 6

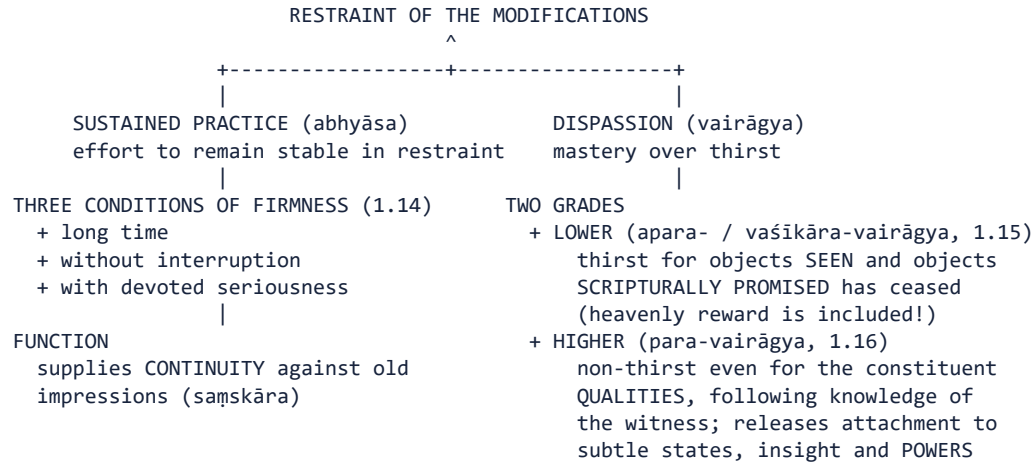
! TRAP 9: do not give Yoga four or six instruments, and do not promote ṛtambharā prajñā
into an independent means of knowledge.

! TRAP 10: restraint is not the destruction of the mind as a substance.

ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE: Yoga prescribes cessation not because thought is bad but because
thought is the running machinery of a mistake.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/24: Practice and dispassion - the two handles of restraint

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/24: Practice and dispassion – the two handles of restraint



JOINT RESPONSIBILITY (1.12): neither repetition without detachment nor detachment without stabilised practice is sufficient.

FAILURE MODES

practice without dispassion strain, tug-of-war, relapse
dispassion without practice mood without capacity

```

+---- COMMENTARIAL LADDER INSIDE LOWER DISPASSION – label it as commentarial -----+
| yatamāna    effort toward control                                                    |
| vyatireka   separation of subdued from unsubdued tendencies                          |
| ekendriya   withdrawal to a single residual mental desire                           |
| vaśīkāra    mastery                                                                    |
+-----+

```

! TRAP 11: higher dispassion is discernment-generated non-thirst, NOT apathy, boredom or world-hatred; and it is not merely a stronger grade of the lower.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/24: Real transformation of the mind-substrate

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/24: Real transformation of the mind-substrate

GENERAL FRAME – any substrate of nature

+-----+ PERSISTING SUBSTRATE (dharmin) dharma-pariṇāma change of PROPERTY lakṣaṇa-pariṇāma change of TEMPORAL PHASE (past / present / future) avasthā-pariṇāma change of CONDITION (intensity, maturity) +-----+	
---	--

THE THREE SPECIFICALLY YOGIC TRANSFORMATIONS OF THE MIND (Vibhūti-pāda)

nirodha-pariṇāma (restraint-transformation)	impressions of RESTRAINT progressively overpower impressions of emergence; the mind becomes habituated to cessation rather than to dispersion

samādhi-pariṇāma (absorption-transformation)	many-pointedness declines and unified absorption rises; distracting multiplicity weakens as one object dominates

ekāgratā-pariṇāma (one-pointedness- transformation)	similar cognitive moments arise and subside in an UNBROKEN STREAM toward the same object (even the highest stability is a stream, not a freeze)

WHY A BEARER IS NEEDED: practice ACCUMULATES · impressions are DEPOSITED and RETRIEVED
· a practitioner ACQUIRES a stable capacity. None of these is a
feature of a mere succession.

IMAGE: one lake – stormy, then calming, then still. Three states, one lake.

THE CONTESTED JOINT

- Buddhist kṣaṇikavādin -> a stream of momentary events suffices; the substrate is an unnecessary fiction
- Yoga's reply -> graded discipline, memory and impression-continuity need more than disconnected flashes
- RESIDUE ! -> a sufficiently rich causal series may reproduce much of what Yoga assigns to a substrate
- Advaita vivartavāda -> change is only APPARENT; Yoga insists the change is REAL

! TRAP 12: the persisting citta is a substrate of NATURE, not a self. The witness stands outside every one of these transformations.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/24: The five afflictions, the four reversals and the four states

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/24: The five afflictions, the four reversals and the four states

```

+---- IGNORANCE (avidyā) – THE ROOT, not merely the first item -----+
|  FOUR REVERSALS (each separately markable)                             |
|  non-eternal  -> taken as -> eternal                                   |
|  impure       -> taken as -> pure                                       |
|  painful      -> taken as -> pleasant                                  |
|  non-self     -> taken as -> self                                       |
+-----+
|               | is the FIELD in which the other four grow              |
+-----+-----+-----+-----+
v               v               v               v
ASMITĀ (egoity)   RĀGA (attachment) DVEṢA (aversion) ABHINIVEŚA (clinging
seer identified with the pursuit following flight following to life) instinctive
INSTRUMENT of seeing remembered PLEASURE remembered PAIN self-preservation,
-> "I think, I act, I suffer"                                PRESENT EVEN IN THE
                                                             LEARNED

```

FOUR STATES OF ANY AFFLICTION

```

-----
prasupta      dormant      seed-like, not presently manifest; DORMANCY IS NOT
DESTRUCTION – favourable conditions reactivate it
-----
tanu          attenuated   thinned by practice, austerity, meditation, discernment;
the only state that represents genuine progress
-----
vicchinna     interrupted  temporarily overridden by an opposing tendency –
attachment may look absent only because fear is louder
-----
udāra         fully active  visibly governing speech, action and affect

```

DIAGNOSTIC RULE: "I no longer feel it" is compatible with dormant, attenuated AND interrupted. Only destruction of the seed removes an affliction.

THERAPY LADDER: gross expression -> ethical and practical discipline
 subtle form (sūkṣma) -> dhyāna burns it
 the seed -> discriminative discernment destroys it

! TRAP 13: do not list five PARALLEL afflictions. Ignorance is the root of the other four.
 ! TRAP 14: abhiniveśa survives learning; it is not an intellectual error.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/24: The engine of bondage - chain, carriers and action-colours

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/24: The engine of bondage – chain, carriers and action-colours

```
AFFLICTIONS (kleśa)
| motivate
v
ACTION (karma)
| deposits
v
KARMIC DEPOSIT (karmāśaya) ..... kleśa-mūla: rooted in the afflictions
| ripens as
v
FRUITION (vipāka), THREEFOLD:  jāti (birth / species-condition)
                                āyus (life-span)
                                bhoga (experience: enjoyment and suffering)
| generates fresh reaction
v
REBIRTH (punarjanma) -----> loop closes and runs again

CARRIED BY: saṃskāra (impression) and vāsanā (latent tendency) – cognition and action
            leave traces; traces dispose future cognition and action; the cycle becomes
            MORALLY STRUCTURED rather than merely repetitive.

FOUR COLOURS OF ACTION
śukla (white) ..... meritorious
kṛṣṇa (black) ..... demeritorious
śukla-kṛṣṇa (mixed) ..... the ordinary human mixture
aśukla-akṛṣṇa (neither) ..... the practitioner whose action no longer produces
                                ordinary bondage
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/24: Jamming the engine - preparatory discipline and the burnt seed

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/24: Jamming the engine – preparatory discipline and the burnt seed

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WHERE THE ENGINE IS JAMMED
(1) AT THE ROOT – PREPARATORY DISCIPLINE (kriyā-yoga), stated purpose: attenuate the
    afflictions (tanū-karaṇa) and cultivate absorption
        tapas ..... disciplined, heat-generating effort
        svādhyāya ..... study and recitation of sacred teaching + self-examination
        īśvara-praṇidhāna . surrender of the fruits and of the ego's proprietary claim
                                (also a niyama AND an independent means to absorption)
(2) AT THE SEED – dhyāna burns subtle forms; viveka-khyāti destroys the seed;
    pratiprasava reabsorbs the residue

OBJECTION -> if release requires exhausting an unsurveyable stock of deposit, release is
            indefinitely postponed.
REPLY      -> liberating knowledge and absorption burn the seeds of FUTURE bondage.
    dagdha-bija (burnt seed) .... keeps its shape; cannot germinate
    potter's wheel ..... after the push stops the wheel turns until momentum is
                        spent = residual embodiment WITHOUT fresh bondage

! TRAP 15: fruition is THREEFOLD. Writing "vipāka" as a single item loses the precision.
! TRAP 16: kriyā-yoga (3 items) is NOT saṃyama (limbs 6-8) and NOT the eight limbs.
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 13/24: The eight-limbed discipline - the five external limbs

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 13/24: The eight-limbed discipline – the five external limbs

EXTERNAL LIMBS (bahiraṅga) – preparatory with respect to subtler operations

- | | | |
|---|-------------------------|--|
| 1 | YAMA (restraints) | ahimsā (non-violence) · satya (truthfulness)
· asteya (non-stealing) · brahmacarya (disciplined
continence) · aparigraha (non-possessiveness)
YS 2.31: unrestricted by birth/class, place, time or
circumstance => SĀRVABHAUMA-MAHĀVRATA, the universal great
vow. No exceptional context licenses violence or falsehood. |
| 2 | NIYAMA (observances) | śauca (purity) · santoṣa (contentment) · tapas (austerity)
· svādhyāya (self-study) · īśvara-praṇidhāna (dedication)
NOTE the overlap with kriyā-yoga in the last three. |
| 3 | ĀSANA (posture) | a STEADY and COMFORTABLE seat; freedom from bodily
distraction, not gymnastic display |
| 4 | PRĀṆĀYĀMA (breath) | regulation of breath and the psycho-physical economy;
breath is the hinge between body and mind |
| 5 | PRATYĀHĀRA (withdrawal) | senses released from compulsive extroversion; the BRIDGE
into explicitly internal work |

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 14/24: Internal limbs, combined discipline, obstacles and remedies

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 14/24: Internal limbs, combined discipline, obstacles and remedies

INTERNAL LIMBS (antaraṅga) – graded, NOT synonymous

- | | | |
|---|----------------------------|---|
| 6 | DHĀRAṆĀ
(concentration) | binding citta to ONE chosen locus; first clear sign of
one-pointedness (ekāgratā) |
| 7 | DHYĀNA (meditation) | UNINTERRUPTED FLOW of cognition toward that same object;
also the burner of subtle afflictions |
| 8 | SAMĀDHI (absorption) | the object alone shines; discursiveness recedes |

6 + 7 + 8 APPLIED TO ONE OBJECT = SAMYAMA (combined discipline)

NINE OBSTACLES (antarāya): vyādhi (disease) · styāna (mental stagnation) · saṁśaya (doubt) · pramāda (carelessness) · ālasya (laziness) · avirati (sensual non-restraint) · bhrānti-darśana (false vision) · alabdha-bhūmikatva (failure to attain a stage) · anavasthitatva (instability in an attained stage)

FOUR SYMPTOMS: duḥkha (suffering) · daurmanasya (dejection) · aṅgamejayatva (bodily tremor) · śvāsa-praśvāsa (disturbed inhalation and exhalation)

REMEDIES: īśvara-praṇidhāna · practice of ONE principle · friendliness, compassion, gladness and equanimity · breath regulation · suitable meditative supports

=> THIS is why questions on samādhi open into the role of God: Yoga's God is a PRACTICE-ENABLING doctrine, not a creation-first one.

! TRAP 17: "external" means PREPARATORY, not unimportant. Yoga's answer to "is dhyāna enough without ethics?" is NO: meditative power can coexist with affliction and egoity.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 15/24: Absorption - the two grids that must not be conflated

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 15/24: Absorption – the two grids that must not be conflated

```
OBJECT-SUPPORTED ABSORPTION (samprajñāta) = WITH SEED (sabīja, YS 1.46)
+---- GRID A – YS 1.17: WHICH FACTOR ACCOMPANIES THE ABSORPTION -----+
| vitarka   gross object-level deliberative grasp
| vicāra    subtle object-level reflection
| ānanda    refined LUCID joy – NOT ordinary pleasure
| asmitā    bare I-am-ness – NOT the binding affliction, but an extremely subtle
|            objectification of the I-sense
| => ānanda and asmitā are NOT a contested later addition; they are IN the sūtra.
+-----+
+---- GRID B – YS 1.42-1.44: COALESCENCE (samāpatti) BY OBJECT AND OVERLAY -----+
| savitarkā  gross (sthūla) object · mixed with śabda-artha-jñāna-vikalpa
| nirvitarkā gross object · memory and verbal construction purified
| savicārā   subtle (sūkṣma) object · subtle reflective consideration remains
| nirvicārā  subtle object · even subtle reflective overlay stilled
| YS 1.45 extends the subtle domain up to the undifferentiated (aliṅga)
| YS 1.46 declares ALL of these sabīja
+-----+
GRID A asks: WHAT ACCOMPANIES IT?    GRID B asks: WHAT IS IT ON, AND HOW CLEAN?
commentators MAP the two grids; they do NOT IDENTIFY them.
example: the crystal takes the colour of the flower – citta becomes so object-coloured
that the object seems to shine through it.
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 16/24: Absorption - seed senses, residue and the two routes

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 16/24: Absorption – seed senses, residue and the two routes

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THE MOVE BEYOND
YS 1.47 vaiśāradya (clarity) of nirvicārā -> adhyātma-prasāda (inner clarity)
YS 1.48 therein the insight is ṛtambharā (truth-bearing)
YS 1.18 ASAMPRAJÑĀTA: preceded by virāma-pratyaya (practice of the idea of
        cessation) AND having SAMSKĀRA-ŚEṢA (impression-residue)
YS 1.51 when THAT TOO is restrained, everything being restrained => NIRBĪJA

TWO SENSES OF "SEED" – THE TERMINOLOGY TRAP
sabīja (1.46) = with OBJECT-SUPPORT
nirbīja (1.51) = without the residual IMPRESSION
=> losing the object-support does NOT by itself make an absorption seedless.
SAFE FORMULA: asamprajñāta = vṛttis stopped, saṃskāra-śeṣa remains;
               nirbīja      = even that residue restrained.

TWO ROUTES (bases, NOT a third classification)
YS 1.19 bhava-pratyaya .. condition-based; videha / prakṛti-laya beings.
        Commentators warn: nature-mergence need not equal final
        discriminative isolation.
YS 1.20 upāya-pratyaya .. means-based; śraddhā · vīrya · smṛti · samādhi · prajñā

! TRAP 18: NEVER write "the four types of samprajñāta given by Patañjali are savitarka,
nirvitarka, savicāra and nirvicāra."
! TRAP 19: asamprajñāta is not sleep – nidrā is itself one of the five modifications.
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 17/24: Truth-bearing insight, seedlessness and the cloud of dharma

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 17/24: Truth-bearing insight, seedlessness and the cloud of dharma

```
nirvicārā coalescence perfected
| its clarity (vaiśāradya)
v
ADHYĀTMA-PRASĀDA – inner clarity of the self-field [YS 1.47]
|
v
+---- ṚTAMBHARĀ PRAJÑĀ – TRUTH-BEARING INSIGHT ----- [YS 1.48] ----+
| FIELD ..... a PARTICULAR object (viśeṣa-artha)
| CONTRAST ... śruta (testimony) and anumāna (inference) reach universals and
|               general relations; this reaches the individual
| STATUS ..... NOT a fourth pramāṇa. Yoga admits three. Best classified as perfected
|               extraordinary yogic perception (yogi-pratyakṣa)
| FUNCTION ... its saṃskāra OBSTRUCTS other saṃskāras [YS 1.50]
| OBJECTION .. if it is still a vṛtti, how can it help rather than bind?
| REPLY ..... akliṣṭa cancels kliṣṭa, then itself ceases. A LADDER, left behind.
| CAUTION ! .. do NOT equate it with later "knowledge by identity" or supermind;
|               the resemblance is thematic only. Here it must finally CEASE.
+-----+
| and then it too must cease
v
NIRBĪJA SAMĀDHI – seedless absorption [YS 1.51]
|
v
DHARMAMEGHA-SAMĀDHI – the cloud of dharma rains down the fullness of discriminative
knowledge; even FASCINATION with extraordinary knowledge or power is relinquished.
The yogin no longer seeks omniscience, attainment or display.
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 18/24: Extraordinary capacities - attainments and obstacles

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 18/24: Extraordinary capacities – attainments and obstacles

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THE SIDE-BRANCH: EXTRAORDINARY CAPACITIES
saṃyama (combined discipline) -> siddhi (extraordinary capacities)
YS 3.37: attainments in the OUTWARD-TURNED state, but SAMĀDHĀV UPASARGĀḤ –
        OBSTACLES TO ABSORPTION when they attract appropriation
WHY: they reactivate egoity, attachment and pride
STATUS: side-effects of discipline, NOT the essence of isolation
GOVERNOR: para-vairāgya (higher dispassion) releases attachment to subtle states,
        knowledge and powers

! TRAP 20: reporting the capacities is doctrinal exposition, not empirical endorsement.
    Say the text owns and subordinates them; do not certify them as verified fact.

ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE: the most disciplined thing about Yoga is what it says about its
own successes – the highest insight is a ladder and the powers are obstacles.
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 19/24: The Lord - definition, roles, negations and source control

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 19/24: The Lord – definition, roles, negations and source control

```
+---- WHAT HE IS -----+
|  ĪŚVARA = PURUṢA-VIŚEṢA, a SPECIAL conscious witness           [YS 1.24] |
|    untouched by kleśa (affliction) · karma (action) · vipāka (fruition) |
|    · āśaya (karmic deposit)                                         |
|  in him lies the UNSURPASSED SEED OF OMNISCIENCE                   [YS 1.25] |
|  TEACHER OF THE ANCIENTS, not limited by time                     [YS 1.26] |
|  denoted by PRANAVA (OM)                                           [YS 1.27] |
|  practice: repetition of it WITH CONTEMPLATION OF ITS MEANING      [YS 1.28] |
|  SPECIAL, not different in kind: he belongs to the category of witness; his |
|  distinction is that he was NEVER ENTANGLED.                       |
+-----+-----+
```

WHAT HE DOES (five roles)

object of meditation -> one-pointed
devotion stabilises the mind-field
aid through īśvara-praṇidhāna ->
surrender reduces egoity
remover of the nine antarāyas
perfect model of untouched status
teacher-principle anchoring timeless
transmission and authority

WHAT HE IS NOT (five negations)

NOT the material cause – prakṛti remains that
NOT the Nyāya creator / efficient cause and
moral governor of the world-order
NOT a devotional saviour granting liberation
arbitrarily
NOT one of the ordinary BOUND witnesses
NOT a substitute for viveka-khyāti

SOURCE CONTROL

PATAÑJALI'S OWN GROUNDS are compact and practice-facing: special witness · unsurpassed omniscience · timeless teacherhood · praṇava-mediated contemplation.

LATER YOGA COMMENTATORS add scripture, maximal degrees of knowledge and power, and the need for intelligent coordination of witness and nature.

! Do NOT project the full later creator / administrator proof-set back onto Patañjali.

OBJECTION (from nirīśvara Sāṃkhya) -> if the ontology already explains liberation, why add a Lord?

REPLY -> pragmatic and soteriological: a unique focus of devotion, obstacle-removal, support for absorption

OBJECTION (redundancy) -> if viveka-khyāti liberates, is he not redundant?

REPLY -> NOT redundant, but NON-FINAL.

THE FORMULA THAT ANSWERS BOTH: THE LORD IS INSTRUMENTAL, NOT CONSTITUTIVE, IN LIBERATION. This is why the school is seśvara-sāṃkhya: real theism, bounded theism.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 20/24: Isolation - the road from practice to self-abidance

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 20/24: Isolation – the road from practice to self-abidance

```
abhyāsa + vairāgya
  v
kriyā-yoga and aṣṭāṅga-yoga
  v
attenuation and destruction of the kleśas
  v
stable samādhi
  v
VIVEKA-KHYĀTI – uninterrupted discernment of the ABSOLUTE DIFFERENCE between the
conscious witness and primordial nature. Yoga stays COGNITIVIST at the summit:
absorption is indispensable, but its function is to MATURE discernment.
  v
PARA-VAIRĀGYA – no craving even for powers, experiences or exalted cognitive states.
Without it, subtle egoity survives advanced practice.
  v
DHARMAMEGHA-SAMĀDHI – ripened summit of perfected discipline and discernment.
NOT a divine grace replacing effort.
  v
+---- KAIVALYA -----+
| DEFINITION: aloneness / isolation / absolute distinctness – the isolation of the |
| witness from prakṛti and its evolutes. |
| ON NATURE'S SIDE: PRATIPRASAVA – the guṇas cease to function for that witness and |
| resolve back toward their source; citta's function is exhausted. |
| ON THE WITNESS'S SIDE: SVARŪPA-PRATIṢṬHĀ – consciousness abides in its own nature, |
| completing the promise of YS 1.3. |
+-----+
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 21/24: Isolation - the four negations, images and contrasts

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 21/24: Isolation – the four negations, images and contrasts

FOUR NEGATIONS (UPSC tests this term almost entirely through contrasts)

- NOT union with God in the devotional sense
- NOT identity with Brahman in the Advaita sense
- NOT annihilation of consciousness
- NOT mere painlessness abstracted from the self's own luminosity
(and NOT destruction of mind as a substance – its binding vṛttis cease)

THREE IMAGES

kṣetrika (FARMER) breaches the embankment; water flows by its own nature.
Discipline removes obstruction; it does not MAKE freedom.

DAGDHA-BĪJA destroyed kleśas keep their shape and cannot germinate.

POTTER'S WHEEL after the push stops the wheel turns until momentum is spent
=> the careful basis for jīvanmukti language.

CONTRAST GRID

YOGA KAIVALYA	ADVAITA MOKṢA
many puruṣas	one Brahman as ultimate reality
isolation of puruṣa from prakṛti	realisation of ātman-Brahman identity
no Brahman-doctrine; DISENTANGLEMENT	non-dual realisation; IDENTITY

YOGA KAIVALYA	NYĀYA APAVARGA
positive isolation and self-abidance	often described as cessation of pain and bondage
rooted in puruṣa-prakṛti discrimination	rooted in true knowledge of categories and self
citta resolves, puruṣa shines	self remains; liberation characterised negatively

! TRAP 21: the Lord assists but does NOT grant kaivalya. Liberation follows viveka-khyāti.
! TRAP 22: whether kaivalya is blissful self-abidance or austere aloneness is CONTESTED.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 22/24: The realist polemic of the isolation chapter

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 22/24: The realist polemic of the isolation chapter

PŪRVAPAKṢA (vijñānavāda / yogācāra): what is taken as an external object is explicable as cognition-only; the object need not be admitted as independently real.

SIDDHĀNTA (Kaivalya-pāda realism), in four moves:

- 1 OBJECT-INDEPENDENCE an object is not EKACITTA-TANTRA (dependent on a single mind); otherwise it would vanish when that mind ceased to cognise it
- 2 THE MIND'S KNOWNNESS citta is NA TAT SVĀBHĀSAM (not self-illuminating) because it is itself DṚŚYA (seen) for puruṣa; mind-only struggles to terminate the regress of cognitions cognising cognitions
- 3 NO SIMULTANEOUS SELF-COGNITION the mind cannot apprehend itself and its object in one act, as though it were both lamp and illuminated object
- 4 UPARĀGA (colouring) an object is known when citta is UPARAKTA by it; known-versus-unknown depends on citta's colouring => object is not identical with the cognition

THREE-TERM REALISM: viśaya (object) · citta-vṛtti (modification) · puruṣa (witness)

COUNTER -> shared karmic traces explain intersubjective appearance without external objects

REJOINER-> a common object plus many cittas explains shared appearance better

RESIDUE !-> Yoga must still say HOW an external object colours an insentient citta

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 23/24: Inter-school comparison, criticisms and graded verdict

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COMPARISON AXES: self · God · causation · liberation · pramāṇa count

- vs SĀMĀNYA same ontology; nirīśvara there, seśvara here; explanatory metaphysics there, practical psychology and samādhi here
- vs NYĀYA-VAIŚEṢIKA broad citta vs atomic manas + self-substance; meditative Lord vs creator; kaivalya vs apavarga; 3 pramāṇas vs 4
- vs ADVAITA many puruṣas + real prakṛti vs non-dual Brahman; isolation vs identity-realisation
- vs BUDDHISM enduring puruṣa vs nairātmyavāda; discrimination-aimed meditation vs impermanence-aimed insight; kaivalya vs nirvāṇa

EIGHT CRITICISMS -> REPLIES

- inactive puruṣa bound? -> misidentification through reflection, not alteration
- insentient citta cognising? -> it becomes luminous by reflecting puruṣa
- restrain TRUE cognition? -> form binds, not falsity; akliṣṭa is a ladder
- asamprajñāta = sleep? -> genesis and value differ; nidrā is itself a vṛtti
- why add a Lord? -> practical efficacy, not metaphysical necessity
- is the Lord redundant? -> non-final rather than redundant
- is kaivalya merely negative? -> svarūpa-pratiṣṭhā is its positive side
- is dhyāna enough? -> no; without yama-niyama, power coexists with affliction

GRADED VERDICT

- STRONG rigorous phenomenology of mental process · integration of psychology, ethics and metaphysics · an operational path · genuine metaphysical commitment shown by the realist arguments
- WEAK the puruṣa-prakṛti interaction problem · the Lord's limited explanatory role · the contestable value of contentless pure consciousness
- CONTESTED status of ānanda and asmitā in the taxonomy · character of kaivalya · unity and layering of the sūtra tradition

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 24/24: PYQ ownership, the answer route and the qualified conclusion

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PYQ OWNERSHIP AND ANSWER ROUTE (7 primary-owned parts, 2019-2025; no 2018 owner)

- 2019 Q7(b) 15 .. citta-levels of scientist / devotee / yogin -> PANEL 5
- 2020 Q5(b) 10 .. samprajñāta vs asamprajñāta -> PANELS 15, 16
- 2021 Q6(a) 20 .. nature of kleśas; removal leads to kaivalya -> PANELS 10-12, 20
- 2022 Q5(c) 10 .. nature and stages of samādhi; role of Īśvara -> PANELS 15-19
- 2023 Q7(c) 15 .. citta and its modifications; why cessation -> PANELS 3, 6, 7
- 2024 Q7(b) 15 .. reflection, misidentification, appraisal -> PANELS 4, 9, 22-24
- 2025 Q7(b) 15 .. nature of God and its role in kaivalya -> PANELS 19-21
- ROUTED 2018 Q6(a) 20 [Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika primary] .. Nyāya vs Yoga proofs of God -> PANELS 19, 22-24

ANSWER SPINE: define in Pātañjala terms -> classify without conflating schemes -> give the causal pathway -> use one accurate analogy -> distinguish from Sāṃkhya, Nyāya, Buddhism or Advaita as demanded -> state objection, reply and residual pressure -> add the textual / commentarial caution -> conclude by relating discipline to discernment.

QUALIFIED CONCLUSION: Yoga turns Sāṃkhya's dualism into a disciplined psychology of liberation in which ethics, attention, absorption and insight progressively dismantle the causal machinery of bondage. Its account of citta and saṃskāra explains why intellectual assent alone cannot liberate. Yet reflected consciousness, the relation among the highest absorptions and the necessity of the Lord remain debated. Kaivalya therefore rests not on trance but on irreversible discrimination between the witness and every transformation of nature.